

Phil 240 The Philosophy of Politics: Part 1

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 240 • Dr. Stephen R. C. Hicks

Contents

Lecture 1. Revolutionary Danger

Lecture 2. Hegel and the State

Lecture 3. Engels and Marx

Lecture 4. Mill on Liberty

Lecture 5. Pragmatic Democracy

Lecture 6. Fascism and Force

Lecture 7. A Darker Turn

Lecture 1: Revolutionary Danger

At a glance — Hicks opens Part 1 in 1793 France with revolutionary danger.

- 1.1 Welcome to The Philosophy of Politics. Let's go to 1793 in France. The lecture title for this particular course is the Revolutionary Danger. By the time we get to 1793 in France, Europe, more broadly speaking, we are well into the modern world. It is a revolutionary couple of centuries, perhaps the most revolutionary centuries ever in human history. What we recognize as modern science and the scientific revolution have come into existence. We're doing religion differently as a result of the Reformation and the Counter-Reformation. The Renaissance has revolutionized modern art.
- 1.2 Columbus and the various explorers, Portuguese, Spanish, and Columbus, Italian, and others, the Dutch joining, the British joining, have revolutionized our understanding of how big and diverse the world is. Trade has been revolutionized. And politics also is in a revolutionary era. Centuries, millennia, tens of thousands of years of human experience has been dominated by tribalisms, nomadic tribes all over the world, the development of some empires after the agricultural and metallurgical revolution, sometimes rigidified into hierarchical, nonetheless sophisticated structures. But in the modern world, much of that is going away.
- 1.3 It is a revolutionary era. In politics, which we are going to be focusing on, we have seen England and its Glorious Revolution, where the feudal monarch was disempowered, and we have a parliamentary democracy that comes into existence. In America, there has been its revolution fought in the case of those ideals and other Enlightenment ideals. Again, a brand new country to be formed on a new set of political principles.
- 1.4 And now, by the time we get to the 1780s, 1790s, it is France's turn to engage in a revolution. By the time, though, we get to 1793, it is bad times. The revolution is going horribly. It is a cataclysm, and it is one of the great examples of how not to do politics and cultural change in the modern world. So revolutionary France comes into the modern world, but it is bloody, it is nasty, it is awful in many respects.
- 1.5 The big symbol by the time we get to 1793 of the danger is the guillotine, a modern instrument of execution, but the guillotine becomes very busy in 1793. Thousands and thousands of people are executed, in many cases summarily, without due process, unjustly in various ways. And of course, it's not only the guillotine, but people are being killed for a variety of means. Riots in the street, summary executions, all of the traditional methods, and various people's lives are destroyed.
- 1.6 What has happened to cause the French Revolution to go so bad? It is a modern revolution, but it's not a successful one, as we might contrast to the earlier British Revolution and the American Revolution. The big symbolic events also occurring in 1793 are when King Louis XVI is executed. It's not simply in this case that we say, "We don't want the king anymore. We're going to send you into exile." It's not that we are

going to modify our political system away from feudalism to, say, having a constitutional monarchy. But the real power lies with the people, with the parliament and so forth.

- 1.7 Instead, we are going to signal a radical break with everything in the past, and we're going to cut this man's head off. And that's not just killing a single individual, that is killing an entire political system. A few months later, his queen, Marie-Antoinette, is also executed. We kill the king, we kill the queen. And of course, many of the executions involved aristocrats, members of the clergy, and other executions all around the country, not only members of those, but members of all walks of society. Lots and lots of killing.
- 1.8 Hunger, widespread. The economy is disrupted. The French economy had been having troubles for some decades. That's partly why the revolution came into existence in the first case. But what is now dominating French society and French politics is everything bad: hunger, betrayal, torture in the modern world, widespread executions. The nation plunges into a brutal civil war in which tens of thousands and even hundreds of thousands of people end up being killed.
- 1.9 Then, of course, many of the countries around France and Europe, most of whom still have kings and queens with various degrees of power, horrified by what's going on in France, and various wars internationally start. Everything that can go wrong is going wrong in France as a result of this modern revolution.
- 1.10 What can we learn from this? Well, one question that is to ask, well, why did the French Revolution happen in the first place? What are the causal forces? Can we identify what led them to not simply a series of reforms and improvements, but rather an attempt to change things through revolutionary means? What are those factors so we can learn the lessons of history here? But also, aside from this long list of terrible things that are happening right now in France, the argument can be made that it gets even worse, because out of all of this, out of the French Revolution, by the time it starts to abate to some extent, there is a power vacuum.
- 1.11 The country is poor, it is exhausted, and out of that arises Napoleon Bonaparte, who in a few short years is going to successfully prosecute a number of wars, expand the territory of France. But nonetheless, tens of thousands of more people are going to be killed as a result of his ambitions, his centralization of power. And by the time he has become extraordinarily successful, he has himself coronated as Emperor by 1804.
- 1.12 The revolution began in 1789. Fifteen years later, we have gone from what seemed like the old regime, the Ancien Régime, as we would put it in the French, feudalism, hierarchy with the majesty of the King, anointed by God, in charge of everything. But France has aspired to become a modern, revolutionary nation. But what has it achieved 15 years later is Napoleon, who not only in power, in fact, if not in name, is just another monarch with absolute power and putting on the same vestiges.

- 1.13** It seems like the old regime is dead. It seems like France is trying to become a modern nation, but has it succeeded in doing so? Have the costs been worse than the benefits? What are the lessons to be learned? Now, this is a course in the philosophy of politics, and I want us to work up to that course descriptor. We can start with a particular event. This was a revolution. It's important, significant. What caused this revolution?
- 1.14** If we can figure that out, are there more general lessons? About why some countries evolve, why some countries stay static, why some nonetheless plunge into revolutions where so many things are changing at once? Are there general lessons about what causes revolutions? This is in the modern world. There have been revolutions in ancient history all over the world. Are there distinctive features about modernity, that it's appealing to, say, ideological principles of liberty and equality and trying to bring about a politics that is going to instantiate those, in contrast to revolutions in other times in other parts of the world that are not driven by ideological labels such as that?
- 1.15** Why this takes us into the territory of philosophy? I'm a philosophy professor by training and by profession. But what I want to stress in this course is the tight connection between politics and philosophy. In many cases, political events occur, and we draw more general philosophical lessons about the nature of human knowledge, about what human nature is, about what our core values are going to be, the place of religion and science in informing our science, or rather, our approaches to politics.
- 1.16** In many cases, what we have is philosophers reflecting on political events. But in many cases, what we find is that what is going on politically is driven by philosophical concerns. We often have debates about particular policy. Should we do this or should we do this in this particular case and have this particular law in place? But in many cases, the debates that we're having over particular policies are not really about those policies, that what we have is people with very different value systems, very different understandings of the place of religion in life, what counts as human knowledge and what we really know, what it is to be a human being, what is the meaning of life?
- 1.17** All of that is operating, sometimes in the background, sometimes explicitly, in the modern world, as we are debating particular political policymakers. This course will be a series of case examples trying to illustrate that more general point about the tight connections between philosophy and politics.
- 1.18** Now, starting with this French Revolution, though, we will use this as our first big example. Starts in 1789. We could make an argument that the important lead-ups to the revolution were occurring in 1788, 1787 or so. But nonetheless, everyone is clear, by 1789, revolution has struck France. What we're going to do also, aside from focusing only on the history, is focus on the important philosophers who are reflecting on this lesson. In this lecture, we're going to focus on Edmund Burke, who has the most influential interpretation of the French Revolution. What are the lessons to be learned from the French Revolution?

- 1.19** But also, Edmund Burke is a founder of a modern approach to political philosophy. He is a conservative, but he is a modern conservative, and he is a philosophical modern conservative. In his reflections on the lessons of the French Revolution, we get not only a better understanding of the history and the lessons of the history, but an articulation of one of the new political ideologies that are going to be dominant and influential on down to contemporary times.
- 1.20** Now, Edmund Burke is a conservative as described, but he is a conservative who is respected not only among his fellow conservatives, but unusually for political figures, by people who disagree with his politics. For example, the liberals in contemporary, at this time, 1780s, 1790s British political system respect Edmund Burke. In many respects, his conservatism has some liberal elements to it. He's not an old, reactionary, hidebound conservative.
- 1.21** He recognizes, as most British do, that there should be constitutional limits to the power of the king, in contrast to older conservatives who would argue that the king should have unlimited power. Perhaps the king is the representative of God, and God has unlimited power, and so the king, as God's representative, you cannot put limitations on his power. Burke is modern. We need a king, but he's going to be limited in his power.
- 1.22** Unlike many conservatives who will argue that religion is important, and my particular religion is the correct religion, and it should be the only religion allowed and tolerated in the land, Burke is a religious man but wants to extend toleration to other religions. And that toleration theme, again, a very modern theme that is going to be incorporated into Burke's more modern conservative.
- 1.23** Burke is going to be highly critical of the French Revolution. But that doesn't mean that he is opposed to revolution in all cases, and he was one of the supporters of the American fight for its own independence. So it's not the case that, as a conservative, the British way of doing things, or we're going to impose the British way of doing things on all countries around the world, Burke is recognizing some countries have the right to go their own way. And in the American case, he thought justice was on the side of the Americans more than on the side of the British. And so, again, a more nuanced position.
- 1.24** Instead of simply apologizing or trying to protect those who have the current power and turning a blind eye to corruptions and excesses that go on in the political regime, Burke had a reputation for being an advocate of uncorrupt politics to the extent that he was willing to blow the whistle to prosecute any politician who was engaging in things that were clearly unfair, illegal, and so on. Not an apologist for those in power, but rather principles of justice and fairness. There was a famous case involving the Governor General of India who had been engaging in corruption.

- 1.25** What is the French Revolution? What can we learn from it? Then what are Burke's, especially, conclusions with respect to the French Revolution? Now, let's rehearse a little bit the story of the French Revolution. Again, there's a long story. You can go as far back in French history as you want, but France was a feudal monarchy. We had the noble family at the top, and then the rest of the nation was divided into three classes. And in the French political vocabulary, they were called estates.
- 1.26** So you had the king, you had the clergy, and there were perhaps 100,000 members of the clergy, very powerful Catholic Church institution in France. They were the first estate, the first class, as a component overall of French society. Then you had the nobles or the aristocrats. They were the second estate. And there's maybe 500,000 or so nobles scattered. Some of them are great, powerful nobles, some of them are relatively minor nobles, but they comprise the second estate.
- 1.27** Then France, at this time, has probably 25 million people or so. Everybody else is in the third estate. These are the commoners, and there are various subdivisions of the commoners and so forth. But you have over 24, perhaps close to 25 million other people who comprise the third estate. And power is distributed hierarchically. In principle, the king has the most power and is at the top. The aristocrats have a significant second amount of power. There's a certain amount of jockeying back and forth between the church and the aristocrats, but the church also has a significant amount of power.
- 1.28** And then there are various feudal privileges and powers that the commoners will have in various ways. The short-form version of saying what is going on in the 1600s and the 1700s is that there's a power struggle between the king and the aristocrats. They are dominating, and the king is winning, or the monarchy is winning. There's Louis XIII, Louis XIV, Louis XV, and by the time we get to 1780s, Louis XVI. It's a whole series of King Louises, and the common name illustrates a common theme, a continuity of the monarchy and its power.
- 1.29** The king wants more power for himself. Of course, the aristocrats want to have more power for them, more wealth, more prestige, more honor, more dignity. But by and large, the kings are winning, and they are concentrating and centralizing their power, and the aristocrats are becoming less and less powerful. But France starts to run into troubles, intellectual troubles, economic troubles, all kinds of social unrest as we get into the 1700s. And by the time we get to Louis XVI, we have a weaker monarch.
- 1.30** In some sense, he's a nice guy. He's influenced by Enlightenment ideals. He's open to reforms and so forth. But he is not a powerhouse monarch in the vein of his grandfathers and great-grandfathers and so forth. And the aristocrats spot an opportunity. We have a chance here to get back for ourselves some of the power that we have lost over the course of the last few centuries. So they succeed in this first phase of doing the various kinds of political jockeying and maneuverings and outright threats to call the Estates General.

- 1.31** And what the Estates General is, it's a peculiar institution in France where all of the classes of France have representatives and they meet in a national assembly to discuss the state of the country and to discuss reforms. And what this then means is that the aristocrats will have their delegates from the second estate. The clergy will have their delegates from the first estate. The commoners will have their delegates from the third estate. We will get together and we will discuss things.
- 1.32** And why this is a big deal in 1789 is that, while this is a time-honoured political institution in France, it had not happened for almost two centuries. Because when Estates General happen, that means the king is going to lose power. And the kings had been powerful, and every time they had been able to avoid calling Estates General and to continue basically doing what they wanted. So just the fact that we're going to get everybody together with their representatives and talk about the future of France is a victory for the aristocrats.
- 1.33** And they know that they're going to be able to get some power and rights and privileges away from the king, to get to what they think of as their rightful place. But very quickly, what happens is that the aristocrats, as a class, stop dominating the Estates General, and it stops being primarily different political classes, feudal classes, deciding who's going to have various powers, and it becomes an ideological convention. Here I've introduced the concept of liberals. Liberals start to dominate. This is important because France is perhaps at this point the leading nation of the Enlightenment.
- 1.34** Part of the revolutionary transformation of the modern world has been the rise of a series of intellectuals who think we can, by applying the new science, by applying reason, by respecting individuals' right to run their religious lives as they want, to try to liberalize the economy, perhaps even to consider equal rights and liberties for women, to start thinking of slavery for the first time in human history as an affront to human morality, that the slaves should be free, and we need to liberalize, so to speak, all of the phrase, the slaves rather, and give them equal rights.
- 1.35** All of these ideals of the Enlightenment had been articulated, debated vigorously over the course of the 1700s, and a significant number of intellectuals and otherwise thoughtful reading people had come to believe in the liberal ideals of the Enlightenment. Thinkers like John Locke, whom we've talked about in other courses here at the Academy, Voltaire, whom we've also had lectures on, are the giant names, and there's a series of others.
- 1.36** What is interesting is that the liberals are not associated primarily with any one class. There are many of the aristocrats who are liberal in their thinking. They agree with those ideals. There are many members of the clergy who are liberal in their thinking. And of course, many of the commoners, particularly those who are literate, lawyers, and other members of various professions were liberal and Enlightenment people in

their thinking. So it stops being about classes and starts to become about principles, ideological principles.

- 1.37 And the great slogan of the French Revolution is three concepts: liberty, equality, and fraternity. We're not just going to jockey power around and redistribute power. We're going to try to remake France in the name of Enlightenment, liberal, political principles. It's at this point in 1789 then that France issues a declaration. The assembly puts forth a declaration called the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen.
- 1.38 There's an important connection here to the Marquis de Lafayette, who was a member of the nobility, but nonetheless a liberal ideologically. This is the Lafayette who had military training and experience, and some decades earlier, when America was fighting its War of Independence against the British, who had the greatest army in the world, and an initially ragtag army led by General George Washington of unprofessional soldiers, they had brought in from Europe experienced soldiers to help out.
- 1.39 And Lafayette was one of the ones inspired by the ideals of the American Revolution, that cause, who went to America and worked with General Washington to help successfully prosecute that War of Independence. That's over. It's successful. Lafayette comes back to France and is the person who writes the first draft of this Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen.
- 1.40 It's a very liberal document with respect for the right to liberty, obviously, rights to property, rights to freedom of conscience in various ways. It reads like a French variation on the Declaration of Independence and with some of the American constitutional principles as well. Interestingly, in that same time, we find other declarations starts to come out as a sign of the time, the Enlightenment liberalism.
- 1.41 We should say that these rights, modern rights, and we're going to change the world, apply not only to men, but they also apply to women. And so, arguably, the very first women's rights or feminist manifesto is written in France by a French woman published in 1791, again inspired by the American liberal revolution and the French liberal revolution as well. And so, we see in De Gouges' manifesto, for example, the first principle is, "Women are born free and remain equal to men in rights."
- 1.42 Freedom and equality. It doesn't matter what class you are in. It doesn't matter what your sex or gender is. You're a human being, and all human beings have these foundational rights. A proper system, modern system, is going to revolutionize itself or perhaps evolve in this direction because this is the proper direction. Then you see further down, rights to liberty, property, security, and resistance to oppression. We will not be oppressed by higher authority.
- 1.43 So all of this is going on. The aristocratic phase ends quickly, is now dominated by the liberals for a couple of years. But then there are other economic, political, religious, and ideological factions at work in French culture, particularly in French intellectual culture.

And then by the time we get to 1793, four years into the Revolution, a new faction comes to dominate.

- 1.44 They are called the Jacobins. They are most noted for the increase in violence, the increase in executions, the increase in nastiness, and the spawning of the civil war in France and many of the international wars as well. So there's then a shift, and the shift is important because the individuals who come to the fore at this point, who seize control of the direction the revolution is changing, they are not aristocrats, they are not liberals. And Jacobin is now a shorthand tag for a particular kind of political ideology.
- 1.45 The most famous names are Robespierre, Maximilian Robespierre, first among equals, but also Saint-Just, Danton, Marat, and several others. They are most associated with then what we call the Reign of Terror. That starts to occur in increasing severity, 1793-1794, until finally France exhausts itself. The worst of the Jacobins, Robespierre and others, are subject to arrest. Some of them are assassinated. The Reign of Terror comes to an end. France is exhausted, and out of that power vacuum is going to then very soon arise Napoleon, and France is going to go off in another direction.
- 1.46 But at this point, I now want to turn to Edmund Burke, with all of that history in the back of our minds. And Burke, very early in the French Revolution, publishes a series of reflections written in the form of a letter to someone who'd asked for his opinion on what's going on in this revolution in France. And he wrote up his thoughts, which turn into a historical document, but as well a political manifestation and a statement of all of his principles and why.
- 1.47 This is 1790. This is still early in the revolution. He is suspicious and worried about the direction the French Revolution is occurring, and he is predicting that things are only going to get worse. It's one of those documents that seems prescient and able to predict things that most other people would not have predicted are going to happen. OK, so let's turn to Edmund Burke's 1790, one of the great political analysts of the modern world, with his reflections on the Revolution in France.
- 1.48 What I want to do is read what I take to be some of the most important passages and then give some gloss on those. In many cases, the language is a little bit archaic. This is a British Englishman writing over two centuries ago with some archaism, so we'll do some translations as well. But the main themes should emerge.
- 1.49 "Dear Sir"—written in the form of a letter—"I do most heartily wish that France may be animated by a spirit of rational liberty." Now, those two concepts, important in the Enlightenment. We are free individuals. Yes, we are rational beings. We have become enlightened. We don't simply believe superstition and dogmas and traditions that have come down as irrational beings might have done in century past.
- 1.50 "But it is my misfortune to entertain great doubts about what's going on in France. I flatter myself that I love a manly, moral, regulated liberty as well as anyone, but I cannot stand forward to give praise or blame to anything which relates to human

actions and human concerns on a simple view of the subject as it stands stripped of every relation in all the nakedness and solitude of metaphysical abstraction."

- 1.51** All right, now there's a complicated sentence, but the bad thing is metaphysical abstraction that we cannot, as apparently his letter-writer has done say, here's a number of principles that the French say that they are standing for, abstract metaphysical principles about the nature of the universe, about human nature, and what we need to do simply is remake human society by applying those principles. And if the old society has not been following those principles, then we throw out the way the old society has been done and put it in place, according to this new ideological set of doctrines. Burke is immediately suggesting, "I am going to be opposed to that point."
- 1.52** "I should therefore suspend my congratulations on the new liberty of France"—it's too soon—"until I was informed how it had been combined with government, with public force, the discipline and obedience of armies, with the collection of an effective and well-distributed revenue, with morality and religion, with the solidity of property, with peace and order, with civil and social manners." That's a long list of things he needs to know first before he's going to sign on to what the French Revolution is apparently all about.
- 1.53** Just saying, liberty, equality, and then just do whatever we need to to make that happen, Burke's saying, no, not so fast. A large number of other things we need to know first. And the place of liberty and equality is not going to be first, as he goes on to say. "Without them," that is, all of the things that I've just listed, "liberty is not a benefit while it lasts and is not likely to continue long." So the point here is that liberty is not necessarily first.
- 1.54** Before we start talking about liberty first, we have to get government right. We have to get the use of public force right. We have to get the army right. We have to have the economic system, well-distributed revenue, correct. We have to have the right moral system. We have to have religion in place, and so on and so forth. Get all of those sorted out, then we can start talking about liberty, a well-regulated liberty. So liberty is further down the list. And already we have been a big philosophical distinction between the liberals who want to make liberty first and all of these other things follow from liberty versus Burke who wants to reverse the order.
- 1.55** "The French Revolution is the most astonishing thing that has happened hitherto in the world." Interesting thing for a British thinker to say after the American Revolution, after England's own Glorious Revolution. If you think historically, the Renaissance, you think the Roman Empire, go all the way back. This is the most astonishing thing that has ever happened in the world. A very big claim. Perhaps some rhetoric here about the importance of this document to draw attention to it.
- 1.56** But this is chaos, and it is chaos happening in the modern world in a powerful nation like France. This is going to be one of the great, great lessons. By contrast, then, we will

look at what did happen in Britain. How did Britain come into the modern world? "You will observe that from Magna Charta to the Declaration of Right, it has been the uniform policy of our constitution to claim and assert our liberties as an entailed inheritance derived to us from our forefathers and to be transmitted to our posterity."

- 1.57** So Magna Charta, 1200s in England. Two, the Declaration of Right in the late 1600s, 1688. That's over four centuries that Britain evolved away from its feudal regime with concentrated power, say, in the king, into being a modern democratic republic with a mostly unwritten constitution and, by and large, a free, successful, prosperous nation. We did it slowly over the course of many centuries. Perhaps the contrast then is going to be that the French are trying to do everything very quickly in one generation. Evolution is the right way to go, instead of revolution.
- 1.58** Other language to unpack here. "We, British, our policy of our constitution is to claim and assert our liberties," we have liberties, and a lot of them, "but as an entailed inheritance." I'm going to pause there. Where do we get our liberties from? Why should human beings have liberty? Now, that, of course, is a deep question in politics. And notice what he is saying. "It is an inheritance from our"—the language here is—"forefathers." So previous British contrived, developed, these liberties and passed them on to us. So we have inherited them from previous British people.
- 1.59** Now, what's important to pay attention to here is that this is in the context of huge debates about the nature of rights in the modern world. And what Burke is not saying is that we get our rights from God. He's well aware that there is a view, political philosophy, that says what we have as human beings comes from God, and all of the proper moral and political principles come from God. We have supernaturally or divinely granted rights to liberty. And Burke is implicitly not saying that.
- 1.60** He's also not saying that our rights are natural, that there's something natural about what it is to be a human being, that we're part of the natural world, and we have a certain biological and mental constitution, and what it is to be a human being by nature is to be a free agent. And so what we need to do politically is respect the natural rights that human beings have. So they don't come from God. They don't come from nature. They come from our forefathers. They are socially passed on from us from previous generations.
- 1.61** They are an inheritance, and they are an entailed inheritance, which means we have an obligation and where they are going to go next, to the next generation, is previously specified, an important language here. "Our political system is a condition of unchangeable constancy." This language, of unchanging constancy, the principles that animate our constitution, are not supposed to be subject to change and revolution. There is something more firm and unchanging that needs to be respected. So it's not the case that we can just do something completely different, start all over and so forth.

- 1.62 What we should be doing, this last line of this paragraph here, "We are always acting as if in the presence of canonized forefathers; the spirit of freedom, leading itself to misrule and excess, is tempered with an awful gravity." So yes, we believe in freedom as moderns, but it's not just freedom to just do whatever we want. That is not a fundamental that we can fill in freedom however we decide as individuals or as a contemporary society.
- 1.63 Instead, whatever we take our freedoms to be, we should always be remembering our forefathers. It's like your mom or your dad is looking over your shoulder as you are freely deciding what you are going to do, and your grandfather and your grandmothers, and so on. We know that that is then a kind of external regulation on you, within which you are going to exercise your freedom.
- 1.64 Then this adjective, canonized, which is a religious nod, that these are not merely human beings, so to speak, but rather they are human beings who have a kind of spiritual morality justification behind them, and that also needs to be attended to. "All of your sophisters cannot produce anything better adapted to preserve a manly freedom than the course which we have pursued," that is to say, the sophisters, "sofia", the ancient Greek word for wisdom, philosophers, or lovers of wisdom.
- 1.65 So all of the philosophers of the Enlightenment, who have come up with these new, modern, abstract principles, and we're going to remake society—there is zero chance that they, unmoored from those traditions, are going to be able to do anything better than what has been entailed to us from generations of slow evolution over the course of centuries.
- 1.66 "You possessed, in some parts, the walls and, in all, the foundations of a noble and venerable castle." We have a building metaphor. How should we understand society and the proper ordering of a society? We imagine a castle, and there are the foundations of a castle, and then it rises in splendor to various turrets and great halls and various infrastructure systems and so forth. Imagine society then as a castle.
- 1.67 Now, of course, some castles go into disrepair, and they need to be reformed, they need to be renovated, they need to be fixed. But look at the foundations. Always respect the foundations of the castle. And if you think that you can take your castle and just totally devastate it and rebuild, overnight or in the next generation, a brand new modern castle, whatever your architectural fantasies are, that is an illusion.
- 1.68 "You might have repaired those walls. You might have built on those old foundations." Take the traditions of your society, the fundamental ones, and don't touch those. Rebuild upon them and be careful of that. "You began ill," you now being the moderns, particularly the advocates of the French Revolution, "because you began by despising everything that belonged to you. Respecting your forefathers, you would have been taught to respect yourselves. But instead showing that freedom is not only reconcilable, but auxiliary to law."

- 1.69 Then again, we have this proper ordering. First we have the law, then we have freedom within the confines of law. We don't start by some idea of freedom, and then we're going to devise the laws that are going to do so. The law comes down to us by tradition. That will give us then not only proper liberty, but also "the true moral equality of mankind." There's now the word equality, that other big modern world, not the monstrous fiction that the new moderns are trying to foist upon us.
- 1.70 We are all equal under the law that has come down to us by tradition. It's not that we are all equal to do whatever it is that we feel like as individuals. It's a different kind of equality. Instead, what we have in the Enlightenment is all these "extravagant and presumptuous speculations." Now, more specifically, what are these foundations that are rooted in tradition? "All other nations have begun the fabric of a new government or the reformation of an old by establishing some rights or other of religion."
- 1.71 What have the successful nations done? All of them, they have founded themselves on religion. Religion is a fundamental. In the modern world, the Enlightened world, we're starting to see a rise of agnosticism and even atheisms. Is there really a God? How do we know that there is a God? There are various arguments for and against the existence of God. Many of the leading intellectuals are saying the arguments for the existence of God don't work.
- 1.72 The idea that we're just going to think that some people way back in time, many of whom didn't know anything about science, were often not particularly literate, that God spoke to them and gave them some absolute truths, how can we believe that in the modern world? So maybe religion is a series of myths. It's all made up. And as modern people, we're going to get religion not only out of politics, but maybe get religion out of social life. And Burke is saying, no, that is a mistake.
- 1.73 Now, you'll see here that he says, "Some rights or other of religion." Just, you need some religion, it seems, if you're going to be a modern conservative as Burke advocates. He's not saying that "my religion is the right religion." Not necessarily the Christian religion, there are lots of other religions that might do the job, but you need some religion or other at the foundation. The moderns, and particularly the French, are being very disrespectful of traditional religion.
- 1.74 They are, in many cases, taking priests and monks and nuns and so forth and just killing them whenever they find them. That's part of the chaos of the revolution in the streets. They're closing down the convents and the monasteries; they're confiscating church property. They are taking away the religious foundation that is traditional to France. Huge mistake.
- 1.75 "All other people have laid the foundations of civil freedom in severer manners, and a system of a more austere and masculine morality." So not only religion, but also morality is prior to liberty and so-called equality. We have to have the right moral code. It's interesting that he says it needs to be severe, a severe moral code. And a masculine

moral code, not a feminine moral code. Different moral codes. Some are more paternal, some are more maternal. Strict, masculine morality and religion. All other countries have them. The French are playing fast and loose with this anything goes kind of liberty, everybody's idea.

- 1.76 "France, when she let loose the reins of regal authority, doubled the license of ferocious dissoluteness in manners." OK, big language here, but what did France do? They are saying, the king and the queen and the priests and the monks and the entire religious establishment, we are disrespectful of them. This is only 1790. We haven't executed them, but we know that that is coming on down the road.
- 1.77 "France has taught kings to tremble at what will hereafter be called the delusive plausibilities of moral politicians." So we have kings and we have politicians. Who should be top? Is it the case that the politicians defer and tremble in the presence of the great king? Or should the king be trembling in the place and worried about what the politicians want for him? And what we have in the modern world is a reversal of that order. The king is in some sense lower, and that is inappropriate.
- 1.78 OK. Then what we have is a list of all of the things that are already happening earlier in the French Revolution. "Laws overturned, tribunals," that is to say, justice tribunals, "subverted, industry without vigor, commerce expiring, people impoverished, a church pillaged, a state unrelieved." It's already a disaster situation. Worse. This is an interesting suggestion here about the people we are now giving political power to in the modern world.
- 1.79 Burke goes on to say, let's take "the composition the National Assembly." We bring all of the different estates and the representatives together, and we now have hundreds and hundreds of people, and they are now coming up with a new constitution, declaring new rights for human beings, and enacting new laws, and so forth. And Burke says, he goes through the list of everybody in this. "Any practical experience in the state, not one man was to be found."
- 1.80 Instead, we had sent a whole bunch representatives, and there were none who had practical experience in government. No professional politicians. Instead, they were regular aristocrats, regular people of the clergy, regular commoners. The idea is, this modern idea, everybody is going to have a voice in government, in making our new constitution, but the French are going at it by not having anybody with any actual practical experience in government. "The best were only men of theory."
- 1.81 So lots of ideas, lots of enlightened principles, lots of abstract speculations, lots of philosophers and want-to-be philosophers, but no actual professional politicians. It's going to be a disaster. And it gets worse. "Judge, sir, of my surprise, when I found that a very great proportion of the assembly was composed of practitioners in the law." Lawyers. We got lots and lots of lawyers now who are in this. And this is just going to

be a disaster. It's not only that they are not professional politicians, but they are coming from predominantly one sector of society, the lawyers.

- 1.82** What kind of people are lawyers? Well, fill in your worst stereotypes about the way lawyers think and behave and act and argue. Then not only that, Burke goes on to say the vast majority of them are coming from the commons. They're coming from all of these remote areas in France. They're coming from small towns and smaller jurisdictions, not from any great center of international affairs and national affairs like Paris. "The general composition was of obscure provincial advocates, stewards of petty local jurisdictions, country attorneys, notaries, etc."
- 1.83** From the very first, Burke goes on to argue, "I read the list, I saw distinctly and very nearly as it happened, all that was to follow." Just from knowing the character and the types of people who are now in the assembly, disaster necessarily is going to happen. This is not serious politics. A more explicit remark in a later section here. "Government is not made in virtue of natural rights."
- 1.84** So he is explicitly, as a now modern conservative, going to eschew any traditional conservatism that says, yes, human beings have rights endowed by God. God made human nature, and so we find them in human nature, but they ultimately come from God. But also, the theory more predominant among liberals who want to say, whether they came from God or not, human beings by nature have certain rights and that it is the job of government to respect what those rights are. Burke denying that.
- 1.85** Government is not based on natural rights. That's not where we start. "Government is a contrivance of human wisdom to provide for human wants." That is to say, we make it up, we contrive it. It's an invention. It's not natural. This is a point worth registering for later discovery. The job of the government is to provide for human wants, what humans want, what they need, what they lack. That is the job of government to supply them. And a certain amount of liberty then is going to be provided or granted to the people, but also a certain amount of control and regulation.
- 1.86** "Men have a right that these wants should be provided for by this wisdom." That is to say, the wise men in power will decide what are genuine human wants, and they will provide those. "Among these wants is to be reckoned the want out of civil society of a sufficient restraint upon their passions." Human beings are rational beings, but we are also passionate beings. The vast majority of people are not particularly good at exercising either their rationality at a high degree of level or restraining their passions.
- 1.87** Instead, they believe all sorts of things and they indulge their feelings, their desires, their passions, particularly when they think that they can get away with it. What people need is people wiser than themselves, but also then people who are able to restrain the inappropriate exercise of those passions. If you just say to people, "You've got freedom, do what you want with it," most people do not have the wisdom or the regulation of

their passions to be able to exercise that liberty well. That has to be supplied by government on them.

- 1.88** "This can only be done by a power out of themselves." This is italicized, a power outside of themselves. We have a philosophical view about human nature. How optimistic or pessimistic are we about human beings if we think we give them freedom to run their own lives as they see fit? One view is quite optimistic. Burke is tending toward the pessimistic view. People do not have what it takes to regulate themselves. They do not have the self-responsibility power to use their minds to regulate their passions, to govern their actions appropriately in their lives. We need a power outside of themselves to regulate them. Within that confines, they will be granted some freedoms. This is a deep point.
- 1.89** "The science of constructing a commonwealth, of renovating it or reforming it, is like every other experimental science, not to be taught a priori. Nor is it a short experience that can instruct us." Another big issue in political philosophy is where do we get our political principles from? We might say we read scripture and we derive them from the scripture, and we apply them to our particular circumstances.
- 1.90** We might say that we turn to wise philosophers who can come up with very general abstract principles like mathematicians can, and then we can apply those principles the way, you say, in applied engineering, we'll take those principles and apply them to constructing bridges and buildings and various other sorts of things.
- 1.91** Burke is saying, neither of those; this is a point about human knowledge or human epistemology. We learn by experience, lots of practical experience, and then we cautiously generalize to more general principles. "The science of government being, therefore, so practical in itself and intended for such practical purposes, a matter which requires experience and even more experience than any person can gain in his whole life." Pausing there.
- 1.92** So, fine, we say, I need to become someone who has practical experience in governing. Maybe I run for student government and I get some experience. I run for local government, then for state government, then for national government. I read a lot of history and all of the experience that is captured there. Then I'm in a position to be a wise legislator. And Burke is saying that's not enough. No matter how smart and studious you are, it is so complicated that no one individual can do this.
- 1.93** We require the wisdom of generations, all of that practical experience and experimenting and cautiously generated principles that come down to us in tradition. And so the proper policy is always going to be to be deferring to tradition of all of those wise individuals and their experience that has gone before you. The idea that you, by the time you're a smart 30-year-old, you've got it all figured out and you should be given power over society to remake things in according to your— that is just completely delusional from this perspective.

- 1.94 Now, another important philosophical point I want to highlight here. "The pretended rights of these theorists are all extremes, and in proportion as they are metaphysically true, they are morally and politically false. The rights of men are in a sort of middle, incapable of definition, but not impossible to be discerned." What is the nature of these wise principles that have come down to us? Are they absolute, inflexible truths? Are they rough-and-ready rules of thumb that we modify depending on the circumstances?
- 1.95 One of our big debates, of course, in politics is whether we think principles should be absolute and they should be followed absolutely, or whether there's just too many exceptions, that really our principles are just rules of thumb and we can be flexible and adapt them to different circumstances and so forth. Burke is arguing it's somewhere in the middle, but we're not going to try to say that we can come up with exact definitions. So there needs to be some wiggle room for our politicians.
- 1.96 But he also says, and this is a very important line to keep, "All the pleasing illusions, which made power gentle and obedience liberal, which harmonized the different shades of life, which by a bland assimilation incorporated into politics the sentiments which beautify and so forth and so on, are to be dissolved by this new conquering empire of light and reason." I'm going to pause there, some more elevated language. But this empire of light and reason, he's talking about the Enlightenment. That suddenly we are enlightened, we are rational.
- 1.97 We can figure out science and engineering and mathematics and figure out what the universal and absolute rights of human beings are and all of the things that held human beings back, all of that superstition and ignorance and intolerance and so forth. We can remake society in the light of these new theories because we are enlightened now. This is Burke's attack on the pretensions, as he sees it, of that entire approach to political philosophy.
- 1.98 Can we prove that God exists the way that we can prove the law of gravity, the way that we can prove a geometric theorem? Do we have evidence of God's existence? If not, then we're going to say that's just a hypothesis. If it's a hypothesis that we cannot generalize and make more firm, we're going to set it aside in light of more firmly grounded scientific hypotheses. That approach, Burke is saying, is a disaster. Reason is going to lead us to become irreligious as it is doing in the Enlightenment. But as he has argued, there has to be a foundation in religion.
- 1.99 Also, we do not believe really anymore in the modern world about kings and queens, that somehow they are appointed by God, the divine right of kings. And that kings are more exalted, special individuals. In the modern world, we say, no, the king is a man, the queen is a woman. There may be a certain amount of luck, the way this battle went as opposed to that military battle. They won the war, and as a result of that, they acquired a certain amount of power, and they then passed it on to their children, the

way parents want to pass things. There's nothing God-chosen or supernatural about this. This is a purely naturalistic process.

- 1.100** But why then should we revere the king? It's the fact that he has a lot of power, but is that power just? And if he is not using that power justly, then we have the right to get rid of the king. That's, of course, what the British had done during their Glorious Revolution. They also had executed their king. The king is a man, the queen is a woman. None of this hocus-pocus, feudal, spiritual awe that somehow they are better than we are. They're playing a political role. If they don't do it well according to the natural standards of justice, we will get rid of them.
- 1.101** And the real power should reside with parliament respecting the rights of man. "On this scheme of things, a king is but a man, a queen is but a woman." But notice, going back to the beginning of this sentence, in the olden times, as a result of tradition, we believed that the king was a special human being. We are finding it hard to believe that anymore, but nonetheless, and this is the phrase I want us to attend to, "all the pleasing illusions" about the existence of God, the truth of religion, that priests and monks and nuns are morally pure and good individuals, that kings and queens are better than you are.
- 1.102** Those are illusions, but they are pleasing to us and they are necessary. Now, I'm emphasizing this because, as a modern conservative, and using this language that, yes, it might be an illusion that our religion is true; it might be an illusion, this claim that the kings and queens are special human beings who are better than us; but it is a pleasing illusion. We like to believe it.
- 1.103** If we believe it, if we believe that we are under the authority of those who are higher than we are and better than we are, then we will have a proper moral character. We will be regulated and hopefully a little more self-regulating in a way that makes us able to exercise the kind of liberty that we want in the modern world. A couple more lines that are famous lines here.
- 1.104** Going back to this theme of inheritance, we have inherited from our forefathers as a result of much experiment, much experience, principles that seem to work, but we're not going to treat them as completely inflexible; that as circumstances change, wise people in the modern world, our political institutions can adapt them and we can evolve in certain directions. But what we should do is see our society—and the word Burke emphasizes here is partnership.
- 1.105** "Our commonwealth is a partnership." This is a very modern phrase in one sense. We are all citizens, we are all subjects, we are all part of a society. Sometimes we start saying language like, well, who owns society or whose society is it? We start to say, well, it is our society. In some sense, we all have our parts to play, we all have our role to play, and we're trying to formalize it in a partnership, and we start to think of people as more or less equal partnerships in making it happen.

- 1.106** But it's our society, and in the modern world, we tend to emphasize that it is a partnership of the living. It is our society, and we can do with our society what we, in this generation, want to do. And what Burke wants to do, is an arresting phrase, is to say, "It, our commonwealth, becomes a partnership not only between those who are living, but between those who are living and those who are dead and those who are to be born."
- 1.107** The partnership that is our current society is not just us living people. This is our society. We might say then, as a partnership, start to talk more democratically. Well, we should get together and discuss as partners do, and then we're going to have a vote, and hopefully it will be a large majority of vote, about what we are going to do with our society. But if we think of the partnership as a partnership with the dead, well, the dead, too, then have a vote, and we need to respect their vote and account their vote in with our votes.
- 1.108** But how does the dead vote? Well, the dead have voted, and that's what the tradition is. The dead have come up with various policies that they decided in their generation; they pass them on to us. So even if the majority of us now want to change a certain thing, if we count the votes of the dead, then we're going to be much more conservative, and it's only going to be in extraordinary circumstances that we make any radical change.
- 1.109** "I do not know under what description to class the present ruling authority is in France. It affects to be a pure democracy." And then this is one of the famous predictions. "I think it in a direct train of becoming shortly a mischievous and ignoble oligarchy." The way things are, what's necessarily going to happen is some small factions are going to grab control and turn things into a disaster. A remarkable prediction for 1790.
- 1.110** All right, now, stepping away from the text, this is Burke reflecting on the revolution in France, but at the same time articulating his reasons for distrusting it and contrasting it with what he takes to be more successful evolutions in the modern world, such as have occurred, particularly in England.
- 1.111** Now, in closing, I want to get a little more analytical here. The French Revolution is our working example, and it's dead. Old society is dead. We are now into the modern world. But what direction should we go here? We should not go in direction of the Enlightenment principles. Enlightenment principles, particularly those who are animated by the spirit of political liberalism. The problem with political liberalism is these points here. It's too abstract and rational, and it's too emotional and fanatical.
- 1.112** Unmoored from tradition, the idea that somehow rationally we can figure out what the proper principles are. Unmoored from tradition, our feelings then just get the better of us because most of us are not able to self-regulate our feelings. It is going to be a disaster. We need the traditional principles as our fundamental guide. It talks a lot

about liberty and equality, but it is, again, liberty unmoored from tradition. It is a kind of equality, again, unmoored from tradition, and that is in approach.

- 1.113** It is going much too fast. Instead of a slow evolution as occurred in the example of England and more broadly speaking, Britain, over the course of many centuries, small incremental changes, it's trying to do things much too quickly, and it is disdainful of the past. We can just forget all of the past and start afresh with a blank page. Those are huge mistakes.
- 1.114** Now, I want to leave us with a few questions about the nature of Burkean conservatism. This is, of course, in the philosophy of politics, and what we want to do is figure out what political principles should animate our thinking about government, the place of society, the laws that we make, our relations with other countries as well. One of the important points, of course, is this idea that revolutions are dangerous, evolution is good. Go slowly, tinker at the margins, and make changes. Do not change too much too quickly.
- 1.115** The example here is of France, and the claim is that France went too quickly. One question we can ask then is to say, well, did France move too quickly? Of course, a lot was happening in the French Revolution. Or is it the case that France did not move quickly enough? That if we take, for example, our two working examples, Britain and its slow changes over the course of many centuries, and France, what we find is that France, largely at that time, is not changing at all. It is becoming a very static, doctrinaire, dogmatic, top-down, king-dominated political system.
- 1.116** Maybe the problem for France was not that it is moving too quickly in the 1780s and 1790s, but that it did not move at all in the 1600s and 1700s. So it was moving too slowly, bottling everything up, and then everything bursts out in ugly form in the 1780s and '90s. So did France move too slowly over the centuries, or is the problem really that it moved too quickly?
- 1.117** And how are we to apply this lesson? If we want to say things should not move too quickly, and sometimes things should move more slowly, how do we apply that in a political context? If we start to think of analogies, well, you're going to go for a swim and you know that when you plunge into the water, it is going to be cold. What is the best way to plunge into the water? Should I just plunge in and get it over with in a couple of seconds and then do the adjustment and then everything is fine? Or should I ease my way?
- 1.118** In either case, I'm going to have a shock and experience of some discomfort, but it's a judgment call about whether I should do it quickly or I should do it slowly. Now, that's an example. Suppose then we say, well, another way of thinking about it, it might be in terms of a business analogy. We might say it took Britain four or five centuries to evolve into a modern liberal democracy with appropriate respect for rights and traditions and so forth.

- 1.119** But think of business. In many cases, a business that is going to do something new, it might take it many, many years to develop the new product, to do all of the research and development and the marketing and establish the new market. But once that business has done very well, the next business that comes along can learn from the first business and do it much more quickly.
- 1.120** Sometimes there's what we call the close follower strategy in business, where we will follow a market leader. We're in a different business and we'll observe what they are doing, and it takes them 10 years to develop and bring a new product to market. But then once they've done it, we learn that lesson and we can do it in two years. Then the next business can learn even more quickly and do it in one year.
- 1.121** Maybe the case, the way politics work is, yes, the British went first, and it took them four or five centuries rather to work out what a modern, proper society should look like with its respect for liberty and equality. But other countries can learn from the lesson of the British. So, say the Americans, it's only going to take them, instead of four or five centuries, it's going to take the Americans one century. Then maybe after the Americans, other countries, it's only going to take 50 years and so on.
- 1.122** What does this too fast and too slow business mean? If we say we are going to take traditions seriously and not challenge those traditions, is it not the case that many of the traditions that have come down to us in the modern world are obviously repugnant? The sooner we get rid of those traditions, the better. Think, for example, of the status of women. We say every country around the world has had women as second-class subjects, third-class subjects, or even worse.
- 1.123** Do we want to say, well, this is a time-rooted tradition, and maybe it's an illusion that women should be in this particular status, but it's a pleasing illusion, and we shouldn't change things too fast, and that, to women of our generation, maybe in 50 years or 100 years, we can slowly move to giving you more liberty and equality, but we don't want to change things too quickly? Do we want to go in that direction?
- 1.124** Or do you want to say, sometimes we can figure out that a tradition, even a universal time-honoured tradition, it's just wrong. The sooner we get rid of it, the better. It's not what we want to say to the generation of women in the 1790s and 1800s. Maybe your granddaughters and great granddaughters will have more freedoms. No, we want to do it now. We'll rip the Band-Aid off, rather than slowly peeling the Band-Aid off.
- 1.125** Other examples, what about slavery? Do we want to eliminate slavery slowly over the course of a couple of centuries? Do we want to say, well, there's a pleasing illusion that some people deserve to be slaves, or we're going to say, no, as moderns, we want to reject that. So all of these, and we're groping for analogies, are put on the table for discussion by Burke, prompted by the cataclysmic events of the French Revolution.
- 1.126** It is clear, the modern world has been revolutionary. Britain's Glorious Revolution, the American Revolution, the French Revolution. What are the lessons that we can learn

from them? And Burke's conservatism, it is a modern conservatism. He's not saying religion is absolutely true. Maybe it's a pleasing illusion. Maybe it's simply an illusion that kings and queens are better than us.

- 1.127** But nonetheless, we need something beyond ourselves that we think is better than we are to regulate ourselves in terms of. As we move into the modern world, the right direction to go requires judgment, further experimentation, and so forth.

Lecture 2: Hegel and the State

At a glance — Hegel and the state, in the German states around 1810.

- 2.1 Let's move to the year 1810 and eastward to the German States. In the first lecture, we focused on France, political developments there as it modernizes, and a British political philosopher's reflections on the lessons of the French Revolution. But things are happening, important things are happening in Germany, particularly in the world of philosophy. Germany is becoming the leading philosophical nation in the world, supplanting Britain and France, which perhaps arguably had been the dominant philosophical nations of the 1600s and 1700s. It is now Germany's turn.
- 2.2 I want to focus on the year 1810 because 1810 is the year that the University of Berlin is founded. It is founded as Germans realized that they, too, need to modernize intellectually, religiously, culturally, and politically. One of the major impetuses for this new modernization phase had been Napoleon Bonaparte, the Frenchman, who, at the head of a huge, powerful, modern, audacious army, had swept through the German states and succeeded in a very short time at defeating and even humiliating the Germans.
- 2.3 And one of the reactions then of the Germans is to say, how could this happen to us? And insult of insults, we have lost a war, we Germans to the French, of all people. We need to revive our thinking, reform our thinking, even revolutionize our thinking. Now, the philosopher we're going to focus on in the context of Germany and the German reaction to the French Revolution and to Napoleon is Hegel, Georg Hegel. He is to become the leading philosopher of the 1900s, and some will argue the most important philosopher of the last two centuries, such that his influence is felt, debated, and being applied even in our generation.
- 2.4 Now, we have covered Hegel, his more fundamental philosophy, in our course on modern philosophy. And there we covered his work on philosophy of religion, his work in philosophy of history. How are we to understand why history goes the way that it goes? Is it anything to do with God and God's plan for history? Is it all just random events? Is there a cycle to history? Is there a pattern to history or not? And there, Hegel had argued that there was, in fact, a pattern to history. In fact, all of history can be read as a kind of self-development of an all-powerful being.
- 2.5 Now, one way to approach this Hegelian underlying philosophy is through religion. One of the traditional problems in religion is called the problem of evil. The problem of evil, in short, is to say, if we are religious, we believe in a God. And then particularly if we are Western religious, we believe in an all-powerful, all-knowing, all-good God. We believe in a God who is a perfect being. And we also believe that that God created this world. So he is also a creator God.

- 2.6 But then when we examine the world that God has created, we find that it is filled with lots of evils, lots of bad things that occur, terrible natural events, terrible diseases, and then all of the nasty, awful things that human beings will do to each other. The natural question then arises from that religious perspective is, if we are to think of God as creating the world, how is it possible that a perfect God would have created a world that is so imperfect? It seems like we're put into various sorts of dilemmas at various point.
- 2.7 If we start to say, well, there's another being, say, Satan or the devil, who is partly responsible for what happens in the world, that seems to limit the power of God, because if God is really all-powerful, he should be able to defeat Satan like that and bring about a good world. If we try to say that God himself, well, sometimes he does evil things or allows evil things to happen in the world to teach us a lesson, well, it seems like then he's not a perfect being himself. Why would, say, a good parent allow evil things to happen to their child, to teach the child a lesson? And so that seems to be a dilemma.
- 2.8 We're having this debate. What Hegel does is enter this debate by saying, no, I'm going to insist that God is all-powerful, and I'm going to insist that God is all-good, and that the ultimate destiny of the world is good. But what I'm going to argue is that God is, from the beginning, not all-knowing. Instead, God is in the process of realizing himself, discovering himself. And as God creates the world and causes events to happen in the world, God comes to realize better who he is, where he wants to go, and to realize the ultimate destiny of the world.
- 2.9 Now, this is in one way an old position in the philosophy and in the history of religion. Most of the Orthodox versions of Christianity had condemned it as a heresy. But what Hegel does is reintroduce this not as a heresy, but as a philosophical solution to the traditional problem of evil. What he then wants to do is apply that to realistic understandings of the way the world works, not only religiously, but also politically.
- 2.10 Today, I want to focus on how that underlying philosophical framework, which is religious, perhaps a heretical form of religion, is modernized and extraordinarily influential in Hegelian philosophy. Now, there's a connection between Napoleon and Hegel. When Hegel was, in 1806, the year that Napoleon swept through the German States and conquered them relatively easily, Hegel was a professor at a university in the southeast of Germany of Jena, and there had been a huge battle that Napoleon had fought against the Germans and other troops.
- 2.11 And Hegel, while he was out, had seen Napoleon ride by on his horse. And he was struck by this and made this entry in his diary. "I saw the Emperor, this world soul." Pause on that language for a moment just to highlight it. Remember the language of a world soul. "Riding out of the city on reconnaissance. It is indeed wonderful sensation to see such an individual who, concentrated here at a single point, a stride, a horse,

reaches out over the world and masters it. This extraordinary man whom it is impossible not to admire."

- 2.12 Now, Hegel, when he was younger, he was born in 1770; when the French Revolution broke out, he was in his late teens, and he was an enthusiast of the French Revolution. As the French Revolution went bad, he soured on it and also its particular ideals of liberty and equality. The mature Hegel comes to reject in significant measure or to reinterpret in his own way, as we will see shortly. But in the person of Napoleon, Hegel recognizes something special, and it fits with his broader religious and philosophical understanding of the way history works.
- 2.13 When we read in Hegel, we find frequent reflection on an admiration for individuals he calls world historical individuals. And these are individuals who, for justifiable historical reasons, we have all heard of their names, Alexander the Great, Julius Caesar, and then in his generation, Napoleon. Individuals who seem to rise up and have this world-mastering vision and world-mastering energy and skills to, in effect, impose their will upon the world and take the world in a certain direction.
- 2.14 In the case of Alexander the Great, of course, the Greek states were doing quite well in the fifth century, fourth century, and so forth. But Alexander rises up and not only conquers all of Greece, but also all of Asia Minor, goes significantly into Asia, and makes his mark on the world, bringing not only his own personal vision, but also the Greek way to much of the world.
- 2.15 A few centuries later, it's Julius Caesar. The Roman Empire, of course, was something significant. But out of that arises someone like Julius Caesar, who's able to then seize control of all of Rome, and for a relatively short period of time, though, before he was assassinated, impose his will and to extend the Roman way on the other world.
- 2.16 Now in our generation—there are other figures we could talk about, Charlemagne and so forth—but we have Napoleon and the French, and this man of iron will, iron vision, unbreaking vitality, able to rise up and assert his will now on all of Europe, North Africa, and who knows how far he will go.
- 2.17 Now, what Hegel, though, wants to argue is that these are not just individuals who, from their own force of personality, force of character, force of individual vitality, are imposing their will upon the world, but they are agents of God's broader plan for the world. Just as God in a religious mode will single out certain individuals to be prophets, to advance his religious message in the world, God also singles out certain individuals in the political sphere to advance his cause and his message in the civil sphere or in the political sphere.
- 2.18 It operates not only at the level of individuals. We can perhaps see a progression that the plan of history works through nation. In the beginnings of the modern world, it was the Portuguese who first rose up and became the great explorers going all around Africa, discovering or coming across to Brazil and South America and so forth. For a

while, Portugal was the great innovative, modern, bringing Europe forward nation. Then for a while, it was Spain that was doing the same thing. Then the Dutch and the British had their moment. Then the French are now having their moment.

- 2.19** But Hegel is going to argue, this is going to be, at a prediction, Germany's century. It's time for Germany to rise up and get its act together, so to speak, and assert itself on the national and political stage. We can try to do the same thing when we do the history of religions. We can do a history of religion going all the way back to their various primitive animistic religions, but then see Judaism, say, as the new wave, and then Christianity coming out of that.
- 2.20** As we get into the early modern world, there are the revolutionary things that occur in religion as a result of the Reformation and the Counter-Reformation. We are becoming increasingly thoughtful and ideological and self-reflective and arguing and systematizing with respect to our religion. But perhaps we can read, so to speak, as self-development of the religious mind, the religious ideology, the religious philosophical approach, as the centuries go on. It's not religious randomness, it's not political randomness. It's all part of the plan of God's acting in the world to realize ultimately his vision for the world.
- 2.21** Now, that said, I want to turn to a book. By the time Hegel became a professor of philosophy at the University of Berlin, and his lectures extraordinarily well-attended, not only by people interested in philosophy, but also by people attending seminary, planning religious careers, people planning to go into law, into bureaucracy, he became, as a result of the power of his philosophical system, he seemed to be a representative of the new philosophical way of the world. And what we have is here a book called *The Philosophy of Right*.
- 2.22** And I now want to turn to *The Philosophy of Right*, look at some of the text, some of the important passages. Now, I'll give you a warning. Hegel is one of the philosophers with a reputation or the notoriety of being a very difficult philosopher to read. It's not only the abstractness of the ideas, sometimes the originality of the ideas, but in some cases, he's developing a new vocabulary. We are going to be reading it translated from the German into English. So the translator has done some nice work for us in modernizing the English language to some extent.
- 2.23** Nonetheless, we will plunge into the text, and I've selected some of the important passages. We'll read in the way this almost always goes. The first time you read a philosopher, you understand 30% or 50% of what you read. Hopefully, your professor massages the text and works with you on that. And then the next time you read it, you understand 60 or 70% and you go up the learning curve that way. Let's go to *The Philosophy of Right*.
- 2.24** At the beginning here, we're not talking about philosophy of history, philosophy of religion. We're talking about the philosophy of right. The concept of rights is one of

those hugely important concepts, particularly in modern political philosophy. What is the right way to do politics? And we have this notion that human beings have rights, and rights are like a trump card or a heavy-duty concept that we employ in our modern political vocabulary.

- 2.25 In contrast to much of pre-modern philosophy, where human beings did not talk about their rights so much as they would talk about their duties or their obligations to the state. Or they are, instead of saying, I am a citizen who has rights, I am a subject who may have privileges that are granted to me by the political authority. So Hegel is taking this modern concept and elevating it to his title, and that is significant as a modern philosopher.
- 2.26 We find, as is increasingly done as we get into the modern world after the French Revolution, particularly on the continent, the French Revolution takes over everyone's mind and everyone has to have something to say about the French Revolution. At this point, Hegel is quite jaded on what has occurred. "A more concrete manifestation of this freedom is the fanaticism of political and religious lives." In some respect, echoing Burke, one of the problems we have in the modern world is that we have unleashed political passion to the point of fanaticism.
- 2.27 Instead of people thinking they are subject to powers that are beyond them to comprehend and they follow as obedient subjects, we think that we can do it ourselves, and that unleashes all sorts of terrible things. "Of this nature was the terrible epoch of the French Revolution" and the fanaticism, and of course, the widespread death and destruction.
- 2.28 Now, this concept of right, we have seen that Burke in the earlier lecture had said that rights are things that emerge out of contrivances that human beings develop when they are constructing governments. They're not prior to the existence of government. It's not the case that we have natural rights that the government is supposed to protect or that we have supernaturally endowed rights that the government is obligated to respect.
- 2.29 What Hegel is going to do is disagree with Burke on this point and say, in fact, rights are not mere human contrivances or government contrivances. Rather, right in general is something holy. It is something that has a religious essence to it. A recapitulation of this notion that society, as part of human history, as part of the history of the world, is developing and evolving. Another strongly modern theme, instead of seeing the world as governed by more or less static, unchanging absolute principles, that the world evolves, it changes, it goes through various stages.
- 2.30 Hegel is one of the first political philosophers to incorporate a concept of evolution into his understanding of religion, society, and politics, including the idea of freedom that is so important to us as moderns. It is not a universal absolute. Freedom itself is in a process of evolving. "Every step in the development of the idea of freedom has its

peculiar right, because it is the embodiment of a phase of freedom." It might very well be the case that we see that we argue for and develop freedom, not as an all-at-once thing.

- 2.31 But first, what we do is, we develop a concept of artistic freedom in the Renaissance, and then a concept of religious freedom, and then perhaps the freedom for women, and then concept of freedom against slavery, and then various other kinds of freedom. So freedom itself is subject to an evolutionary process.
- 2.32 "Only the right of the world-spirit is the unlimited absolute." So we might have this idea of rights in all of these different domains. I have my artistic rights, or I have my rights as a woman, or I have my rights with respect to religion. And all of those are domain-specific rights, and they evolve over time. But the fullest concept of right is going to be the right of the world spirit, the unlimited absolute.
- 2.33 Now, this is a piece of technical terminology. Hegel is a modern. And as we know in the modern world, talk about the gods, talk about God, is fraught. We've been, as developer, inheritors of modern science, modern technology, embroiled in debates over the existence of God.
- 2.34 We're well aware that there are so many different religions all over the world, and it's very hard for us in the modern world, now 1800s, to say that somehow our religion is the one and only true religion, and we're more open to the idea that maybe our religion's got some pretty good things, but part of the evolution of it is going to be recognizing that there are other religions that have some pretty good ideas, and we're going to borrow some ideas from them, and maybe they're going to borrow some ideas, and we're going to evolve jointly toward a better and better religion.
- 2.35 We talk about God with a capital G, but some religions talk about gods, and sometimes they don't have their gods so personalized with a personality. They will talk about spirit and be more spiritual and have supernatural beings that have less personality and individuality in that respect to them. What we will find in Hegel is that while he is incorporating many of the insights of traditional religions, his language when he refers to it is variable.
- 2.36 Sometimes he will talk about God. Sometimes he will talk about the world-spirit, capitalizing the W and the spirit, the spirit that governs the world. Sometimes he will talk about the absolute, or he will talk about providence, using various kinds of synonyms that are staking out that kind of territory.
- 2.37 Now, with respect to concepts that matter to us as moderns, liberty is going to be one of them. Right is going to be another one. Hegel is largely dismissive of the concept of equality and some of the early forms of socialism that have been developed in the 1700s and early 1800s under the idea of equality, that what we need to do in society is not only get rid of hierarchy and all of the feudal hierarchies orienting people from the

peasants all the way up to the king, with God over everyone, but rather, in many cases, a radical equality of human beings.

- 2.38** In our religion, in our political life, in our economic life, everything, everyone should be at the same level. And various versions of socialisms and communisms are going to work that concept and prioritize it. Hegel is dismissive of it. "Equality is the abstract identity of the understanding, reflective thought, and all kinds of intellectual mediocrity." So if you find yourself attracted to socialism, from Hegel's perspective, you are a mediocre intellectual. You're trying to grab some sort of principle, but you've not really thought things very through.
- 2.39** "The demand sometimes made for an equal division of land and other available resources, too, is an intellectualism all the more empty and superficial." Some people will then say, well, the kings and the nobles and rich people have all sorts of land. What we need to do as moderns, basically, is take over all of the land and redistribute all of the land equal. Everybody will have an equal starting point. Maybe we will manage all of the land equally as part of a collective and so forth. Hegel is saying that is ridiculous.
- 2.40** One of his arguments is, "We may not speak of the injustice of nature in the unequal distribution of possessions and resources since nature is not free and therefore is neither just nor unjust." So the argument sometimes is made by socialists that it's unfair that some people have more and some people have less. Maybe some people are smarter, some people are less, some people are more vigorous, some people are less, some people have more stuff, some people have less. Your parents in their will left you this amount, but an unequal amount was left to these various other people.
- 2.41** If we set aside the social issues, for example, any natural endowments that sometimes socialists will argue are unfair—it's unfair that some people are physically superior to others or intellectually superior—you want to argue that's a misuse of the concept of fairness. Nature by itself just is. It's not fair or unfair. It's not fair that the giraffe has a long neck and you don't have a long neck. It's just the way it is.
- 2.42** But also, he wants to argue, even if we did take all of the land, say, and redistribute it, and everybody started off with an equal share of land, very quickly, we would be back to a state of inequality because people's natural vitality, their ideas, their energy levels, in some cases, of course, their luck, their natural luck is different. Within a very short period of time, everything would be unequal again. He wants to reject the concept of equality as in any sense a significant or fundamentally important concept in the modern world.
- 2.43** Another important concept in the modern world has been the concept of an individual and that we should, as individuals, have certain freedoms and have certain rights. That all individuals, we might say, have their own life. We're aware of the American Revolution, the right to life, liberty, pursuit of happiness. Your life is yours, my life is

mine, and it's the job of the government and the state to protect our lives. We are individuals with our own life pursuits.

- 2.44** That individualism is also rejected by Hegel. "A single person, I need hardly say, is something subordinate, and as such, he must dedicate himself to the ethical whole. Hence, if the state claims life, the individual must surrender it." So from the beginning, Hegel is rejecting the idea that individuals are the morally significant entities, and that they have rights, and that governments are the servants of the individual, servants of the people. Hegel is reversing that and saying it's the other way around. Individuals are servants of the government, servants of the state, such that if the state says, "We need your life, I claim your life," you have an obligation to give it.
- 2.45** Now, some language here. "The external subjectivity, which is thus identical with me, is the will of others. The will's ground of existence is now subjectivity, and the will of others is that existence which I give to my aim and which is at the same time to me and other. The achievement of my aim, therefore, implies this identity of my will with the will of others. It has a positive bearing on the will of others." This is Hegel's concept—lots of language there we'll unpack in just a moment—of universal subjectivity.
- 2.46** What is it even to be an individual? What makes you, you? And one of the movements in the modern world had been to say individuals have agency. They can inspect the world, they can develop their own ideas, they become self-reflective, they realize their own dreams, their own aspirations, they have their own agency, and they are able to control and be responsible for their actions in the world. So first and foremost then, we are individuals, and to a large extent, we are self-sufficient individuals.
- 2.47** And of course, we will form various kinds of social units after discussion and negotiation and various kinds of agreements and so forth. What Hegel is doing philosophically is saying that that is going to be the wrong approach doing politics because it is metaphysically wrong. You as an individual are not this more isolated, self-sufficient entity with agency of your own. You become you through becoming aware of others who are at the same time becoming aware of you.
- 2.48** There's a social interconnectedness that goes on in the course of conversation and how we are raised with each other in all sorts of walks of life. And so what you are as an individual is, yes, you are physically discrete and so forth, but your essence comes to be something that is created as a result of all of the interactions with all of the others that are out there. So your individuality is a socially universal individuality.
- 2.49** Now, that is a deep philosophical concept, but it is going to set Hegel up for rejecting the kinds of individualistic political philosophies that are more prominent in England and in America. "The ethical order is freedom or the absolute will as what is objective, a circle of necessity whose moments are the ethical powers which regulate the life of individuals. To these powers, individuals are related as accidents to substance. It is in

individuals that these powers are represented, have the shape of appearance, and become actualized."

- 2.50** All right, so more heavy language. One of the big issues in philosophy, again, is to understand who we are as human beings. It's one thing to say that I am a human being. I have my particular, say, bodily mass. I'm a certain height, certain coloring, my voice sounds a certain way, I have certain ideas and passions and goals and dreams and so forth. I am a self-sufficient individual, and that is the fundamental reality. The same thing we would say with respect to you. The individual is the fundamental unit and we are all distinct individuals.
- 2.51** But at the same time, we are also human beings. We share something in common. We are all human. So despite all of our individual differences, it's also true to say that I am Stephen Hicks, but I am human being. Now, one is a particular label for a particular individual, and the other is a more abstract general label for me as part of a collection, the things that we call human beings. They're both true.
- 2.52** But which one is more fundamental? Is it more important to my identity to say that I am an individual and you are an individual, and then in a secondary way, we are a human being? That's just more of an abstraction that has a little less reality and significance. Or is it the more important thing that you are a human being and you have an essential humanity, but you just happen to be accidentally shaped in this particular way, and these other human beings happen to be actually shaped in this other way?
- 2.53** Is the universality more important than the individuality, or the individuality more important than the abstraction? Hegel is saying the more important is the general, the more abstract, the more universal. You as an individual are lesser. The individuality is not the important thing. "Since the laws and institutions of the ethical order make up the concept of freedom, they are the substance or universal essence of individuals."
- 2.54** You belong to a legal order that has certain principles of goodness, rightness, correctness built into it. You are a part of that legal order, and that's the most important thing about you, not your individual uniqueness and particularity. Those are just accidental. "Whether the individual exists or not is all the one to the objective ethical order. It alone is permanent and is the power regulating the life of individuals." What we need to do is stop thinking of individuals as having their own lives to live, and that's the important thing.
- 2.55** Then the state and the political structure is to enable or protect individuals as they do so. That the life of the individual is the important thing. Rather, the important thing is the ethical and the legal order within which the individuals live. Individuals come and go. They live and die. The ethical and legal order is the permanent, ongoing thing. That's the real life of a society. Individuals are secondary.
- 2.56** "The right of individuals to be subjectively destined to freedom is fulfilled when they belong to an actual ethical order because their conviction of their freedom finds its

truth in such an objective order, and it is, etc. It is by becoming a citizen of a good state that the individual first comes into his right." OK, more language, but absolutely fundamental. You do not have rights that the state recognizes. Then you join the state, perhaps we agree, we have a social contract that we're going to assent to these laws, and the laws are going to be respected by the state.

- 2.57** Wrong, according to Hegel. You have no rights as an individual. You have no rights outside of the state. It is by becoming a member of a state that your rights, whatever they are in that state, come into existence. They are conferred, made possible, by the existence of the state. The state and its ethical and legal order comes first. Individuals acquire their rightness and their rights of status by joining the state.
- 2.58** All right. "A similar view is that a collection of judgments, like those available in a corpus juris, are far superior to a code worked out in the most general way." Now, here we talk about the laws, the specific laws and the code of laws, that a political system is going to develop. One of the big debates is a subfield of political philosophy, is debate over the philosophy of law. What is the status of the particular laws that govern us in a society?
- 2.59** One argument had been that laws are developed from the bottom up, so to speak. Let me just read this passage. In the back of this passage, think of Edmund Burke, whom we covered in the last section where he was arguing that everything should be empirical as a result of experience, and we work our way up generally to principles that are rough and ready in a slowly evolving way. Hegel is going to argue that it's the exact opposite, that we start with a very abstract general conception of law and we apply it to particular cases.
- 2.60** "The reason alleged is that such judgments always retain a certain particularity and a certain reminiscence of history which men are unwilling to sacrifice. But the mischievous of such collections is made clear enough by the practice of English law." The English legal tradition, and this is Burke's argument, we go back to Magna Carta, we did a major experiment there.
- 2.61** But the nature of life is so particular and so variable that the way we are going to conduct our legal system and our justice system is, disputes arise, but people go into a court, they make their arguments for and against. And on that particular case, the judge makes a decision. That is the common law. Then hundreds of other similar decisions are reached by judges over the course of that generation. And of course, the judges are all reading each other's decisions.
- 2.62** New generations of law students come along. They read as many of the decisions of the previous judges as they possibly can. They try to sift out some principles that are a little bit more general, but they apply them to the new, unique, individual circumstances of this generation's legal conduct. We build up a legal system over the course of centuries that way.

- 2.63** The opposite way is to say some very wise and smart philosophers generate some general principles of law. This is what justice is. This is what rights are. This is what we mean by freedom and equality. Then we develop a constitution, and then on the basis of that very general constitution, we apply and develop laws that are going to govern all of the particular circumstances. Do we go from the bottom up or the top down? Here, Hegel is saying, the English way, the common law tradition, the empirical way, is wrong. It's mischievous, and it's going to lead you to all sorts of troubles. Instead, we start from the top.
- 2.64** Now, again, we can make a connection to religious history. The idea of religious history with reapplied to politics is to say God is the supreme legislator. God is the all-knowing, wise being, and he communicates a few very general principles to his prophets. The job of those prophets then is to become the political leaders of their communities and to apply those general principles to all of the particular cases. That's the top down in religious history century. Hegel is going to say, we're going to secularize that, but it's nonetheless going to be a top-down process.
- 2.65** With respect to the economic sector of society, Hegel is also positioning himself against the emerging free market capitalist systems that are developing, particularly in England, America, and in the Dutch experiment as well. There, as part of the modern world's development and those traditions, it had been very individualistic. The argument had been, in feudalism, we're all born into certain classes and castes, and these things become pretty rigidified.
- 2.66** What you are going to do for your living is determined by what your parents were doing. So if you were born a peasant, you're going to remain a peasant. If your father was in one of the guilds, he was a blacksmith, chances are good, if you're the son, you're going to become a blacksmith as well. If you were born into the nobility, your job is to train to become the future Duke or the future Earl or whatever. If you were a girl, your job is presupposed. Everyone is born into preset and preestablished structures in society and how you are going to make your life is predetermined.
- 2.67** The moderns come along and say, no, individual freedom matters. I should be able to make a living how I want, my own choice. I can start my own business. I can trade with whomever. If I have resources, I can buy whatever I want. And so we have the development then, on this individual freedom basis, of the idea that that should be applied to the economy and we should have a free market economy.
- 2.68** This is now 1820s, but 50 years earlier, Adam Smith had published *On the Wealth of Nations*, the first modern treatise on free market economics, and everyone is aware of him. Hegel, arguing that also is wrong. We don't leave freedom to this anarchic whatever individuals want to do. Instead, he's going to argue that the economy also needs to be top-down regulated in a significant measure.

- 2.69 "The differing interests of producers and consumers may come into collision with each other." So producers and consumers don't always see eye to eye; there are collisions. And so because of those collisions, their adjustment also requires a control which stands above both and is consciously undertaking. So the relationships between buyers and sellers, producers and consumers, needs to be managed consciously by the state in order to make sure that they are harmonious. It's not that people are going to work out things by their own judgment, sign contracts, and so forth.
- 2.70 Also, "public care and direction are most of all necessary in the case of the larger branches of industry." So it's not just the small producers, but especially the big branches of industry that are important to a nation and its economy. Those especially need government oversight and care, "because these are dependent upon conditions abroad and on combinations of distant circumstances which cannot be grasped as a whole by the individuals tied to those industries for their living."
- 2.71 So it's only going to be the politicians or the administrators of the government who are aware of the state of the economy as a whole, what's going on economically and politically in other parts of the world. They are the only ones who have the perspective to be able to regulate and direct the larger industries in the appropriate way and so forth.
- 2.72 The state. "The state is the actuality of the ethical idea. It is ethical mind qua the substantial will manifest and revealed to itself, knowing and thinking itself, accomplishing what it knows and in so far as it knows." Now, what Hegel here is arguing is that the state is to be seen not as an amoral collection of interests. If we think of the development here of, say, modern, more democratic politics, we learn to be respectful of the democratic outcomes. We think maybe majority voting and so forth is the right way to go. But nonetheless, we are, to some extent, cynical about it.
- 2.73 We recognize that the kinds of people who often get elected are not particularly moral individuals; they're not particularly smart individuals. Maybe they happen to be charismatic or be controlling a certain party machine. We understand that many of the laws that come into existence are not particularly ethical. They're the result of compromises and various kinds of political trades and special interests that are going on.
- 2.74 So, we combine a certain idealism about democracy with a certain cynicism about it because we think the laws are made by us or people just like us whom we have happened to vote into power for a certain amount of time. Hegel is arguing that the benefit of this more top-down approach is going to be that we understand that the law is representative of something higher than people like us. It is something that we can respect as an ethical ideal.
- 2.75 If, ultimately, in some sense, God has chosen certain individuals to have political power, then in some sense, God's goodness is reflected in what those individuals do. And it's

going to, of course, be imperfect as time goes on, as God comes to realize himself better. But nonetheless, it is a morally perfecting process as it goes on because of the source that is going on.

- 2.76** "The state is absolutely rational inasmuch as it is the actuality of the substantial will which it possesses in the particular self-consciousness once that self-consciousness has been raised to the consciousness of its universality. This substantial unity is an absolute unmoved end in itself in which freedom come into its supreme right." So it is through the state, which is the collective realization, perhaps of God's plan, if we want to use that, or of the march of history, if we want to use that language, it is increasingly perfecting itself as it goes along.
- 2.77** "On the other hand, this final end has supreme right against the individual whose supreme duty is to be a member of the state." The individual is not a free agent and the state protects the individual's rights. Rather, individuals have duties toward the state, which is the vehicle through which things are improving.
- 2.78** In considering freedom now, this, again, important modern concept, the starting point must not be individuality. Individuals are not free. We don't start there. The single self-consciousness, my freedom of conscience, say, on matters of religion or what my beliefs know. "But only the essence of self-consciousness, for whether man knows it or not, this essence is externally realized." Who I really am is outside of myself, in the other, the collection of other—that is, my society represented in the state in which single individuals are only moments.
- 2.79** "The march of God in the world." Now, here Hegel is forthright with the religious language. "The march of God in the world, that is what the state is." The state is the vehicle for God to realize his purposes. You as an individual have no right with respect to God. You are a vehicle through which God is going to realize his purposes. At various other points, Hegel uses less religious language and more biological language.
- 2.80** "The state is an organism. That is, the development of the idea to the articulation of its differences." What do we mean by an organism? Well, I am an organism. I have skin cells, I have kidneys, I have a liver, I have a heart, I have ligaments and muscles and so forth. So all of these organs have a role to play in this overall organism. And so it's not that individual skin cells have their own rights and their own destiny to do what they want.
- 2.81** So we extrapolate that concept of an organism to a society, and a society is like that, where we are each cells in that overall society, but it's the society that has its own life. It's the real organism that passes. I scratch my hand like that, and I don't know how many individual skin cells I just knocked off, but they die. Other ones are born. The organism carries on. Individuals in a society die, other ones are born, the society carries on. An organic understanding of the state.

- 2.82 "This is the place now to allude to the relation of the state to religion." One of the big modern moves has been, of course, a certain amount of skepticism with respect to religion. Two big moves. One has been to delegate the importance of religion to the individual, the idea that individuals have responsibility for their own religious lives.
- 2.83 If I'm interested in saving my soul, it's up to me to investigate the various religions, decide which one is best for me and the truest, and as a matter of self-responsibility, to dedicate myself to the one that I think is right, or maybe I don't think any of them are right, and I am going to dedicate my life to achieving values without a religion. But that is my individual responsibility. And that then means, as a matter of social ethics, I have to respect that you also are individuals embarking on the same project.
- 2.84 And chances are good that you are going to have different views on lots of things that I am going to have, and you're going to go your own way, and maybe you're going to believe all sorts of crazy things that I can't believe anybody would believe, and you're going to believe the same thing about me. But we're going to have to be tolerant of individuals' freedom with respect to their own religious conscience.
- 2.85 Politically, it's also been a move in the modern world to say it is not the business of the state, of the government, of the laws, to tell me what I'm supposed to believe and do with respect to religion. I have a right to my individual conscience and the right to act with respect to religion, and the job of the state is to protect my religious freedom, however I choose to exercise that. That has led then to the modern doctrine of separating the church and the state, or separating religion from politics.
- 2.86 Politics focuses on these issues. Religion focuses on these issues, but it's not the job of the political sphere to regulate the religious sphere. That's a free zone for individuals to do what they want. Also, we want to keep religion out of politics. We don't want political people trying to influence the laws on behalf of their particular religion. So, all of those issues that Hegel is well aware of developing in the modern world, particularly in the Western world, he's going to take them up and reject, again, in its entirety, that approach.
- 2.87 "This is the place to allude to the relation of the state to religion, because it is often reiterated nowadays that religion is the basis of the state. And because those who make this assertion even have the impertinence to suggest that, once it is made, political science has said its last word. No. Further, while the state is mind on earth"—and this is mind somewhat capitalized, the mind of God on earth is what the state is realizing—"religion may sometimes be looked upon as commanding downright indifference to earthly interests."
- 2.88 Some religions, though, we know, say the world is divided metaphysically into the natural world and the supernatural world. Maybe what we should do is keep the two separate, not so much for political reasons or because we think individuals have freedom rights, but because religion and politics are just dealing with completely

different parts of reality. Religion is about what we should think about the supernatural world, but it has nothing to say about what the natural world is like.

2.89 Also, when we are studying the natural world, whatever sciences and secular political systems that we come up with, that doesn't tell us anything about the nature of the supernatural world. And so those two realms should be indifferent to each other. Maybe we take that argument. Hegel is going to again say, no. "If religion be religion of a genuine kind," that is to say, the proper approach to religion, "it does not run counter to the state in a negative or polemical way. It rather recognizes the state and upholds it. Furthermore, it has a position and an external organization of its own."

2.90 Here, religion, and it has to be the correct religion, if that religion is correct, it will recognize that the state is the ethical ideal. It's the realization of the absolute mind. It's another language. It's the realization of God's plan for the world. And the proper religion will see itself as supporting the state and as performing rules adjunct to the state, so that the state can do its role. So we are rejecting entirely this principle of separating church and state.

2.91 "In the nature of the case, the state discharges a duty by affording every assistance and protection to the church in the furtherance of its religious ends." That is to say, not only will the proper religion support the state, the state will also support and further the proper religion. There will be an integration of the church and the state. In addition, well, one of the things that religions are supposed to do is to teach people morals.

2.92 "Religion is an integrating factor in the state implanting a sense of unity in the depths of men's minds. The state should even require all of its citizens to belong to a church." So church attendance or not is not optional. It's not a free choice that you make. It will be mandatory by law. Now, what we then said is church and state are going to be integrated, not separated, as in the British, some Western European, and certainly in the American tradition.

2.93 But if we are integrated, there still is going to be a question about which one is going to be more important than the other. Are they in an equal partnership, for example? And Hegel is going to argue no. "In contrast with the church's faith and authority in matters affecting ethical principles, rightness, laws, etc., in contrast with the church's subjective conviction, the state is that which knows."

2.94 What we have here is an argument that the state is the more equal or the superior in this partnership on epistemological grounds, or that is to say, with respect to knowledge or with respect to cognition. It is the state, Hegel is arguing, that has actual knowledge. By contrast, the important concept here is, the church operates on the basis of faith.

2.95 So the church will say, you will have faith in these principles that were revealed to God, but God did not reveal them, or revealed by God to various prophets. He did not reveal them to you. Or they are captured in our scripture, but you are not able, you as an

individual, to verify that scripture is accurately reflecting the word of God. So you, first and foremost, have an obligation to accept the scriptures, the word of God, on faith, and then to obey within that tradition.

- 2.96** So Hegel's argument is that religions then are important, but they are of a cognitively lower order, and that the state is the one that has better epistemological standards. So it's a partnership, but the first among not quite equals is the state. "The state retains the right and form of self-conscious objective rationality. The right to make this form count and to maintain it against pretensions springing up from truth and subjective dress."
- 2.97** So all kinds of weird and alternative religions are going to crop up. The state will pick and choose which ones are to be tolerated. It will keep the other ones confined, and in some cases, it might put them out of business, so to speak.
- 2.98** All right. Democracy. "The phrase 'the many', 'o polli' from the Greek," 'hoi polloi'. What is the place of democracy? Another important concept. The Greeks were the first to experiment significantly with democracy, two and a half millennia earlier. There had been various democratic elements in the Roman Republic and in various other small city-states like Florence and Venice, and some of the Baltic states had incorporated significant democratic and Republican elements as well. Of course, this is a huge concept in modern political philosophy as well.
- 2.99** We have then the idea that somehow, if we bring the masses together, the people, all of the people together, and we give everybody a vote, some wisdom is going to emerge from this democratic process. We have another mention here of the French Revolution, the summoning of the Estates, when in 1789, first, second, and third estate got together. They had their representatives, and they said, "We're going to vote on various kinds of new constitutional policies and principles, and the king is going to be subordinate to us on those."
- 2.100** Hegel has nothing to do with democracy. "The truth is that if 'people' means a particular section of the citizens, then it means precisely that section which does not know what it wills." Here he's asking you to think about most people. How politically savvy are most people?
- 2.101** If we say we're going to enact laws with respect to important policy matters— energy, legal reform, anything involving science and math, knowledge of what's going on around the world in some closing on 200 nations around the world so that we can form appropriate foreign relations—the vast majority of the people, they have no idea what they want, and they have no idea what they even know in those areas.
- 2.102** Of course, get them into a bar and give them a beer or two. They'll start pounding on the table. "I know what's going on and what this country needs" and so forth. But that is pretentious. Most people are relatively ignorant, and most people are relatively governed by their passions. So democracy is a disaster. "To know what one wills, and

still more to know what the absolute will, Reason, wills, is the fruit of a profound apprehension and insight, precisely the things which are not popular."

- 2.103** So the people who know, who have well-regulated passions, is a tiny percentage of the population. This is going to be a professional class of politicians and administrators. They are the ones who will formulate the policies. Democracy is ridiculous.
- 2.104** What about freedom of speech and freedom of the press? Another modern freedom. I should be able to think what I want, say what I want, publish what I want, read what I want, my decision, my right. "To define freedom of the press as freedom to say and write whatever we please is parallel to the assertion that freedom as such means freedom to do as we please. Talk of this kind is due to wholly uneducated, crude, and superficial ideas." No freedom of the speech, no freedom of ideas. It's ridiculous.
- 2.105** "The question of the perfectability and education of the human race arises here." Education is not a self-responsibility. It's not an individual family responsibility. Partly, if we think back to 1810, the founding of the University of Berlin, that is part of the massive education reform that the German states embarked upon, starting in 1810. We need to reeducate Germans in a modern way, a way that is going to enable us to realize our destiny and certainly to stand up to the French and the British when we need to. Individuals belong to the collective. We belong to the state, and so education should be a state-managed process.
- 2.106** Now, what about Germany in particular? Here we step more broadly and think about history, and we connect this philosophy of right with Hegel's philosophy of history. "The nation to which is ascribed a moment of the idea in the form of a natural principle is entrusted with giving complete effect to it in the advance of the self-developing self-consciousness of the world mind." All right, more big language, but the world mind is the mind of God.
- 2.107** History is God creating the world, acting in the world, putting himself into the world, and then, having done so, reflecting on what has happened, and then re-putting himself into the world. So the history is the march of God in the world, and God is realizing successively, as the generations go on, what his powers are and what ideas he wants to realize by the use of that power. What Hegel is saying is, that self-developing self-consciousness of the world mind of God happens primarily at the level of nations. There are certain nations at various points history that develop.
- 2.108** "This nation is dominant in world history during this one epoch, and it is only once that it can make its hour strike." So in any generation or any epoch, God chooses one nation. Maybe it's the Babylonians, maybe it's the Assyrians, maybe it's the Egyptians. And it's going to be through that nation that God experiments, tries something out, realizes himself, and takes world history to the next stage.
- 2.109** During that epoch, when that nation has been singled out, it is the special nation. "In contrast with this, its absolute right of being the vehicle of this present stage in the

world mind's development, the minds of the other nations are without rights. And they, along with those whose hour has already struck, count no longer in world history." So at any given epoch, there is one nation that has been chosen by God to advance world history. It alone has the right and the power. All other nations are instruments. They have no rights. This nation can do what it wants with respect to those other nations.

2.110 "All actions, including world historical actions, though, culminate with individuals as subjects giving actuality to the substantial." Here, think of Alexander the Great. When it was the moment of the Greeks, God chose the Greeks to take the world historical development one step further, and Alexander is his instrument. Then it's the Romans, Julius Caesar. Then it's the French, Napoleon.

2.111 Now, "they are living instruments of what is in substance the deed of the world mind, and they are therefore directly at one with that deed, though it is concealed from them and is not their aim and object." So Alexander is the vehicle for God's plan at that moment, even if Alexander does not realize. The same thing for Julius Caesar, same thing for Napoleon. "All that is vouchsafed rather to them by such opinion is undying fame."

2.112 And now, in closing, what about now? We are well into the modern world. We have read history a certain way. It's gone through the Babylonians. Maybe we say something about the Chinese and the Japanese and the Indian subcontinent and the Arabs. We get into the modern world and we have absorbed our lessons of Renaissance and Reformation, and we've now lived through the French Revolution.

2.113 Out of all of that, Hegel abstracts four big stages. There was the Oriental stage, primarily China. Then there was the Greek stage, then the Roman, and now it is the time for the Germanic. It's the time for the Germans to step up onto the world stage and take it next. "This is the absolute turning point. Mind rises out of this situation and grasps the infinite positivity of this inward character. That is, it grasps the principle of the unity of this divine nature and the human."

2.114 In now the German state, it is the divine integrated, unified, with the German people. "The reconciliation of objective truth and freedom as the truth of freedom appearing within self-consciousness and subjectivity." We Germans now, having done our history, done our religion, done our philosophy, are becoming self-conscious of the direction of history and of our place in that history. "A reconciliation with the fulfillment which the principle of the north, the principle of the Germanic peoples, has been entrusted."

2.115 Now, this is early 1800s. Hegel is to become the ruling philosopher of Germany. One thing that we can then do is, as Burke tried to do with the French Revolution, early in its stages, project what's going to happen if we try to do the French Revolution the way the French Revolution is being done.

2.116 What is going to happen in the German nation when the leading German philosopher says, "We Germans have been selected by God to advance the world to its next stage,

and God is going to select certain special individuals among us to be the vehicles for that transformation of the world. All individuals have no individual rights, but rather belong to the state to be used by the state in the furtherance of this God-directed purpose"? Where is German politics going to go over the course of the 1800s?

- 2.117** That is a digest of some of the essential passages in Hegel's *Philosophy of Right*, published in Berlin while he was professor at the university there. In his lifetime, Hegel becomes enormously popular, and schools of philosophy develop out of Hegelian philosophy. I want to argue to the side that in order to understand Hegel fully, it's important to recognize that in the modern world, he does not see himself as entirely original.
- 2.118** Rather, he draws significantly on a French, actually a Swiss-French philosopher, Jean-Jacques Rousseau. We have some discussion of him in our course on modern philosophy. "But the principle of freedom dawned in the world in Rousseau and gave infinite strength to man, who thus apprehended himself as infinite." To have a fuller understanding of Hegel, I would recommend you spend some time reading up a little on Rousseau. There is an integration of Rousseauian political philosophy and Hegelian political philosophy.
- 2.119** Also, less on political matters and moral matters, but on more fundamental metaphysical and epistemological matters, Hegel sees himself as largely standing in the tradition of Immanuel Kant, who had been the ruling philosopher of Germany in the generation prior to Hegel. Just one quotation from Hegel on the importance of Kant, "From the Kantian system and its completion, I expect a revolution in Germany." We have revolutionary philosophers. We are the ones who are going to be showing the way going forward.
- 2.120** Important for not only our next lecture, but for the next two centuries is in the next generation of German philosophy, Karl Marx. When he was a young student of philosophy, he became a Hegelian for a while and read deeply in the Hegelian tradition and introduced some dramatic, significant, important transformations of Hegelian philosophy. But nonetheless, much of the overall contours of Hegelian philosophy are carried over into Marxist philosophy.
- 2.121** One standard way of reading the history of philosophy and the history of political philosophy in the 1800s is to say that Hegel spawned two movements. There was the right Hegelians who took things in a more nationalistic, top-down, religion-friendly political direction, and the left Hegelians, who were nonetheless Hegelians fundamentally, but took things in a different philosophical and political direction. This is just by way of promissory notes for the future.
- 2.122** I want to read a quotation jumping ahead almost a century. This is from a young man who died, a young German boy, who died in World War I. This is a letter he wrote home to his parents. We talked about reforming and revolutionizing the German educational

system, teaching young people what it is to lead a meaningful life, what your life is all about. See if you can hear the echo of Hegel in this young man's letter home a century later, as Germans and their allies are fighting the French and the English and their allies.

- 2.123** This is what my life means, and I am Otto Braun. I have volunteered for World War I. "My innmost yearning, my purest, though most secret flame, my deepest faith and my highest hope, they are still the same as ever, and they all bear one name: the state. One day to build the state like a temple rising up pure and strong, resting in its own weight, severe and sublime, but also serene like the gods, and with bright halls glistening in the dancing brilliance of this sun—this, at bottom, is the end and goal of my aspirations."
- 2.124** So the influence of Hegelian philosophy, Hegelian political philosophy, the reformations over the course of the 19th century of the German educational system, here we have a student who is representative of the learning of that system, but also putting it into political practice to the point of being willing to volunteer for war and, if necessary, to die for the state.
- 2.125** One more. At the end of this long series of courses in philosophy of politics, we are going to get out of the pre-modern era into the modern era, where we are now, and into what is called the postmodern era. And the philosopher Michel Foucault is perhaps the most famous of the postmoderns, but just an interesting point to retain. "Whether through logic or epistemology, whether through Marx or Nietzsche, our entire epoch, epoch, struggles to disentangle itself from Hegel."
- 2.126** Hegel, perhaps the most important political philosopher of the last two centuries, explaining many of the events and many of the ideologies. So stay tuned.

Lecture 3: Engels and Marx

At a glance — Engels and Marx from 1842 onward.

- 3.1 To turn to the year 1842, jumping further into the 19th century. And this date because Friedrich Engels who's most known to history as sponsor and research and writing partner with Karl Marx, founder of Marxist philosophy and Marxist political philosophy, it's the year that Friedrich Engels visited England.
- 3.2 The choice of England was significant in part that Engels came from a business family, an industrial family, and they had interests in England. But also, Engels had intellectual interests, along with his colleague, to be Karl Marx, in what is happening in England, the most developed liberal democracy, the most developed free market capitalist nation, and the most important nation, the most developed nation of the Industrial Revolution.
- 3.3 The modern world has been revolutionized in every important segment of society—art, religion, science, politics. With respect to slavery, the status of women, and with respect to engineering and production. The Industrial Revolution changed almost everything. Now, standardly, historians like to choose James Watt's steam engine to mark the symbolic date for the beginning of the Industrial Revolution. That certainly makes sense because a steam engine, a commercially viable steam engine, that is to say, you consume less valuable resources in your inputs relative to the value of your outputs.
- 3.4 It makes possible large-scale energy, available for all sorts of purposes, and it also does not have to be attached to sources where there's lots of firewood or lots of coal necessarily or lots of water power. You can make a factory anywhere you want and with the principles of engineering to deliver that power, various, through various sorts of transmissions and gear shafts and so forth, to make it move the machines in almost any direction that you want. It was a game-changer.
- 3.5 I want to signal also the year 1776. Also 1776 is important. The American Revolution begins in 1776. Important for politics. Adam Smith publishes *On the Wealth of Nations* in 1776. Important for modern economics as a science, particularly free market economics. The beginnings of the Industrial Revolution, at least symbolically in 1776, with the steam engine, it makes it important.
- 3.6 But that is a bit deceptive because England, in particular, had been going through a century of innovation and invention and tinkering for well over a century in both the agricultural sector and in the more industrial sector. This is, in one sense, a capstone of well over a century of all sorts of engineering, technical inventiveness that is characteristic of English culture. Then more broadly, Welsh culture, Scottish culture, Irish culture, British culture in general, and then spreading to the continent.

- 3.7** It's astonishing, when you read the histories about how many inventions that come into existence, and all of these significant inventions. Instead of every generation or so, something new comes along, or every 10 years or so, something new comes along, every year there are new inventions, important inventions, and entire festivals devoted to celebrating the new invention.
- 3.8** The steam engine, of course, is one, but soon the cotton gin, water frame, metallurgy, vulcanizing rubber, the photograph, anesthesia, in all sorts of these areas, in medicine, developing cosmetics, communications, transportation. Just an amazing century that has gone on, and England is at the forefront of it.
- 3.9** Now, with the Industrial Revolution, everything is happening so quickly. England is in some sense becoming wealthier, although it's not clear if it really is becoming overall wealthier or if there are just pockets of wealth and so on. One of the very clear symbols of the Industrial Revolution is not just the amazing inventiveness and a huge number of new inventions and new products that are available to them, but the mass migration of people from the countryside in England had largely been a rural agrarian nation for many, many centuries to, in a short period of time, it being concentrated in the cities, Birmingham, Manchester, London, and other great centers of industry.
- 3.10** And with that mass urbanization comes not only a great deal of potential and many successes, but also a significant number of problems. In the midst of this revolution, the English are a liberal democracy. They are a free market nation. They are trading all over the world. They are developing their empire. They are industrializing on a rapid pace. They are urbanizing on a rapid pace as well. There's a great deal of reflection on what is happening in England, and can we sort out what's good and what's bad, and of the things that are bad, can we figure out why they are happening and what to do about those?
- 3.11** It seems like, obviously, we are now, by the time we get to the 1840s, enormously productive. Just English factories are cranking out huge amounts of stuff and things that used to be luxuries that only were handmade and available to the very rich, everybody has—multiple suits of clothes, kitchenware, and even glass to put in your windows. So overall, productivity is going up. Overall, wealth is going up.
- 3.12** The size of the English, and by extension, the British population, is going up. And that's one good measure of a healthy economy, if you can support in existence more people instead of people starving or choosing not to have large families because they just can't afford it. English population has clearly increased significantly since the Industrial Revolution. The amount of food that is available, even though many people are struggling to find food and to find nutritious food. There's more clothing, there is more housing available, but the quality of the housing in many cases is very poor to ramshackle.

- 3.13** Our understanding of human hygiene, the developments of new science and new biology and new medicine, we at least have the understanding, but at the same time we're crowding people into all of these new cities and we haven't developed sewage systems yet. What do we do with our waste products? And what do we do when we have so many people crowded together, most of whom are not bathing very often and washing their clothes very often, because they don't have indoor plumbing and toilets yet? Those are still in the future. So hygiene is seriously an issue.
- 3.14** Also, it's clear, while there's lots of jobs that are available, it's not clear that the wages are going up, particularly for people who are lower skilled and perhaps not very educated as well, because while there are lots of jobs, all the factories want lots of people, there may be a huger number of people competing for those jobs, and that's going to force wages down.
- 3.15** The working conditions in these new factories, of all of these new machines and the hygiene issues and so on, and people not yet knowing very much about safety or even being particularly safety conscious, are their working conditions up to speed? And great debate over life expectancy. Some of the early data indicated, astonishingly, the average person in Britain was living almost 40 years by the time we get to the 1840s, life expectancy at birth being 40.
- 3.16** Then, of course, from our 21st-century perspective, that sounds like abysmally low life expectancy, since ours is approaching 80, more than doubling since this time period. But this was, to those who were optimistic about these numbers, astonishing, because the world average and the British average had been in the 20s and perhaps in the low 30s at the beginning of the Industrial Revolution.
- 3.17** So are we making progress? Overall, is the progress being distributed and enjoyed by all members of society? Are we creating all sorts of wonderful things? Yes. But are we also causing new problems that we don't have solutions for? Perhaps those new problems that we have created are unsolvable. This is a culture in the midst of multiple revolutions at once. And certainly the English themselves and everybody interested in what's going on in the world are paying very close attention.
- 3.18** It's in this era that the novelist Charles Dickens comes to fame for being a brilliant storyteller, brilliant with characterization, such that many of us will still watch A Christmas Carol during the Christmas season, now a century and a half or more later. But two of the characters that have come down from Dickens at this time are reflective of many of the concerns that the British had about their own population and, of course, foreign observers as well. One is the character of Scrooge.
- 3.19** Scrooge in the novel is a capitalist. He's a very wealthy businessman, but he's miserly and an unpleasant fellow. He has an employee, Bob Cratchit, whom he doesn't treat very well, and he doesn't pay him very much money, and he even begrudgingly gives him Christmas Day off. What we then have is, is it the case, the question being raised

here, that the kind of people we are becoming as moderns, as modern capitalists, concerned with making a profit and making riches, these cold, calculating, uncaring people who mistreat other people in society, particularly our employees and people who are poorer?

- 3.20** Another famous character from Charles Dickens, reflecting many of the concerns the British have is what about the poorest of the poor people in our society, and the endearing character of Oliver Twist, who was an orphan boy, an orphan boy sent to one of the workhouses, one of the poorhouses, along with lots of other children who had lost their parents, and they are looked after by an uncaring bureaucracy that, again, makes them work, gives them substandard food, substandard heating in the winter and so forth. And so what about the poor? What about the orphans? What about the many people who seem to be being left behind by this fast-moving revolutionary world that is being created?
- 3.21** Can we see most of the problems that have come into existence as problems that are solvable, or are they new problems that are going to be, in principle, unsolvable? So maybe it's the possibility that, yes, we are becoming very productive as a result of the Industrial Revolution and all of the new free market economies and the freedoms that we are having in civil society. That has unleashed a huge burst of human productive energy. But there are limits to how productive we can be.
- 3.22** Maybe in the first century or so, we've taken all of the low-hanging fruit, so to speak, off the tree. But it gets harder and harder to harvest the fruits higher up on the tree, and then eventually you get to the top of the tree and there's no more fruit to be harvested. So maybe we're just doing the easy pickings, so to speak, as a result, and we're going to reach the limits of productive growth that's possible to England or to any economy.
- 3.23** And then at the same time, we are as a result of all of this new stuff and the new wealth, we're supporting a larger population, but a larger population, they just need to eat more. And larger populations are going to start having larger family. And so the population is going to grow and grow and grow. And we can plot that on a curve, an upward curve. And we say, isn't this wonderful? We can support more human beings. Our productivity is going to go up for a certain amount of time, but it's going to plateau. And at a certain point, the human population is going to outstrip the productive possibilities of our economy, and then things will get ugly.
- 3.24** And so there are deep discussion of the Reverend Thomas Malthus, who early in the 1800s had published an essay on population, and he was statistically very literate, and so he gave us some theorems with respect to population dynamics. He had made one prediction, which is to say, yes, human productivity is increasing. We can say it's going up in an arithmetical factor. Say it's going up 10% a year. Actually, that's a bit high. Suppose it's going up 5% a year. With ongoing innovation and so forth, we can continue to improve the economy 5% per year.

- 3.25** But we also have to plot that against making stuff that people are going to consume, and it's the population growth, the people who are going to consume, we also have to plot that. From his studies of animal populations, including human populations, he had this statistic. "Population, when unchecked, goes on doubling itself every 25 years, or increases in a geometric ratio."
- 3.26** Now, that then is to say, 25 years, we choose that as the normal human generation. By the time you're in your late teens, into your 20s and on so forth, perhaps into your early 30s, that's when you have your family. The claim is then, you take a man and a woman, they will double themselves in 25 years, but then the population is going to double again in another 25 years and then double again in 25 years, so what we then have is not a straight line curve, but rather a curve that goes up and so forth.
- 3.27** What then happens when we have the productivity curve going in this direction and then the population curve, the population outstrips the productivity, and again, we are setting ourselves up for some ugliness. When population growth, which is a good thing, we like that, but it outstrips the food supply, we need to then decide who's going to live and who's going to die. That's going to be an ugly problem for moderns to solve.
- 3.28** Now, back in the old days, we didn't believe that we could be so productive, and we weren't with that modern mindset that we can solve all problems and make things better and better in all ways. Back in the old days, we just thought, well, every once in a while, there's a famine. People starve to death. That's just the way it is. Maybe that's nature's way of keeping the population in control, or maybe it's part of God's plan. But nonetheless, the idea that we can support increasing population, that's just not an issue that we think about in the modern world.
- 3.29** But now we're moderns. We think we are enlightened. We've got science and engineering and freedom and productivity, and we can solve all problems. But what about this one? Malthus is signaling that maybe this is a problem that we cannot solve. What we then are going to do is have to make some very harsh choices without having to wait until that point is reached in the necessary dynamic.
- 3.30** Now, others, more optimistic, want to say, well, population can grow up, but we also can improve productivity in an unlimited fashion. Maybe one of the issues is that we have an uneducated population. If we go back to the beginnings of the Industrial Revolution, there's only a tiny fraction of the British population that is even literate and knowledgeable about very much of anything. Then we have all of these new factories coming into existence, and all of the people all over England, rather, are rushing into the cities to get all of these factory jobs, but they don't have any skills, and they don't have any knowledge, and they don't have any basic literacy.
- 3.31** The reason why their wages are so low is that they are unskilled labor. But there's a solution to this problem, and the solution is increase their skill level, increase their knowledge level, teach them to read. Maybe what we need, in addition to the

Industrial Revolution, is an education revolution, where we develop a culture where everybody's going to teach their children to read and send them off to school to get basic education and so forth. With the increasing skill level and knowledge level, we can become even more productive. Maybe that's the issue that we need to deal with.

- 3.32** We start to then see the collection of statistics over the course of the 1800s that show that some of the more optimistic British recognize this as necessary for the modern world. It's not only that you need to be able to read the Bible, say, so you can get your religion right to save your soul. It's not only that you need to be able to read the newspaper so you become informed about world affairs. So then this new democratic republic, you can vote as an informed citizen.
- 3.33** Maybe we also are going to enforce, or rather encourage, lots and lots of education for people's self-development so they could become more self-responsible economically and be able to compete in this new economic world that we are creating. We see in various parts of England and various subsectors in England increases in educational efforts and literacy efforts as the 1800s go on.
- 3.34** One of the big problems, of course, is the problems of urbanization. We take all of these people who are poor and they're scattered all over the countryside. Of course, they're living, most of them, in terrible living conditions. Sanitation is primitive at best. There's lots of diseases and choleras and various other things that happen to various sorts of people. And so what we've done, though, is, as a result of the Industrial Revolution, concentrated that very visibly. It's not really a new problem. It's just the worst version of an old problem by putting everybody in the cities.
- 3.35** And so we have substandard housing, substandard hygiene, and so on. But maybe, again, this is not an unsolvable problem because what we know with the new mathematics, the new statistics, the new science, the new biology, better understanding of antiseptic and so on, all of these new sciences that are coming along, we can figure out what causes all of these diseases, and we can develop cures for many of the diseases.
- 3.36** One of the great heroes on the optimist side of this equation was to say, yes, we do have lots of people concentrated into London, and people are just throwing their sewage into the streets, and it's ending up in the Thames and so forth. Every once in a while, we have a plague, but it's not a mystery. It's that, statistically and mathematically, I can show where this cholera epidemic originated from. Then having identified that, we can develop new hygienic waste disposal systems, start to develop sewage systems, and the Industrial Revolution is going to make it possible for us to develop mass production of pipes and all of the engineering projects to make it possible.
- 3.37** That's another problem that is solved, but it's not obviously solvable in the context of mid-1800s. Do we have a revolutionary society that is overall progressive? We're

solving lots and lots of problems, and life is getting better and better, and every new problem that we create along the way—our new education, our new science, our new engineering—is going to help us solve those new problems as they come along and the future looks bright.

- 3.38** Or is it the case that really what we have in this new modern society with its capitalism, with its Industrial Revolution, with its factory workers, with its terrible living conditions in the big cities, is a sign of an experiment that has gone horribly wrong, and we have an irredeemable sick society? Is England then, and Britain, more broadly representative of the progressive future, or a sign of a decaying decadent modernity that in some sense needs to be identified and transplanted?
- 3.39** Now, Marx and Engels are on the pessimist side with respect to modern capitalism and modern industrialization. They recognize it as an enormously transformative force, but that one that ultimately needs to be recognized as sickly, challenged morally, and hopefully supplanted from their perspective by something that is not going to be free market capitalism, but rather a kind of socialism or communalism.
- 3.40** And so Engels is very concerned to study what's going on in England. And a couple of years after his visit, he's taking notes, he writes up the formal book, *The Condition of the Working Class in England*. It is these notes and this analysis that Marx read very avidly and incorporated into his broader framework. Now, I mentioned Engels, he's often seen as the junior partner, but I do want to elevate him some for the purpose of this lecture, particularly in the early stages when Marx was developing his philosophy, developing his political theory, developing his economic theory, the importance of Engels' research, Engels' analysis, to the young Marx's thinking.
- 3.41** Now, there's a huge literature on Karl Marx. We in this academy have had another lecture on the younger part of Karl Marx's corpus of works, focusing on his 1848 *Communist Manifesto*, co-written with Friedrich Engels. But in this lecture, I want to emphasize more the later works of Karl Marx, the more mature versions of Marx. But there is a lot of controversy about how to interpret Marx in himself, whether Marx was the same from early to late, whether this portion of Marx is revelatory of what is most fundamental and important in Marx, and the rest is, in some sense, secondary or in some cases, a cover story. So I want to put that out there without passing judgment on that.
- 3.42** But I know there is one simple version of Marx, or at least I think of it as the simple version of Marx, that young Karl Marx, when he was a teenager, had a certain psychology, and that much of his philosophy is a rationalization of the psychology that he had. What we know about Marx's philosophy, and its economic and political philosophy, that it's very violent, that it's about conflict and oppression, and there being no way for, peacefully and democratically, people to get past their economic and political differences.

- 3.43 So necessarily, we have to have a violent revolution that's going to overthrow all of the institutions of society and kill off large segments of the society as well. All of this is part and parcel of the official version of Marxist philosophy. And so what I think of as the simple version of Marx is to say that Marx was a stereotypical alienated teenager and that his philosophy ends up being a rationalization of that.
- 3.44 Here's Karl Marx at age 18, for example, writing some poetry. He wrote a significant amount of poetry. But let's read this poem, just four lines from it, to get a sense for what's going on in the 18-year-old. Very intelligent guy, very sensitive guy, enough to write poetry. But here it is. "Worlds I would destroy forever, since I can create no world, since my call they notice never, coursing dumb in magic whirl." OK, let's take all the poetry out of that. The first line is, I'm willing to destroy the world forever. What kind of person is willing to see the whole world destroyed? Someone who is very angry. But why is he so angry and willing to destroy the whole world?
- 3.45 Second line, I can create no world. I don't feel that I can bring about the world that I want it to be. I feel powerless. I feel impotent. Maybe I have big dreams, but I don't think they're ever going to happen. Maybe I feel artistic and creative, but I have the psychology of a failed artist who realizes maybe something like that's going on. I can create no world, so I would rather just destroy the whole world.
- 3.46 Since my call they notice, nobody pays attention to me. Nobody listens to me. I'm sending out my words, my call, and they don't give me any attention. So I feel alienated from them. Coursing dumb in magic whirl. My words just go out and dissipate into a world of nothingness. OK, so there's more Karl Marx's young poetry that goes on in this vein.
- 3.47 I just put it out there for reflection because one of the interpretations, philosophically and politically, is to say that, in many cases, people's politics are really a reflection or a rationalization of underlying psychological forces and psychological states. You can read off a person's psychology from the politics that they happen to advocate. This sort of young stuff from Karl Marx often feeds into that interpretation. It's the psychological, alienated perspective, revolutionary, anarchist type of person.
- 3.48 There's the activist version of Marx. Marx, now in the 1840s. In many cases, people will argue that Marxism, it says that it's a scientific, it's a materialistic, it's a fact-based understanding of the world. But some interpretations of Marxism want to say that it really is a religion, that he has a certain vision. Just as many people in religion will have a vision of heaven or of some beautiful place that they would like to exist, and they believe it in every fiber of their being, where that this is a true and beautiful world that I would like to come in.
- 3.49 But the problem is that the actual world we live in is so ugly and nasty and full of oppression and dog-eat-dog horribleness. So this gulf between the real world, as I see it, and this world that I would love to believe in, is too much. But nonetheless, I am

using my vision, my faith-held philosophy, to attack the world as it is and maybe to try to transform it in a way that is going to fit with my religious, essentially, vision of the world. So there are arguments and interpretations of Marx that want to say it's really a new kind of religion, but dressed up in materialist and scientific clothes.

- 3.50** Again, I just want to put that one out there. But there is a textual grain of evidence for this one worth reflecting on. Engels, in the year that the Communist Manifesto was going to be published, in 1847, they had a working draft. It was all ready to go to the publisher. But it's interesting that it was not originally called the Communist Manifesto. The working title was Confession of Faith. And so what Engels and Marx had done was consciously adopted a religious rhetorical labeling system.
- 3.51** We are doing a confessional, and that has a long history in the religious traditions. And what I am confessing is my faith, and that this document that we are going to publish and put out to the world functions in that same rhetorical vein as a confession of our faith. Here we have Marx, late in the year before the Communist Manifesto is published, saying, no, I think we should drop that title and instead substitute the Communist Manifesto. That is, of course, what happened.
- 3.52** But now the more complicated version of Marx, and this is the one that I want to focus on as a philosopher, that we're not giving a psychological interpretation, we're not doing a religiously-based interpretation, that we're going to take Marx seriously as a philosopher, and according to his self-description, as a certain kind of materialist, scientific, well-read in Hegelian philosophy, philosopher, figuring out the way the world works, and then offering prescriptions for how the world is going to go and how it ought to go, so that we can get out of what he takes to be a horrible capitalist modernity and into something closer to a kind of communism.
- 3.53** Now, it's important that, while Marx is known as a political revolutionary for inspiring political revolutionaries, he was an academic initially. He wanted to get an academic teaching job. He wanted to become a professor. Of course, everybody wants to become a professor. It's the best job of the world. While he was a student, he's studying at the University of Berlin. Berlin was a hotbed of Hegelian philosophy, with Hegelian study groups all over the place and different factions of Hegelianism at work.
- 3.54** And there, Marx states explicitly and realizes that if he wants to change the world economically and politically, he cannot approach economics and politics directly. It is through philosophy that the ultimate changes are going to occur. Politics, so to speak, is downstream from philosophy or it's applied philosophy. As he puts it in this quotation, "Without philosophy, nothing can or could be accomplished." That was his deep realization.
- 3.55** And while he was there, he joined the Young Hegelians; regular people get together, as philosophy and college students often do. A lot of drinking is involved and a lot of arguing about absolutely everything. And this is a sketch by Engels of one of the Young

Hegelian meetings. And as you can see, it's a relatively tumultuous affair about what the true interpretation of Hegel is going to be.

- 3.56** Now, some of the language that we have seen coming out of Hegel is the idea that history is not random, history is not cyclical, but rather, history is progressive, that we try, we being the world, so to speak, and then we learn a little bit, we become more self-conscious, and then we try again, and that improves, and ultimately, we are going to achieve a perfectible world. We are trying to do this. This is our thesis, but that will generate lots of conflict. But out of that conflict, we end up in a synthesis that is an improved state of the world.
- 3.57** Some Hegelian language that gets adopted explicitly by Marx, he's going to argue also that history is ultimately progressive. It's not random and it's not cyclical. It's going in a certain direction. If you understand the underlying principles by which the world is governed, you can understand why we are where we are and necessarily where we are going. All of that Hegelianism gets incorporated into Marxism.
- 3.58** The difference, though, is with respect to other philosophical components of your overall understanding of the world, human beings, and history. As we've seen in the case of Hegel, Hegel is ultimately a kind of religious man. He believes that there is a God or a world mind, and that God is trying to realize a plan in the world. Of course, he's using nations and states and particular powerful individuals like Julius Caesar and Napoleon to achieve those ends. But nonetheless, it is, as we say philosophically, an idealist understanding of history.
- 3.59** It is God and God's ideas that are prior, and they are realized out there in the world, and the world is just a reflection of God's ideas as they are working themselves out in history. So while Marx is going to believe that history has a plan and it's working it out, he wants to reverse that order and say instead, there is no God. He is going to be an atheist, but the world works through material processes. And so what it is is unformed or an earlier form of state of all of the matter in the universe. It is trying various combinations and experiments, but ultimately history is going to be worked out in a materialistic direction.
- 3.60** Hegel, and the Right Hegelians, the school that follow out of this, want to then argue that it is the nation that is the proper vehicle through which to understand what's happening in the world. It's not individuals, and it's not just disembodied God or spirit, but rather, God realizes himself through the various nations that he has selected at various points. And those nations, that language, that culture, that ethnicity, it has its own internal organic unity, and it's developing in a certain direction.
- 3.61** So what we will then get, on the Right Hegelians, is a more religion-friendly, but also nation/ethnic-friendly understanding of how history should be going further. The Marxists, by contrast, they're going to be materialists, but they're going to argue that the material forces that are most operative in society are economic forces, not legal

forces, not religious forces, not other ethnic forces, but rather human beings are divided into groups, collectives, according to their economic position in society.

- 3.62** Some people own property, some people don't own property, and they're forced, therefore, to work for people who don't own property. We have the distinction between the bourgeoisie, who are the property owners and the controllers of the property, and the workers who are selling their labor to the people who own the property, own the factories, and so forth. It's not nations in conflict with each other, it's economic classes that are in conflict with each other.
- 3.63** With respect to religion, we've seen in the case of Hegel, Hegel sees religion as essential to the state. It is a tool that the state should be using. It should be mandatory state-enforced church membership, and the state is using religion to perform a role in primarily morally educating the citizens so they know how to obey and to do their duty as the state requires. We don't have a separation of church and state. Rather, we have the church used by the state in the Right Hegelian.
- 3.64** The Marxists are materialists. As a result of that, they argue that religion is false. We invent religions. All of religions are invented, but they are invented primarily for people to improve their economic circumstances, and they are reflective of their economic circumstances. So back in the day when we were hunters, we had all sorts of animal gods, and we would engage in lots of religious rituals in order that the hunt be good. Or if we were living by the water and we made a living by fishing, we had lots of water gods and gods of the various animating spirits for the things that live out there in the ocean.
- 3.65** If we become agricultural, where our economic living is based on the soil, it's based on the weather, the sun, the rain, then in those cultures, we have gods and goddesses that are reflective of the Earth goddess and the rain god and so forth. And so from their perspective, there is no truth to religion, but rather, religion is developed in order to rationalize and support whatever our economic purposes are.
- 3.66** But what the argument here is going to be is that religion now is being used to support the capitalist state. So we have this Protestant religion, for example, after the Reformation, that has come to prominence and dominance in the most advanced capitalist states. It tells you that people are individuals, and if you work hard and you build up a lot of wealth, then that shows that God has favored you. And that your soul has been saved. Here we have a religion then, the Marxists argue, that has been developed in order to be reflective of the capitalist economic reality.
- 3.67** What about all of the poor and oppressed workers who are in the factory? Well, what the religion tells them is, things like, well, the love of money is the root of all evil, and rich people aren't going to go to heaven because it's going to be easier for the camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to get into heaven. So the religion is

crafted then as a set of stories by the capitalist class to keep the workers in their place so they don't get too revolutionary and so on.

- 3.68** So the Marxist analysis then is that religion is entirely false and used for whatever the dominant economic class is to protect its interests. So what we need to do if we're going to get to communism is abolish all of religion as an illusion and not allow it to interfere in the proper formation of the new society. So once again, we're not going to leave religion as a matter for individuals to decide for themselves. Rather, religion is a state matter, but religion is a threat to the state under the Marxist analysis, so we are going to abolish it.
- 3.69** Again, we have, in Hegel, in the Right Hegelians, this notion that we are making progress, and ultimately history is progressive, but it goes through relatively violent cycles. Alexander was a really brutal, killing-a-lot-of-people kind of guy. Julius Caesar was a great warrior. Napoleon, millions and millions of people are dead. So there's an acceptance that it's through violence, war, conquest, death, that we are taking society in the right direction.
- 3.70** And the Right Hegelians then are saying, as a matter of political philosophy, we're not seeking peace internationally. Instead, we should expect that we, if Germany is going to show the world its rightful place, become militaristic. It is power, army, force, violence, conquest that takes the world forward. So we should embrace that as our policy. And the Marxists are similar in that, that they argue that it is not going to be that we bring about communism by means of democracy and voting and people ultimately coming to respect each other's rights and be tolerant and so forth.
- 3.71** None of that nonsense that we hear from the English and the Americans who are starting to assert themselves to some extent, but rather it is conflict between all of the classes and that the conflict is always resolved brutally by means of a violent revolution, and it's not going to be any different in the capitalist stage. It's going to be the workers versus the capitalists, but ultimately the workers are going to be able to rise up because they have superior numbers and overthrow their capitalists in a violent revolution and then reorganize society in a communist fashion.
- 3.72** What we then have in Germany in the mid-century is the dominant philosophies and political philosophies. The Right Hegelians and the emerging Marxists are sharing several things, the general outlook, but also diverging from each other on several important things. I do want to emphasize that Karl Marx was an educated man, that I want to take him seriously, that he did end up writing a PhD dissertation in philosophy. He wrote it on metaphysics, on what's the fundamental constituent reality.
- 3.73** The title of his thesis was, again, a lot of words, The Difference Between Democritean and Epicurian Philosophy of Nature. That's to go back to Democritus and Epicurus, two ancient Greek philosophers, who he knows the traditions, he knows the metaphysical

arguments; and what they have in common is that both of them are non-religious materialistic philosophies, and this is incorporated into Marx at a fundamental level.

- 3.74** Now, we have the youthful Marx writing poetry. We have the middle years, young middle years, Marx writing Communist Manifesto, a more activist publication. By the time we get to the 1860s, 1867, Marx is mature. He's been thinking, he's been writing for a lot of years. He's been getting a lot of pressure from his publishers, finally, to get this manuscript out. And his magnum opus is then published, the first volume of it, rather, in 1867, and it's just called Das Kapital. In English, we just call it Capital.
- 3.75** What is the nature of capital? And then what specifically is the nature of capital-ism, where we take capital and what we understand capital to be, and we build our entire system, principally, on what capital is. Capital is an economics concept. It's resources that are applied for productive purposes. Excuse me. And so what we then have is a certain understanding of what resources are, what productivity is, and then an "ism" that says who should be organizing production, who should get the fruits of the productive process, and all of the things that are downstream from that.
- 3.76** All right, so Das Kapital, 1867. This is from the preface. "The work of the first volume of which I now submit to the public forms the continuation of my contribution to the Criticism of Political Economy, first published in 1859." This is an additional eight years, but it's also 11 years after the publication of Communist Manifesto that this contribution came out and now Das Kapital, and so on. These are ideas that have been in development for many decades now.
- 3.77** Political economy. Its economy is fundamental. Politics is a modifier with respect to politics. What we are now doing since we are in a capitalist political economy, we are critiquing it. Now, critique has several related meanings, but one of them certainly is criticizing, pointing out the negativity, understanding in order to criticize it, hopefully then to transform it into something else.
- 3.78** Now, capital, value, money, commodities, supply, demand, all of these concepts that are at the fore of economics, we need to get those sorted out. Here he's talking about the relationship between money and value. We have things like saying, well, this is a piece of money, and it might be a coin or it might be a piece of paper with some ink and some numbers put on it. We say, this is money and I can do various things. But what is the value of this?
- 3.79** In some sense, it can become mysterious fairly quickly because we can say, well, it's just a piece of paper with some ink on it. All by itself, it's not really worth very much. But if it has the word \$100 on it, or 10,000 Deutsche marks on it, suddenly it has great value. We get excited about it, and it seems like I have power to be able to do various things. How is it that just putting some ink on a piece of paper has transformed something relatively valueless into something that seems to have a lot of value and power?

- 3.80** That same piece of paper, for example, if instead of writing 10,000 Deutsche marks, I'd written 100 Deutsche marks, not very much of a material difference there, but somehow one is 100 times more valuable than the other. What is this value that we are talking about and what's its relation to money? "The value form, whose fully developed shape is the money form, is very elementary and simple. Nevertheless, the human mind has for more than 2,000 years sought in vain to get to the bottom of it all."
- 3.81** What he is saying here is, if you think about reflections on the economy and on the nature of commodities and money, you can go all the way back perhaps to Aristotle, who wrote the first treatise on economics and the huge amount of effort extended on trying to figure out what's going on with respect to business, the economy in various forms, up to and including Adam Smith; and now two generations, three generations later, nobody has gotten it right. Nobody has gotten to the bottom of it. It is now time for me to get this all straightened out.
- 3.82** Now, what is also characteristic of Marx is, he will use analogies, and the kind of analogies that an author will use is often interesting here. We saw Hegel talking a lot about mind and geist and spirit and the absolute and God and so forth. Marx, as a materialist, uses physics metaphors and biology metaphors. Here's one. If we want to understand the economy, we should understand it as a kind of body, as a kind of organism.
- 3.83** "Because the body, as an organic whole, is more easy of study than are the cells of that body, in the analysis of the economic forms, moreover, neither microscopes nor chemical reagents are of use. The force of abstraction must replace both." We have the economy as a whole, and in many cases, economists will talk about supply and demand and various forces and so forth. But to get down to the individual elements in that, the workers who are working and creating the value, it's very hard for the economists to do so. They more easily like the big picture, and they don't have the microscopes, so to speak.
- 3.84** "But in bourgeois society, the commodity form of the product of labor—or value form of the commodity—is the economic cell-form." By bourgeois society, we mean that's our contemporary society. The word bourgeois comes from "bourg", city, people of the city or people of the town. The economic powers are concentrated in the cities now, and the economically powerful people are the rich people by enlarging the urban city, they are the bourgeoisie, borrowing from the French word.
- 3.85** The contrast, though, is to the people who are working for the bourgeoisie, the workers in the factories who are individuals. Those individual workers are doing their appointed roles in this overall factory, which is part of an overall economy. They are the cells, by analogy, to the body. "The physicist," now we have a physics analogy, "either observes physical phenomena where they occur in their most typical form. In this work, I have to examine the capitalist mode of production and the conditions of production and

exchange corresponding to that mode. Up to the present time, their classic ground is England."

- 3.86** England is the most classic capitalist-developed nation. That's why we are in England. We now have Engels' work also in long-term support. "That is the reason why England is used as the chief illustration in the development of my theoretical ideas." In contrast to Hegel, who thinks Germany is the place where the future of the world is most going to be developed, and the Marxist analysis, it being economic, it's the most developed economic nation, England, that is going to show the world where its future is.
- 3.87** "A question of the higher or lower degree of development of the social antagonisms that result from the natural laws of capitalist production. It is a question of these laws themselves, of these tendencies working with iron necessity toward inevitable results." Just as in physics and, more complicatedly, in biology, once you realize the underlying forces at work, it might be electricity and magnetism, it might be gravity, it might be various chemical attractions of various sorts, we work these things out scientifically; then we can figure out how they are going to work in combination and on a larger scale.
- 3.88** It is time for economics to take its rightful place as a materialist science, just as physics, chemistry, biology, and mathematics are the sciences. The social antagonisms. What the argument here is that what has happened in the modern world is we have developed out of feudalism. Now, in feudalism, of course, we had the royals, we had the aristocrats, we had the clergy, we had the various skilled craftsmen in the various guilds. We had the peasants and the slaves. We had all of these classes. Each of them had their own economic interests. They were all in conflict with each other.
- 3.89** But what happened under capitalism was, as a result of its revolutions, is all of those different classes got resolved into two fundamental classes. That's a progress in the march of history, the development from feudalism into capitalism. But it's also enormously clarifying, because instead of thinking of five or six classes in conflict with each other, now we have two. We have the people who own property, the bourgeoisie, the capitalists, and we have people who don't own property. Those are the people who go to work for the big landowners, the big owners of the factories, and so forth.
- 3.90** Both of those classes have their own interests, and those interests are antagonistic to each other. What do the workers want? They want more money. What do the capitalists want? They want to pay the workers less money, so they are in direct conflict with each other. The workers might want various other benefits. That's to their interest. The capitalists say those other benefits are expensive. They might get you into thinking you are deserving of more than I want you to have. Then we have a conflict between the two classes.
- 3.91** We have the supply of labor, we have the demand of labor, and we can work out supply and demand laws as they are going to work out under capitalism. It's interesting

to see that Marx uses the language here of "iron necessity toward inevitable results." Once we understand the laws of economics, we can see that capitalism is going to develop in a certain direction. Just as we know, if you take one billiard ball and you bounce it off another billiard ball, if you know the mass of each of them, you know the gravitational field, you know their initial velocity, you can predict where both of those balls are going to go in the future.

3.92 Economics is a materialist science. We can do exactly the same. It's not the case that human beings have free will, that it's a matter of individual agents making their choices. You are born into a class. You're born rich or you're born poor, or you're born a worker or you're born someone who's able to hire workers. You are acculturated into that class. You have your certain interests in this economic system. You are going to behave, according to your class interests, in conflict with people in other class interests, and we can work out what's going to happen here. Society necessarily has to go in the direction that it goes.

3.93 "The country that is more developed industrially only shows to the less developed the image of its own future." Now, that then is to say, where England is going to go, all of the other countries in the world are eventually going to go there, but just on their own timeline. "In all other spheres, we, like all the rest of continental Western Europe, suffer not only from the development of capitalist production, but also from the incompleteness of that development." So capitalism has brought suffering overall. We don't believe in this myth of progress that the western liberals are trying to sell. This is overall improving despite the problems.

3.94 Rather, it is a suffering, and it is only because that suffering is not realized enough, but the suffering is in the cards, and as we develop further, we will be able to resolve at least some of those problems. "Alongside the modern evils, a whole series of inherited evils oppress us, arriving from the passive survival of antiquated modes of production." So it is still a little more complicated, Marx is wanting to argue.

3.95 England, for example, has gone significantly in a capitalist direction, but it still has a significant amount of carryover from feudal times. It still has king. It still has some aristocrats. It still has some deference that we're supposed to call people sir and lady and so forth. So it inherits some of the bad stuff from feudalism, added to all of the bad stuff that we think is coming out of capitalism as well. So we suffer not only from the living, but from the dead.

3.96 "Let us not deceive ourselves on this. As in the 18th century, the American War of Independence sounded the tocsin for the European middle class, so that in the 19th century, the American Civil War sounded it for the European working class." What we then have is, if we use then America, not the French model in this case, as a representative of the future developments, America being one of the first capitalist nations to come into existence, that sends a strong signal with respect to the older feudal regime.

- 3.97** America is saying to England, which is still under a monarchy, "We do not want to be under the monarchy anymore. We are going to go independent in this feudal direction." But America had its original sin of slavery. It did not get rid of the problem of slavery. But as America progressed, slavery becomes a more significant issue. And who are the slaves? Slaves are the workers. They're the ones who are doing the actual physical labor, and the slave owners are expropriating the excess profits in order to enjoy their lifestyle.
- 3.98** But as that dynamic progresses, America then overcomes that problem, gets rid of the slaves, it frees the slaves, it makes the slaves more equal. So we are going in a more progressive direction, even though it takes, again, violence and a lot of nastiness in order to get to the next stage. "In England, the process of social disintegration is palpable. When it has reached a certain point, it must react on the continent. There it will take a form more brutal or more humane, according to the degree of development of the working class itself."
- 3.99** What about individualism? Individuals are not fully real, and they certainly are not self-responsible agents the way now western liberalism wants to see it. Instead, individuals from the Marxist perspective are representatives of their class and paragons of their class interests. An important passage here. "Individuals are dealt with only insofar as they are the personifications of economic categories, embodiments of particular class relations and class interests."
- 3.100** You're not an individual with your own personal values, goals, dreams, and so forth. You are a worker or you are a capitalist, and as such, you inherit and embody your class interests, and your function in the economy is to further those, and so that is the proper level of analysis. "My standpoint from which the evolution of the economic formation of society is viewed as a process of natural history can, less than any other, make the individual responsible for relations whose creature he socially remains, however much he may subjectively raise himself above them."
- 3.101** Individuals are creatures of society and the society relations. A lot of times, the argument is going to be, the capitalist will say something like, "Look, I came from nothing. My dad was a peasant, but I left the farm, I went to the city, and I became a millionaire. See? Liberalism is true. Capitalism is true." Individuals, if they have their dreams, if they have their self-energy, if they take responsibility for their lives, you can make yourself into anything that you want.
- 3.102** Marx is arguing that is a myth. It's a mythos that is created by the capitalists to justify their own—individuals cannot see themselves as responsible for their relations. There are going to be some accidents that occur. Some people will become rich, some people will become poor, some people will defect from their class interests. But by and large, the statistical relations are dominated by the interests of the class that one is a relation to.

- 3.103** "In the domain of political economy, free scientific inquiry meets not merely the same enemies as in other domains. The peculiar nature of the material it deals with summons as foes into the field of battle the most violent, mean, and malignant passions of the human breast, the furies of private interest."
- 3.104** What we have here is then people are resisting the idea of reforming society, perhaps in a more socialistic direction, giving the workers more benefits, more wages, more legislation that's going to benefit the workers, perhaps bringing in a mild form of socialism or a strong form of socialism or even communism. What Marx is arguing is that it is private individualism, private self-interest that is the great enemy. That's the moral philosophy that needs to be challenged in part to go forward.
- 3.105** All right, I want to give one more quotation ending here. Again, using an American example, "Mr. Wade, vice president of the United States, declared in public meetings that after the abolition of slavery, a radical change of the relations of capital and of property in land is next upon the order of the day. These are signs of the time." So the modern world has been revolutionary, and it's been revolutionary in multiple dimensions and in increasing quickness time. Now is the time, 1860s, for the next significant revolution for the workers to rise up.
- 3.106** "They show that, within the ruling classes, even the ruling classes themselves, the rich capitalists and the politicians who are in bed with them, a foreboding is dawning that the present society is no solid crystal, but an organism capable of change, and is constantly changing." OK, I'll draw a line there on this text. The argument is going to be that there has been this enormous crystallization. We went from multiple classes competing with each other under feudalism to two great classes.
- 3.107** Right now, the capitalists own all of the property. As a result of owning all of the property, they're able to use their wealth to basically own the politicians, to own the law courts, to get legal rulings passed that advance their interest to keep the workers rather in their place. They're able to mount the right kind of sham elections, to get elected the politicians who are going to support their interests. So the capitalists are using their economic power to control the political system, including legislation and the law courts and so forth.
- 3.108** And so the argument is going to be extended into the next generation indefinitely. There is no way then, through the political process, the Marxists argue, for the workers who are poor, who have no property. They are living in substandard neighborhoods. They go to substandard schools, if they're allowed to go to school at all, to go through the political process and achieve representation of their interest and get through legislation what they are going to need.
- 3.109** At the same time, though, the workers are being brought into the factories. They are being aware of each other. They are starting to learn how to organize themselves because the capitalists want to organize everything in the factories. The workers are

then learning that they're all in the same boat. They are learning every time they are miserable and they ask for some improvement to their condition and being told no over and over again, that they're not going to, through a democratic political process, get what they need.

- 3.110 But at some point, they will be organized enough. They will realize they have the advantage of numbers because there's many, many, many of them, while there's very, very few of the rich capitalists. The famous phrase coming out of Marxism, "The rich get richer and the poor get poorer." The tendency of society, as an economic law, the Marxists argue, is that there will be more and more poor people, but organized more and more people with a self-consciousness of their terrible circumstance.
- 3.111 Fewer and fewer rich people who are more desperately using their wealth to control the political process and necessarily than having to be more and more oppressive of the poor workers, until the point is reached where the workers say, "We're not going to take this anymore." They will rise up and, in a violent revolution, overthrow their capitalist masters and institute a new kind of political system.
- 3.112 Now, I want to, with the death of Marx and the publication of this big work, just foreshadow a little bit what happens in Marxist political philosophy after Marx. As we've seen, Marx publishes in 1867 Capital. At this point, the American Civil War is over. The British Industrial Revolution is in full swing, and capitalism is at its most developed state and increasingly developed in America and in England. Ten years later, Engels publishes a very widely read account of Karl Marx, his idea, and his life.
- 3.113 Then I want to leave Germany and go further east to Russia, which is at this point still under the Tsars, perhaps one of the most feudal, backward nations, at least in the European consciousness at the time. But in 1887, a young man named Aleksandr Ulyanov was executed. He was a radical anarchist, socialist of some sort or other, but hated the existing Tsarist regime in Russia and was part of an assassination attempt on the Tsar. He was caught, tortured brutally, and sentenced to death.
- 3.114 He died, but he had a younger brother who was outraged by the death of his older brother, and that younger brother was Vladimir Ulyanov, who later took the name Lenin. Lenin, in part because of this and because of his readings of Marx and some of the other radical socialists and anarchists, came to hate the current regime and dedicated his life to advancing the cause of Marxism. He was exiled to Siberia as a young man for some of his activities.
- 3.115 He was forced to leave Russia for a while, spent some time in Switzerland, some time in Sweden as well, organizing, connecting with younger revolutionaries like himself, like Leon Trotsky and Joseph Stalin, and at some point in World War I, which had been going on for a few years in Europe, terrible war involving Russia as well.
- 3.116 The regime in Russia is weakened to the point, partly by its internal political problems, partly also as a result of the war. The young Marxists, who are at this point calling

themselves Bolsheviks, realize this is their moment. The Russian revolution with Lenin, Trotsky, and Stalin at the head comes into existence successfully in Russia. It becomes then the first serious experiment in applied Marxist philosophy in the early 20th century.

- 3.117 One more looking-ahead thing is, we've spent some time talking about Hegel and the split after Hegel between the Right Hegelians who were more nationalistic, more religious-friendly, but still advocating for militarism and power, and the Left Hegelians, better known as the Marxists, who are arguing, again, for violent revolution in order to take the world over. Russia, after the revolution, became the Soviet Union, the first significant communist state in the world.
- 3.118 The argument is also going to be that the Right Hegelians back in Germany, over the course of the next couple of generations, develop into the Germans who initiated World War I, into the Germans who initiated World War II. This is a philosopher, Richard Rorty, late 20th century, who, looking back, making a point about the importance of philosophy and how these ideas develop over time. If you want to understand war and why revolutions and terrible international nastiness often occurs, philosophy is a huge part of the answer.
- 3.119 And his pithy formulation is to say, at Stalingrad, which was one of the most brutal extended battles to occur—it occurred in western Russia when the Germans under the Nazis were advancing, trying to take over Russia, and the Russians under the Soviets, Stalin is now in power at this point, met into a terrible, terrible slugfest over the course of many, many months— Rorty's analysis is to say, you understand why the Russians and the Germans are fighting each other. You have to understand why the communists and the Nazis are fighting each other.
- 3.120 Understand why the communists believe what they do and why the Nazis believe what they do. You have to go back and understand Hegel versus Marx. We'll stop there for today

Lecture 4: Mill on Liberty

At a glance — Mill on liberty, centered on 1848 Britain.

- 4.1 I wanted this lecture to turn to 1848 and make England, and more broadly, Britain, the center of our attention again. England being the leading nation of the Enlightenment. The Enlightenment came into existence full flower in the 1700s. And the theme there is the light of reason, and reason being a property that every individual possesses. So we want to free people to be able to think on religious matters, artistic matters, scientific matters.
- 4.2 And we have the confidence that people can, free individuals, rational individuals, come to govern their own lives in all walks of life. It is the century of the Enlightenment in which we see the movements toward democratic and republican forms of government, the idea that we can extend freedom equally to women, that slavery is an affront to the freedom of some human beings, the slaves to live their own lives. And so a broad-based movement that encompasses religious freedom, economic freedom, scientific freedom, lifestyle freedom, and of course, political freedom.
- 4.3 Now, as we jump into the middle part now of the 1800s, 1848 or so, as we have seen in the previous lectures in this series, the Enlightenment and liberalism, the political philosophy of the Enlightenment that came into existence, have been significantly under attack. And so in this lecture, we want to give the liberals a chance to respond and to update the case for liberalism in the light of those attacks.
- 4.4 So we have seen, for example, the argument that the Enlightenment leads to the French Revolution, and the French Revolution was a disaster culminating in the regime of a military dictatorship under the guise of Napoleon Bonaparte, widespread destruction, death, war, and so forth. So the claim there is that the Enlightenment liberalism ultimately leads to a disaster.
- 4.5 And then we've seen Burke commenting on the French Revolution and rightly pointing out the excesses and the potential excesses there, arguing that the problem is that we're trying to be too rational, rationality unmoored from centuries of traditional experience. We're leaving individuals freedom and giving them too much freedom.
- 4.6 But really, from the Burkean perspective, we need to see liberty as a value, but pretty far down the list of important values. There's lots of other things that need to be in place politically before we consider granting individuals a certain amount of liberty space. But also arguing that individuals need a significant amount of constraint, not merely liberty, in order to function properly.
- 4.7 We have seen then also the rise of Georg Hegel as the most prominent philosopher in the German tradition, and Hegel arguing not for a kind of modern conservatism, as we see in Burke, but in a kind of nationalism; that nations are the organic unity, perhaps

even the God-chosen unity, entity, by which God is going to realize his purposes in the world.

- 4.8 Individuals are not free. Ultimately, individuals are tools of God. They are tools of their nation. They should subordinate themselves to the nation. And nations have this destiny, perhaps an organic destiny, perhaps a God-given destiny, to be realized. And now the Hegelian nationalists are arguing, it is the time for Germany to rise up and assert itself on the world stage. Again, profoundly anti-liberal.
- 4.9 We've also seen the rise of Karl Marx and Marxism as one of the leading forms of socialism, and socialism also strongly anti-individualistic, anti-liberal, seeing instead individuals as divided into collective groups that are in conflict with each other and that, ultimately, only a very violent revolution is going to be able to take society in the appropriate kind of direction.
- 4.10 What do the liberals then have to say in response to all of these anti-liberal attacks? And part of it is to say, well, look, it is messy. We are living in a revolutionary era. But now that we are more than a century into the Enlightenment, and many cultural and political experiments in liberalism, we should be able to make a strong case that liberalism has been enormously successful.
- 4.11 We have gone from eras of dramatic intolerance to widespread belief that individuals should be free in their own conscience to be able to think for themselves, particularly on religious matters and to take those into their own lives. We have eliminated and lessened significantly, in the more liberal nations, the censorship and the repression of ideas circulating in various forms—magazines, books, newspapers, and so forth. We've increased dramatically, in conjunction, of course, with the Industrial Revolution, the amount of information available for people to learn about the world, learn about values, and so forth.
- 4.12 Religious intolerance, in many cases, politically motivated, politically guided intolerance on religious matters that has plagued human beings for centuries, the liberals and the enlightened liberals are the ones who've argued, "Let's be reasonable about our religion. Let us understand that individuals need to think for themselves and tolerate each individual as they are on their own religious journey." We have seen a dramatic decline in the amount of religiously-based violence.
- 4.13 The idea that women should be able to get an education, start to control their own economic destiny, perhaps own property, and to vote in political elections, as we were starting to see happening in the 19th century; that women can and should be free, we've seen a dramatic increase and success in that area as well. Again, the result of the Enlightenment and its liberalisms.
- 4.14 The anti-slavery movement. Prior to the Enlightenment, almost nobody had a problem with slavery, and slavery was practiced by all cultures around the world back to time immemorial. And suddenly we start to realize there's something wrong with slavery.

Slaves are human beings. They have the same freedom rights that all human beings have, and that has been precisely in the Enlightenment nations. England, particularly at the forefront, Britain at the forefront in the anti-slavery movements that are in full swing by the time we get into the 1800s.

4.15 And the rising prosperity that is now measurable from poverty being a fact of life that 90-plus percent of the world's population lives in, even the British population. England is now, and Britain, the most wealthy nations in the world by a significant margin, to a large extent due to the liberalisms.

4.16 And peacefulness—war, war, war on all sorts of issues for the first time in history, where it seemed to be in a century where there's not very much war going on in Europe. In particular, we don't find very much war between the nations that are the more Enlightenment nations, the more liberal nations. It is the illiberal nations that seem to be the most conflict-driven.

4.17 Now, all of these are assertions and there are data that need to be investigated, but these are the kinds of claims that the liberals will then more confidently start to make once we have a century track record to base our assessment of the Enlightenment and its liberalism on.

4.18 Now, all of this, of course, is aided by the great achievements in modern science, what physics and chemistry and biology and mathematics are enabling us to do to understand the world. But we need to understand also that science requires a liberal ethos, the idea that I can think freely, that anybody can put any idea out there, that we're going to be able to experiment relatively freely and argue with each other.

4.19 And junior scientists, so to speak, can challenge the older, more established scientists and so forth in their field, that we're going to be able to challenge the great old books and famous figures, even from the ancient world, religious scriptures, the great Greek and Roman authors and so forth. Every individual is a free thinker in scientific matters, and it's going to be the better arguments that prevail and the better experimental results that are going to prevail. We have been able to see great progress as a result of that.

4.20 The Industrial Revolution. We've seen, again, huge outpouring in productivity, mass production of all sorts of goods that millions of people are now enjoying, putting medicine on a scientific footing, and mass-producing all sorts of medical technologies so that everybody can enjoy them. We start then to see better hygiene, better nutrition, better knowledge about both of these things, better ability for people to afford the things that are going to give them better medicine, better hygiene, better nutrition, and now life expectancy gains. England, and more broadly, Britain, are now the longest-living people in the world by a significant jump.

4.21 And all of those measurable achievements have happened in the last century, and precisely in the nation that is the most Enlightenment-oriented and the most liberally

oriented. So, data matters. And Britain then can fly its flag proudly in terms of all of these gains. Now, just to put some numbers to it, this is data, in part, driven. It's not just abstract theory, as we might have argued at the beginning of the Enlightenment. Here is a table showing education, a commitment to every person needs to be able to think for himself and increasingly herself, so that he or she can be a free, self-responsible agent in the modern world.

- 4.22** And so the most basic thing is to get basic education and certainly literacy. So this is a table, just basically one generation, 1818, a few years after the end of the Napoleonic Wars. Finally, that problem has been solved. England turns its attention to a lot of schooling. Over the course of the next 40 years, there is an increase of about 400% of the number of kids who are in school in England. Never happened before in human history, that rate of increase.
- 4.23** This is also an achievement of liberalism. This is parents freely deciding that their kids need to get an education. This is before the big movement of government schools and publicly funded and publicly mandated schools. This is lots of private schools all over Britain being founded, many of them quite tiny, but people committed to self-education and committed to having their children become educated. It is a liberal cultural movement.
- 4.24** To put in perspective the scale of the achievement, one more set of numbers here, somewhat anachronistic because we want to try to stay in the 1800s. But by the time we get to 1851, 66% of all British kids, or sorry, this is southern Britain, so England and Wales, 66% of all kids are attending school. And that is astounding in historical perspective. And partly the historical perspective is if we jump ahead one century to the 1960s and we look at the rest of the world, what we see is, in Africa, a century later, it's still only 34% of kids in school. In Latin America, it's about 60%, but it took Latin America an extra century to get to where England and Wales were a century previously.
- 4.25** Of course, the English numbers and the Welsh numbers, and more broadly, the British numbers, and much of the Western world, the number of kids are in school by the time we get to the 1960s is close to 100%. So these are claims. At the same time, worries. Now, after all of that good news or claims of good news, there are nonetheless many things worrying the liberal intellectuals of Britain in the 1800s.
- 4.26** From their perspective, there is a worrying rise in the conformity movements, urging that people be less individualistic and more conformist to various kinds of social trends. As we've seen, there are significant movements toward various sorts of illiberalisms, the rise of socialisms, the rise of all sorts of authoritarianisms, and calls for ideologically outright violence in order to solve various social problems. Now, in philosophical terms, we're going to be turning to John Stuart Mill, who emerges in the 1840s as the leading, not necessarily the leading British intellectual, but certainly in the top tier, but is

certainly the most articulate, deeply read, well-argued liberal philosopher of the century.

- 4.27** One of the things that already is apparent and worrying is the divergence of the philosophical and political trends between the Anglo-speaking world—that is to say, England, Britain more broadly, North America, and now perhaps Australia, New Zealand, the English-speaking world, the intellectual culture, the moral culture, and the political culture that has taken deep root in those nations, and what is going on on the continent, particularly the continent of Europe, just across the English channel.
- 4.28** So we've seen, for example, as France tried to enter into the modern world to get rid of its feudal monarchy and so forth, it was a complete disaster or an almost complete disaster, with tens of thousands, hundreds of thousands of people killed, the destruction of the rule of law, trust between human beings, the emergence of a military dictatorship with Napoleon Bonaparte, millions of people killed in Europe, and then after Napoleon is confined, France goes back to being a quasi-monarchy of various sorts and so on. So that's not a success story on the continent.
- 4.29** We have seen in Germany the rise of nationalism in the form of Georg Hegel becoming the most prominent philosopher there, with the argument that it's Germany's moment to rise up and assert its will on the world stage. And since this Germany is God's chosen nation, all other nations do not have rights and can be used for Germany's purposes. And again, a shocking degree of illiberalism there.
- 4.30** And we have seen the rise of various sorts of socialism, some of them less violent than others, but certainly the one that's going to become the most prominent with its call for violence and revolutionary violence in order to totally transform society in terms of a vision that Karl Marx and others have. The English liberal and Enlightenment tradition and the various continental traditions seem to be going off in very different cultural and political directions.
- 4.31** John Stuart Mill is a comprehensive philosopher. He wrote on all major aspects of philosophy. In our course here at Peterson Academy on Modern Ethics, we have an extended study of his Utilitarianism book, widely influential in moral theory. But here we are going to be focusing on Mill as a political philosopher. Now, 1848 was the year he published a work called Principles of Political Economy. It's an interesting amalgam of politics and economics as a unified discipline because all societies, of course, have a political regime. They have economic ways of doing things, and often those are blended in various degrees.
- 4.32** But here is Mill as a liberal philosopher, arguing in 1848 that already the track record is clear that if we have an economy that respects individual freedom to pursue one's life as a producer, as a consumer, as a trader and whatever you want, that we encourage people to be international traders even, to trade with other people all around the world, that this already is proving to be a solution to the problem of war that has been

devastating for human beings all over the world since time immemorial. Here's the quotation, which we can unpack.

- 4.33 "Commerce first taught nations to see with good will the wealth and prosperity of one another." We think of most of human history. This is my nation, that's your nation over there. We are rivals, maybe even worse than that. Maybe we hate each other because we have all kinds of history and we can't get past all of that. And so what naturally comes with that then is that I want to see you guys suffer. I don't want to see you guys do well. I want us to do well, but not you.
- 4.34 So there is, in economic terms, a zero sum. My benefit is going to be to your detriment and anything that benefits you, I'm going to see as being to my detriment as well. But by contrast, once we start to have free trade internally and then free trade internationally, then what starts to happen is we start to see each other as trading partners. And partnership is something that's mutually beneficial if it's done well. And we start to get past that natural rivalry or even many of the traditional historical hatreds.
- 4.35 "Before, the patriot wished all countries weak, poor, and ill-governed but his own. It is commerce which is rapidly rendering war obsolete." And that's interesting. Now, this is a generation after Napoleon has been defeated. But the French and the English have been at peace for well over a generation. And as the century goes on, the French and the English start to become allies with each other on the international stage.
- 4.36 So rather than the centuries of history between the French and English, which is rivalry, hatred, war, war, war, suddenly, they start to like each other and to trade with each other. And of course, they tease each other about all sorts of things, but it's relatively low-grade. Why is that? Because they are trading partners with each other.
- 4.37 The French recognize that the English are very good at producing certain sorts of things, and so those get transported across the Channel, and the French enjoy consuming those English products. At the same time, the French are very good, better than the English, at making certain sorts of things. And so they produce those and those go across the Channel and the English enjoy their trade goods. They see each other as trading partners.
- 4.38 You don't want to go to war then with the other country, because to the extent that you go to war with the other country, then those trade goods are going to be cut off. You're not going to be able to sell in that country. You're not going to be able to buy from that country. So all of the people in business and the big capitalists particularly, who are doing the international trade, they want peace between all of the trading nations.
- 4.39 It takes a while for people to realize that that's what is going on, that international peace requires that people interact with each other, willingly. And what goes on in a business transaction? Well, we negotiate with each other. I don't try to conquer you

and just take your stuff. I make you an offer. We negotiate, we shake hands, and that's a sign of a positive interaction between the two.

- 4.40 So there's a claim here that's being made. This is sometimes called the capitalist peace thesis, that the nations that are the most capitalist are the least warlike. Sometimes it's called the liberal peace thesis, capitalism being part of the overall liberal project, that is, the nations that are most freedom-respecting, that are going to be the most peaceful, in contrast to the nations that don't do very much by way of commerce. They are much more interested in conquest and plunder, rather than making stuff and trade.
- 4.41 "It may be said without exaggeration that the great extent and rapid increase of international trade"—this is the first great era of globalization that the world is now entering; international trade is becoming a serious thing—"is the great permanent security for the uninterrupted progress of the ideas, the institutions, and the character of the human race." Some big vocabulary there. Let's unpack that a little bit.
- 4.42 It's not only international trade that enriches us all because we get the best products from all over the world in our country, and the best products that our country makes get distributed all over the world, so we learn to like and respect each other internationally. But it's also ideas that then are transferred. The more that we are interacting with ourselves from all over the world, all of the best ideas from all over the world, we learn about them and we then say, well, let's take that idea and change our culture in the direction of using that new idea.
- 4.43 And of course, the ideas that we have that are really good ideas through the international trade networks, all of those discussions and negotiations and business meetings and so forth get communicated to other people, so our best ideas also get circulated around the world, and the world as a whole then starts to make progress.
- 4.44 Then that final point about the character of the human race. We become better human beings, partly because we are taught to deal with each other as traders, that I'm not going to simply try to conquer you and take your stuff. I have to make something. I have to make something that's good, that is attractive to you, and I have to convince you by showing you its merits and letting you test the product that it is, in fact, good for you.
- 4.45 I'm going to respect that you are going to make your own choice. Then, of course, when you make your own choice, if you choose to buy my product, I feel honored. I get some money from you; you get my good product. That's how civilized human beings deal with each other, and we become better as human beings to the extent we have these commercial networks.
- 4.46 Now, that's a positive from the liberal John Stuart Mill perspective. But he's afraid that the individualism that is essential part of the Enlightenment liberal project—as an individual, I'm responsible for my religious beliefs, for my developing my moral character, for the actions that I am engaged in; as an individual, I am responsible for

making my own way in the world, becoming an informed citizen and voting responsibly in the democratic political institutions— that that individualism is being undercut by many social, political, intellectual forces.

- 4.47 This is in part interesting because the English internationally are noted for their eccentrics, their unusual individuals, and for having a culture that tolerates all sorts of eccentricities, to go your own way on whatever issue it is that is part of your lifestyle. "In this age, the mere example of nonconformity, the mere refusal to bend the knee to custom, is itself a service. Eccentricity has always abounded when and where strength of character has abounded."
- 4.48 When you think of that, you want to have people of strong character. What is strength of character? It is the willingness to think for yourself what you believe, what you think is important, and in the face of all kinds of social pressures. People say, "No, you shouldn't think that, or we're going to punish you in various ways," socially, ostracism, mocking you, perhaps trying to take your stuff away from you by political means and so on.
- 4.49 Strength of character is being able to stand up for what you think is true and important, and nonetheless, then to be your own self in a world that wants you to conform to other people's expectations. "The amount of eccentricity in a society has generally been proportional to the amount of genius, mental vigor, and moral courage in which it contained. That so few now dare to be eccentric, marks the chief danger of the time." So he's worried that England and Britain more broadly is losing its respect for eccentricity and the theme of individualism.
- 4.50 Mill is one of the great liberal champions of free speech in our course on modern philosophy. His work, *On Liberty*, chapter 2, we spend a significant amount of time developing his very powerful case for almost unlimited free speech in the modern world. But what I want to do now is turn to the opening of his 1859 work, *On Liberty*, in which Mill is not simply focusing on politics and economy, what it takes to have a free polity, what it takes to have a free economy, and why those are ultimately mutually beneficial for society and the individuals in that society, but a broader statement.
- 4.51 What about liberty, not not only in those areas, but liberty in scientific matters, liberty of thought, liberty of thought on religious matters, and so forth? So as we like to do, I'm going to turn now to the text and excerpt what I take to be some of the key passages. John Stuart Mill, as I sometimes like to joke, is a brilliant writer, but he writes in 19th-century British style, with long, complicated, nonetheless thought-compressed sentences. And the way I sometimes put it is to say that, for British writers of the 19th century, why say something in 10 words when you could say it in 30? What we'll need to do is break the sentences down to their digestible components.
- 4.52 All right, so this is a book, and it's a relatively short book, *On Liberty*, in its various aspects, but he's trying to make a more general case for liberty as the foundational

value in a society. Not one value among many. There are other important things in society. Not one among many, but further down the list, as we find, say, in Burke, conservatism, but rather the fundamental social value, and then by extension, the basic political value that governments should be charged with respecting and protecting.

- 4.53** So the famous opening, "The subject of this essay is not the so-called liberty of the will." Do I have free will to make my own choices, or am I pushed around by biological, environmental, or perhaps divine forces beyond my control? Do I have agency over my own mind, over my own body? That's not what we're talking about here. Rather, the liberty we are talking about is a social and political liberty. "The nature and limits of the power which can be legitimately exercised by society over the individual."
- 4.54** We have a society which is comprised of various individuals, and we want to then talk about society and society's representatives or society's embodiment in various institutions, particularly governmental institutions. What is their authority over the individuals who make them up? Most political philosophies will say they have at least some, and some, as we see, say, well, they have virtually unlimited authority over the individuals.
- 4.55** But addressing this question directly, "What is the nature of the power that can be legitimately exercised?" When we say society should have power, when we say government should have power, what are we saying? What kind of power are we talking about? Intellectual power, moral power, physical power? That needs to be sorted out. And what is the limit to that power?
- 4.56** Now, this is, of course, a deeply liberal question, and Mill is now two generations after, say, the American Revolution, where that question had, in a broadly liberal framework, been taken up. And the American Constitution was saying, yes, we are going to delegate certain powers to the government, but we are going to put severe limits on that power. This is what that power can be used for and only for that power.
- 4.57** And since we know historically that governments have often abused power, sometimes abuse their power terribly, we're going to take the limited powers that we give to government and divide them up into different subpowers. There's the legislative power, there's the executive power, there's the judicial power, so that no one part of government has too much power. We're going to put them in tension with each other. We do want them to work together, but also we want them to be a check against each other. We're going to take power, particularly government power, very seriously and on principle, specify what those limits are.
- 4.58** Now, that has not made its way significantly to the continent, and the understanding of those principles are, to some extent, shaky, even in Britain, the original home of liberalism, from Mill's perspective. Now, Mill is a great historian as well as a great philosopher, and one of the ways he makes his arguments is by putting what we are doing now in a historical context. We are liberals, and we note, though, that this

conflict between liberty and authority—and we have seen societies that have said individuals should have no liberty. We are slaves of the state. We are slaves of the powers that be.

- 4.59 Carving out some exemptions to that over the centuries has been a long, hard-fought battle. Mill wants to rehearse this history so that we understand how we got where we are and where improvements, nonetheless, are still necessary. "The struggle between liberty and authority is the most conspicuous feature in the portions of history with which we are the earliest familiar, particularly in that of Greece, Rome, and England."
- 4.60 Here he is singling out Greece as a reminder that these are the first city-states in history to experiment seriously with democracy. And democracy is the idea of, to break the concept down, power to the "demos", to the people. The people have their own power, and government should be an exercise in self-government.
- 4.61 We should be running the government, participating in it, and all of the democratic institutions of being able to run for office, anyone being able to criticize the current holders of political office, to have widespread debates about all of the issues, leaving it up to individuals to make up their own minds, what they think is true, to be able to cast a vote that has some serious meaning in fair elections— all of those institutions first worked out in Greece, but carved out against centuries of clearly antidemocratic and undemocratic political institutions.
- 4.62 Rome is then singled out, particularly the first few centuries of Rome. We talk about the Roman Republic before it became an imperium. And republic, breaking it down, "res publica", the rule of the public. So again, the public has the power, and different segments of the public have different powers, and those powers are kept to some extent in tension, but everybody has the liberty to participate in the process and to exercise meaningful political power.
- 4.63 And then the case of England, from Magna Carta on through the Glorious Revolution in 1688, on through the 1700s, in which liberty, liberty of conscience, liberty of speech, anti-censorship, strengthening the democratic institutions of Parliament in Britain, is a story that everyone should be familiar with.
- 4.64 But, Mill then interjects, "In old times, the contest was between subjects, or some classes of subjects, and the government. By liberty, was meant the protection against the tyranny of political rulers. The rulers were conceived as in a necessarily antagonistic position to the people whom they ruled. They consisted of a governing one, or a governing tribe or caste, who derived their authority from inheritance or conquest, who at all events did not hold it at the pleasure of the governed."
- 4.65 Here we think of, say, a classical feudal regime. I will be the king in this political regime, and you are my subjects. You're not yet citizens in the modern world. You are subject to me. I am the one with the power. I am the one with the authority. I am the one with the sovereignty. And on this theory, whatever I grant to you, whatever freedoms I grant

to you, I grant to you as a privilege, not as a right, but as a privilege that I can revoke at my will.

4.66 And the argument then, to say that that is not the appropriate way to do government, that whatever privileges, your zones of freedom that you now have, they should not be privileges granted by someone who has that authority. Those are things that should inhere in you. If you are the people and I am the king, you have a right of some sort to those, not something that I can take away from you.

4.67 The assumption here then is that this has to be fought for as a matter of principle to generate a zone of liberty against a being, me, the king, who is seen as being in an antagonistic position with respect to that liberty. And so the history then, in the case of English history, is various sorts of privileges being transformed into liberties by right or liberties by political custom in England over the course of many centuries. And it's a largely piecemeal process.

4.68 "The aim, therefore, of patriots was to set limits to the power which the ruler should be suffered to exercise over the community, and this limitation was what they meant by liberty." Liberty is limitations on the power of the government, the king, the aristocracy, whatever the variation is. "It was attempted in two ways. First, by obtaining a recognition of certain immunities called political liberties or rights, which it was to be regarded as a breach of duty in the ruler to infringe."

4.69 They now become rights. They're not privileges that I have granted to you. If I am the king and I own all of the property, but you do a nice service to me and I grant you your own fiefdom, and I say, "This is yours, you are now the lord of whatever it is," there's a difference between that being a fief that is granted to you as a privilege that I can take back from you at any time, versus saying, "This is now your property by right, and I have no right as the king to take that away from you for whatever."

4.70 Such that, if we find that we have a monarch who is abridging these various liberties and rights that have been carved out, the citizens have the right of rebellion, in which, "if he did infringe, specific resistance or general rebellion was held to be justifiable." When can people rise up against their king or against their feudal lord? On the old systems, never. You are totally a subject. You owe duty and obedience. Now you are a being who has rights, liberties on principle, that are outside of the zone of the king's purview.

4.71 If I try to step outside of my purview and override your rights, you have the right then to protect yourself, to rise up against me, to get rid of me, and to put perhaps in power another king. Long thought. "We get into the modern world, though," Mills then says. We start to forget some of that ancient history. We start to think of the government not as something that's over and above us.

4.72 But we start to now, as moderns, think of the government as something that we have created, that its job is to protect our rights and liberties, and that the people who are

running the government are not some exalted class appointed by the gods, but rather people who have been selected by us through various democratic institutions. So now the government is us. We are one with the government, and the government is the servant of the people, but it's also constituted by a subsection of the people. And so we stop thinking of the government as opposed to our liberties, but rather as a servant of our liberties. And that's progress, but it brings with it a danger.

4.73 "In that way alone, it seemed, could they have complete security that the powers of government would never be abused to their disadvantage." Why would we think of the government as a threat to us anymore in the modern world since it is government of the people by the people, and the people who are running the government are just one with the people. We're not thinking of them in that alienated way now.

4.74 "What was now wanted was that the ruler should be identified with the people, that their interest and will should be the interest and will of the nation. The nation did not need to be protected against its own will. There was no fear of its tyrannizing over itself. This mode of thought, or rather perhaps a feeling, was common among the last generation of European liberalism in the continental section of which it apparently still predominates." So a small number of liberals still on the continent.

4.75 All of that gets thrown out the window during the French Revolution. And after the French Revolution, after Napoleon, we are starting to see an increase of democratic republics as the 18th century goes on, and here we are. Now, the problem is this. What happens, though, when we take seriously the democratically liberal idea that everyone is going to participate in the government. Of course, we're all individuals. We're going to have lots of different ideas about what the right policies are going to be and who the best politicians are, whom we should be electing.

4.76 How are we going to say that we, the people, are one and we have a common set of interests and a common idea? It doesn't seem very realistic that's going to happen. So we say what we need to do then, as a second-best solution, is, since we're not ever going to have unanimity, is vote. And whoever gets the majority of the votes, that will be the set of people or the party that has the power for the next chunk of time.

4.77 But that power that they have is now not reflective of the interests of the whole. It is reflective only of the interests of the majority. And yet the power of government, even in liberal societies, is quite a lot of power. What about the liberties, the freedoms, and the interests of the minority of people? There's a new form of tyranny that can come into existence. It's not one guy, a king, with the power who can do what he wants with all of the subjects. It's not a small group of people, the aristocrats, who have all of the power, and they are the minority, but they have power over the majority of people.

4.78 Even if we take that next step and say, now we are going to give power to the majority in every election cycle, now the majority of people have power over the minority. And

what if they choose to abuse that power? That's a new problem for democratically liberal institutions today. So what is "the will of the people"?

- 4.79 When we talk about self-government and so forth, "the will of the people, moreover, practically means the will of the most numerous or the most active part of the people, the majority, or those who succeed in making themselves accepted as the majority. The people, consequently, may desire to oppress a part of their number, and precautions are as much needed against this as against any other abuse of power."
- 4.80 How do we, liberals, who think, yeah, we want to have democratic, republican self-government, people participating. Ultimately, we are the sovereigns. And we think people should have their individual freedoms and the right to go and to act freely to pursue their interests. We do all sorts of political reforms, but we now run into a new problem. But Mill, following Alexis de Tocqueville, is going to call the tyranny of the majority, and that is a kind of abuse of power. Here is the phrase.
- 4.81 Suppose the majority of people in one country are of this religion. Now there's a variety of other religions that are a religious minority. The party and the politicians who come into power are members of the majority religion. Well, they now have the potential to start taking away the religious freedoms of those in the minority. What do we know about human psychology when it comes to religious matters? What do we know about the entire history of the world when it comes to religious matters and when that is conjoined with political power?
- 4.82 Suddenly, we think, oh, we're being democratic, or we're going to have a democratic tyranny with respect to religious minorities. Of course, it's not just religious minorities, it's going to be minorities on all of the other issues in life. " Society can and does execute its own mandates, and if it issues wrong mandates instead of right or any mandates at all in things which it ought not to meddle, it practices a social tyranny more formidable than many kinds of political oppression."
- 4.83 If we think, as moderns typically do think, and certainly modern liberals, that religious freedom, probably the first major freedom that was fought for in the modern world, is sacrosanct and should never be meddled with by the government, we don't yet have a clear solution to this problem to the extent that we think only of government as the will of the people, the expression of the people, embodied by the people, and it's the majority rule principle of democracy.
- 4.84 But it's also not merely a political problem because we know that human beings are individuals, but they're also social animals, and they're participating with each other in all kinds of units, family units, business units, sporting associations, and so forth. That if we don't have an ethos of respecting minorities and respecting individuals going their own way and being eccentrics, that in addition to political power of the majority, the majority of people in any group can exert various kinds of psychological and social

pressures on individuals from their perspective who seem to be deviant in the minority, going the wrong way.

- 4.85 That if we're going to have a healthy liberal society, we need not only to have political limits to what the majority can do to the minority, but a social ethos in which we're going to be tolerant of individuals and minorities who are going their own ways on with respect to their own life. Here we might think, for example, where, here's Mill's line.
- 4.86 He says, "In a society, liberal society, as we are social beings, we have—" so, it's not the government is just the king in some other faraway part of the world, the government is my local people in my local government and my community and the state level and the federal level. There's lots more ways in which political authorities can affect the individual.
- 4.87 So here, just by analogy, if we think of a small town, one of the things that people don't like about small towns, some people love small towns, but people who get out of them is, they say, everybody knows everybody's business. There's no privacy in a small town. And the gossip mill—you do anything, and suddenly everybody in the small town through the gossip mill knows everything that is going on that I have done.
- 4.88 And then they have various small-town ways of letting you know that they know. And people then start to feel like, "I need to conform to what is going on in this small town, the small-town ethos. It's hard for me to be myself. I need either to go out into the wilderness or I need to escape into the big city where I can be a free and private individual and so on." So that is a fear and a worry that political liberals need to think about as well.
- 4.89 "Protection, therefore, against the tyranny of the magistrate," that is to say, the king or the aristocrat or the lord or the mayor, "is not enough. There needs to be protection also against the tyranny of prevailing opinion and feeling, against the tendency of society to impose by other means than civil penalties its own ideas and practice. There is a legitimate interference, a limit rather, to the legitimate interference of collective opinion with the individual independence, and to find that limit and to maintain it against encroachment is as indispensable to a good condition of human affairs as protection against political despotism."
- 4.90 So even if we think, for example, of a family unit, suppose you have the mom and the dad and four kids, and they have conversations about all sorts of issues around the dinner table, there's a difference between a family unit in which each kid and each parent knows that he or she is free to say what they think, to defend their position, to disagree with mom on religious matters, to challenge dad's idea about some political process, or if you're the younger sibling, to challenge your older sibling and to disagree.
- 4.91 They're going to have lots of discussions, and we're going to hopefully learn from each other, and we'll change our minds and so forth. But ultimately, each member of the family has this zone of freedom, and that's going to be respected and tolerated. The

younger ones are going to be, from the beginning, encouraged to think for themselves and speak their own mind in a respectful way. Respectful means you're also allowing the other members of the family to do the same thing.

4.92 Versus a family unit where there's lots of different kinds of power, even in a family, where I might be the dad, and I make it clear in the family that there is one set of views on religious matters, one set of views on political matters, one set of views about what career you are going to pursue when you grow up, whom you are going to marry, and that is enforced also by the mother, or maybe the mother is the power in the family and not the father.

4.93 That is an entirely different social regime. There might not be any overt coercion. It might not be that the father is hitting the children or spanking the children or confiscating their stuff. But it is a matter of creating a certain social environment in which a tyranny is being exercised. It's not only political liberalism, social liberalism that we need to make clear.

4.94 After all of that, by way of preamble, is there a way in which we can, in principle, specify the limits of society over the individual, whether it be a family unit, a business unit, a religious unit, a political unit, or whatever? Here is Mill's effort. "The object of this essay is to assert one very simple principle, as entitled to govern absolutely the dealings of society with the individual in the way of compulsion and control, whether the means used be physical force in the form of legal penalties, or the moral coercion of public opinion."

4.95 Where do we draw the line? Now, physical coercion, we know that everything the government does when the government passes a law, it is backed up by the police. You break the law, the police come, and the police are entitled to use physical force against you. They will have a baton, they will have handcuffs, they will typically be larger, trained in physical coercion techniques, compared to the average citizen. Sometimes there's one or two of them. You break the law, you are arrested by force.

4.96 You are perhaps taken to jail and you are confined by force. You are taken into a court of law where there are bailiffs present, and they also are armed. You are found guilty, you are sent to prison, or some of your property is confiscated. That force, what is the limit? Where we say you cannot, government, use force against an individual. These things, yes, here, no.

4.97 And the moral coercion of public opinion, where we outnumber an individual, the individual is saying or doing something that we don't like. We don't physically coerce that person, but we use all kinds of verbal and ostracism and other kinds of social pressures to get that individual to conform. Where do we draw that line? "That principle is, that the sole end for which mankind are warranted, individually or collectively, in interfering with the liberty or action of any of their number, is self-protection." Pausing on that one. This is the big gun.

- 4.98** Each of us has our own life. My life is my sovereignty. I am sovereign over my own life. I have sovereignty over my mind. I have sovereignty over my actions. A healthy society is going to respect every individual's sovereignty in those respects. When we come together in social units, say, a man meets a woman and they start to date, it has to be that each is a sovereign who has chosen, so to speak, to come together on the date.
- 4.99** We're going to form a religious institution. I want to do my religion this way. You want to do your religion that way. We discuss and we find commonality. Let's do religion together. We have freely chosen to do so. In commerce, I have made this, you have made that. I like what you've made, you like what I've made. We see the possibility of a trade. We come together, we negotiate, we exchange voluntarily. In all walks of life, including sports and other things that we do, we start from the presumption that individuals have sovereignty and maximum sovereignty.
- 4.100** At what point, though, does my freedom to think and act as I want justify you in stopping me from acting that way? And Mill's answer is self-protection. If what I am doing interferes with you and your life projects to the point where you're not able to do your life project, then you have the right to stop me by force.
- 4.101** So if, for example, we say, people should be free to do their religion as they want, as opposed then I believe something religious that you think is completely crazy, maybe you think it's even completely immoral, that it's going to lead to the damnation of my soul or whatever, and you want to interfere with me, to stop me from, say, going to that church or going to that mosque or going to that synagogue.
- 4.102** The only time you would have the right to do any of that is if my doing, my religion, my way, is preventing you from doing your religion your way. If what I'm doing is not preventing you from thinking and engaging in religious practices as you decide you want to do, you have no proper justification for interfering with me. If you want to interfere with me, you have to interfere with me as you would interfere with a free individual. Give me a counterargument. Point out my mistakes, and I might listen to you, but ultimately, I am sovereign, you are sovereign.
- 4.103** Part of life is making things that we can consume. If I want something that you have made, I have to make you give it to me voluntarily. If I steal from you, well, I'm interfering with your ability to control your own life. If I start stealing your property, at that point, I am harming you. And in self-protection, you can stop me from being a thief. You can exert physical force upon me.
- 4.104** But if I'm making a living doing some way and it's not interfering with your making your living the way you want to make your living, even if you disapprove of the way I'm making my living, if it's not harming you and interfering with your ability to do your economic life, you have no justification for interfering with me. That's where we're going to draw the line.

- 4.105 "That the only purpose for which power can be rightfully exercised over any member of society, of a civilized society, against his will, is to prevent harm to others. His own good, either physical or moral, is not a sufficient warrant." Now, this is interesting. So as I am doing things that are harming you in the course of your life pursuits, you want to do religion a certain way, but I kidnap you and I want to coerce you and torture you, even as has happened many times in human history. Well, that's obviously an interference with your liberty. I should not be able to do so.
- 4.106 But what if I am not harming some other person over here in religion? Suppose I'm doing something in religion that is harming myself. So we say, I don't know, we make some an argument like this. I'm just going to make up a religious practice, that we can make an argument that, in order to look after myself, I need to have food, take in nutrition. And in order to take in food and nutrition, I need to have teeth that can chew up the food so that I can swallow it. But suppose I come to believe in some religion; I believe that by pulling out all of my teeth and not using any antiseptic afterwards, I'm going to get in good with the gods that I happen to believe in.
- 4.107 Now, you, objectively and scientifically, would say that's crazy. That's ridiculous. That's a self-harm. You should not be able to do so. But if I'm in possession of my faculties and I've come to believe in something that is going to be self-harming, it's not interfering with your practice of your religion. You can try to argue with me, but you cannot prevent me from pulling out my own teeth in this severe example.
- 4.108 If I'm going to engage in a business practice that is going to lead me to bankruptcy, and you know I'm making a stupid decision, you can argue with me, you can present me with facts, but you cannot stop me from making stupid business decisions. If you think I am dating the wrong woman and that she is going to make me miserable because you know things about her that I don't know and I'm in the raptures of infatuation and so forth, you can reason with me, you can give me evidence about her moral character, but you cannot prevent me from engaging in self-destructive dating behavior.
- 4.109 This is a very strong liberal principle, and Mill wants to argue that only to the extent that we have widespread agreement with respect to that principle will we have a healthy society. And one final concluding remark from the text here. This is a strong doctrine of individualism, that life is about self-responsibility, self-control, self-regulation. Of course, life has risk, we will all make lots of mistakes. We will get lots of things correct. In various aspects of our lives, we will succeed. In other cases, we will lose. Sometimes we will win, and sometimes we will be failures. That is part and parcel what life is all about and what makes for a meaningful life. That's what we need to respect socially and politically.
- 4.110 What this means is that "the only part of the conduct of anyone for which he is amenable to society is that which concerns others. In the part over which merely concerns himself, his independence is of right absolute. Over himself, over his body and mind, the individual is sovereign." Sovereignty rests with the individual, and that can

never be taken away. In contrast to the kind of, say, modern conservatism that we saw in Burke, where Burke was arguing that we are part of a society, and a society perhaps can be conceived of as an organic whole, and we exist to do our part in society.

- 4.111** We're not sovereigns as individuals. It is the society that is the sovereign. We are part of the past. We are part of the future. It's one large social organism. And what liberties and sovereignties I've had are more or less delegated from the being that has the real sovereignty. Mill is disagreeing as a liberal with that conservative thesis. Against the nationalism of someone like Hegel that says, again, it is the nation that has sovereignty, and that sovereignty is delegated to it or an embodiment of God, who is the ultimate sovereignty, working through nations.
- 4.112** The individual does not have sovereignty, rather the individual is to serve and do his part in the nation seeking its destiny. Mill, as a liberal, rejecting that formulation of nationalism. The kind of socialism, particularly the Marxist, communist form of socialism that says you are not an individual with agency, but rather you are a part of a class, an economic class, and that to the extent that you have obligations is to join with the other members of your class against the competing classes in order to march history in the appropriate political direction. Mill disagreeing fundamentally also with the socialisms. It is individualism and liberalism.
- 4.113** I want to just add one more point here. This individual liberalism, this will be a point for side reflection on your own time here. Individual liberalism has a tradition already, going back to John Locke and others at the end of the 1600s, of saying, yes, we believe in individuals, fundamentally, and that individuals have these exemptions from the power of the government. You have your life, you have your liberty, you have your property, you have your conscience, and you have these as a matter of natural right.
- 4.114** That, independently of any consequences, it's the nature of individuals to have certain inalienable rights that hold universally and more or less absolutely. For philosophical reasons, Mill disagrees with the notion of rights. If we're going to talk about rights, we're not going to talk about rights in that fashion. He is a utilitarian, and so I would again mention, we have, in the modern ethics course, a whole session devoted to Mill on utilitarianism.
- 4.115** The idea of utilitarianism, in short, is not that individuals have a prior right that must be respected, but rather in recognizing freedoms and liberties that we are going to respect that all individuals have, it's because of the consequences that we're going to lead to. We think that individuals who are free are going to do better in their own lives. Those societies are going to be better, in contrast to a position that says people have certain rights, whether those rights get exercised with respect to good consequences or not. It's a different argument, but it's worth noting here for further study.
- 4.116** "It is proper to state that I forego any advantage which could be derived to by argument from the idea of abstract right, as a thing independent of utility. I regard

utility as the ultimate appeal on all ethical questions." All right, this is Mill's introduction, the introductory chapter 2, On Liberty. It is a multi-chapter book, and he goes on to consider then various dimensions of liberty— liberty of speech, liberty of conscience, liberty of lifestyle.

- 4.117 And encouraging eccentricity and people being willing to experiment in their lifestyles and not just dress and listen to music and so forth the way their parents taught them to, to strike out on your own and put together your own meaningful package of life, as well as much history of the various battles over liberty with respect to censorship, with respect to the arts, the sciences and religion and so forth.
- 4.118 It is the most significant work in liberalism in the 19th century, and he is offering it as an update to the kinds of arguments for liberty that have been developed during the Enlightenment, but also against the kinds of anti-liberal arguments that are becoming more prominent, certainly on the continent and even in England, as Hegelianism, Marxism, and various other forms of illiberalism are resurgent.
- 4.119 In conclusion, let me just come back to some dates here. 1859 is a banner year in publishing. Mill's On Liberty comes out. Charles Dickens published A Tale of Two Cities. Florence Nightingale publishes a work on nursing, turning nursing into a profession. Samuel Smiles, a self-help book that went through multiple editions, the idea that you can take charge of your own life and improve your life, also 1859.
- 4.120 Certainly also 1859, an important year for biology and evolutionary theory. It's the year that Darwin publishes Origin of the Species. Origin of the Species is a work that is, not only one that takes the world of science by storm and the world of religion by storm, but it also affects deeply political philosophy. In the next lecture, we are going to turn to pragmatism, which is an American phenomenon, first and foremost, but it is a philosophical approach that, to a large extent, is influenced by evolutionary biology and evolutionary thinking.
- 4.121 And as we are going to be jumping across the ocean to America, America is now, by the time we get into the latter part of the 1800s, 100 years old. Up until this point, it has not been a first-rank nation in terms of political power or economic might or as an intellectual and cultural nation. But as it grows and is growing rapidly, it is starting to assert itself. And one way in which it asserts itself is by means of its intellectuals and pragmatism, to which we will turn in the next lecture, is illustrative of the American staking out its stage or its place, rather, on the world stage.

Lecture 5: Pragmatic Democracy

At a glance — Pragmatic democracy in 1900 America.

- 5.1 All right, let's go to the year 1900 and America. Exciting times with the turn of a new century, of course, but also a sense that the new world is coming into its own in contrast to the old world, both Europe, Africa, Asia, that what has been happening in the new world, in the United States in particular, has been revolutionary, and there is, so to speak, a new player on the world stage, economically, politically, culturally, and intellectually.
- 5.2 We march through the centuries. We might say the 1500s were Portugal's century, and then the Spanish century, and the French century, and the British century. And Germany, certainly in the 1800s, has become a rising power, politically, economically, intellectually as well. But perhaps the 20th century is going to be America's century. In this lecture, we want to turn to America's contribution to political philosophy. The philosophers who are most associated with putting America on the political philosophy map are two pragmatist philosophers.
- 5.3 We're going to be focusing on William James and John Dewey. Now, pragmatism is another "ism", and it's often closely associated with progressivism. You can see these two as siblings, pragmatism being the more fundamental philosophy, and we have some coverage of pragmatism in our postmodern philosophy course here at the academy. And progressivism is the social and political side of the equation, or the, mixing my metaphors again, the other sibling; take the underlying pragmatic philosophy and apply it to social and political matters.
- 5.4 Now, the name pragmatism is self-consciously chosen by the early thinkers in this tradition. The earliest thinkers in this tradition are all Americans. While they are influenced, some of them, in different phases by some of the European traditions in philosophy and political culture, they also see themselves as weary of the old ways of doing philosophy, the old ways of doing theory and so forth.
- 5.5 And that, with what seems to be often the American stereotypical way of doing things, what we are interested in is not ideas for their own sake or abstract speculation or coming up with pure and perfect theories and not paying too much attention to their practical consequences. Rather, what philosophy should be about, what political philosophy should be based in, is reality, practical, workable reality. And so what we're more interested in when we're thinking about various kinds of ideas is not so much, are they true, but do they work?
- 5.6 If I take this idea, of course, I can step back from looking at the world and consider arguments back and forth for it and try to construct an internally consistent model in my head. But the pragmatic is to say, what we need to do is to take that idea and put it to the test, put it to the practice, and we'll see how it works out. And if the working out

seems to be going in the right direction, then we will accept those ideas. So this distrust of theorizing, more emphasis on practicality.

- 5.7 And often the phrase that is used is, what is the cash value of this idea? That's a phrase popularized by the pragmatic philosopher William James. So we have an idea, and we're not so much interested. Is it true? Is it good? Is it beautiful? Can it be made perfect? But the way Americans with their commercial mentality will think, if I put this idea into practice, what cash will it generate? What difference will it make in practical living affairs? And so pragmatism then is a philosophical orientation away from abstraction toward practicality, away from speculation to doing.
- 5.8 And often our ideas and our theories are going to be messy and not very perfect. But if they get the job done in the real world, that is sufficient. That's what we are looking for. Now, one interesting application of this is also developed by William James, a very famous essay that he wrote called *The Will to Believe*, and it's worth reading if you're interested in the philosophy of religion.
- 5.9 But there we see, as part of James' exploration, the working out of religion and whether one should be religious or not, not in terms of arguments for and against the belief in a God or any particular religion, or trying to do serious historical and textual studies to try to figure out how historically reliable or factual a given set of scriptures is and so forth. Not even whether a religion is true.
- 5.10 But the test for religion and whether you should be religious or not is, if you take a religion seriously and you try to live it, you put it to practice, does it work for you? And that way of talking about religion is very pragmatic, and as far as we can tell, first comes onto the scene significantly in the American religious tradition. Of course, we've been arguing about religion forever and all sorts of things.
- 5.11 The Americans, with their sense of individuality and distrust of all of these centuries of speculation, will be quite willing to say, look, maybe religion works for you, but it doesn't work for me. Or that religion works for you, but this other religion works for me, and we are fine with that. Let's not get hung up on arguments and speculation whose religion is actually true. Let's let people live according to their own religions and work out a religious set of beliefs that are practically workable for you.
- 5.12 The two big names are William James, born in 1842. I wanted to mention that this means that James was 17 years old and a smart young man when Darwin's *Origin of Species* was published. John Dewey, born in 1859, the very year *Origin of Species* was published. And this is important because evolutionary ideas sweep the world. They have been growing in ascendancy over the course of the 1800s, but certainly after Darwin, 1859, evolutionary ideas come to be front and center.
- 5.13 And what this means philosophically, according to these two young men now growing up and absorbing current intellectual trends, is that we should stop thinking about ideas and structures and principles as somehow these fixed, eternal, unchanging truths

that perhaps were in the mind of God, and God is eternal and unchanging, and so the reflection of true principles should also be fixed and unchanging.

- 5.14** But rather, we live in a world of change. We live in a world that is on process, new ideas and organisms and beings and institutions coming into existence and mutating and dying out. And what we then need to do in our thinking, as well as in our acting, is be flexible and look for principles and ideas and habits of action, not that are going to stand the test of eternity for all time and be absolute truths, but things that work in the here and now, in the way the world is right now, that constantly changing world, and help us navigate and survive and flourish in the world as it is going, so an evolutionary application to ideas.
- 5.15** This is then going to apply to society and to our political institutions. We're not going to think that there's one set of true political rights or one right way of doing government. Rather, it's going to be experimental and evolving as its society itself evolves. Now, I also want to use war as a particular focus of our attentions here in our political philosophy. We've had some discussion about revolutions. We've had some discussions about forming nations to realize their destiny, some discussion about the centrality of religion or about the economy.
- 5.16** But in considering Dewey and James, I want to draw attention to their social thinking and their political thinking in reaction to the eras of war and the kinds of war conduct that is going on in their time. Of course, the conduct of war is an important part of political philosophy. Under what circumstances does one go to war? How should one prosecute the war? Is war something to be celebrated as human aspiration, realizing it itself, as some political philosophies would argue? Or is war a problem that should be solved and that we should be able to develop humanity in a direction that gets past war and become essentially pacific?
- 5.17** Now, in addition to the importance of evolutionary ideas and the new science to the generation of the American pragmatic thinking, certainly the American experience of war, not so much international war, but certainly civil war is shaping of these young men's minds. A horrible war between north and south, largely over the issue of slavery, fought and prosecuted. And here you have brother killing brother, cousin killing brother, former trading partner killing former trading partners. Huge amounts of hatred, destruction, death, and so forth. A great scar on the national consciousness.
- 5.18** So how do you come to adult life absorbing this terrible experience that we Americans have gone through? But by and large, America is staying out of the European wars. It's not interested in the European wars. It's not particularly involved in Asia, and it's staying out of the Asian wars. And the same thing with respect to conflicts going on in Africa. America is, in the 1800s, by and large, peaceful. There was a small skirmish in 1812 with the British in the north. Not a very significant war.

- 5.19** Its only significant war was that internal Civil War. And then toward the end of the century, 1898, the Spanish American War, significant over territory issues in what is now the southwestern part of the United States. As wars go, we always have to preface this, wars are always horrible and terrible and devastating to those who lose their lives, lose their limbs, and so forth, but it was a small war. The Americans lost perhaps 2,000 people in combat deaths. Many more people actually died from yellow fever and various sorts of diseases than in combat. So it was a war, devastating to some extent, but relatively a small-scale war.
- 5.20** As we get, though, to the turn of the century, 1900, the Civil War is now a generation behind us, the Spanish-American war on people's minds, William James is now in the maturity of his intellectual powers. He is a professor of psychology and philosophy at Harvard University, very well-esteemed, and he is making his mark in psychology as well as in philosophy, but he is also a social and political commentator. His famous brother, Henry James, a well-known novelist of the era.
- 5.21** It's in this context that James then steps forward to make his remarks and to develop his political philosophy, particularly with respect to war. How can we reflect on the experience of human history in general, and the progress that we have made? We are progressive in the sense that it's not simply a narrow political ideology or a social reformer ideology, but we are progressive in the modern world in the sense that we think that progress is possible.
- 5.22** That's an unusual thing in the long span of human history, where poverty seemed to be natural and normal, relatively short life expectancy seemed to be natural and normal, a whole lot of suffering and not being able to recover from various diseases. That's just the way it is.
- 5.23** The idea that somehow we can put religious conflict behind us, we can solve the problem of slavery, we can invent new machines to improve our condition, we can make the economy grow so that our children will live a better life than we will live, and their children will live a better life than we—all of this idea that progress is possible to human history instead of just stasis or things getting a little bit better and then a little bit worse, a little bit better, a little bit worse.
- 5.24** Or even against the very pessimistic understanding of human history, that there always was the good old days when men were men and women were women and everyone was a moral giant, and it's just been a story of decline and decadence over the centuries—this progressive mindset is very modern, very Western European, and certainly very American. We should be able to solve all problems.
- 5.25** And one of the big problems that William James, as a progressive pragmatist in a new country, America's century coming on, is to say, we should be able to lead the world in showing how to solve the problem of war. War is not divinely mandated. War is not built into the human condition as an absolute necessity. And given what we know

about human biology, human psychology, and all of the progress we've made in morals and politics, we should be able to figure out how to think as individuals, how to form, and in some cases, reform society and international relations in a way that solves, once and for all, the problem of war.

- 5.26** In 1906, he gives a very famous lecture that is shortly thereafter published, called *The Moral Equivalent of War*. What I want to do next is go into the text and pull out a few important passages on this aspect of pragmatic and progressive political philosophy. Now, William James is a pacifist, and that is a person who is committed on principle to not engaging in war. A pacifistic policy as an individual means that one will not volunteer for war. If one is drafted or conscripted by one's nation to go to fight, one will resist, even up to the point of going to prison for doing so, or only under extreme duress.
- 5.27** If you have to go to war, you will lobby to try to get positions in the war effort that don't involve you doing actual fighting. Perhaps you will work as a hospital orderly or work in administration doing paperwork and so forth, anything that does not involve you to do so. But then more importantly, as a political thinker, to craft national and international policies that are going to make war solvable.
- 5.28** "The war against war is going to be no holiday excursion or camping party." With this provocative title, *The Moral Equivalent of War*, what would the moral equivalent of war be, particularly if we think of war as some horrible, devastating death and destruction thing? How can we find, so to speak, a substitute for war that fulfills its moral aspirations? "The war against war is going to be no holiday excursion or camping party." And that is a paradoxical formulation. We're going to war against war. But nonetheless, there's a deeper philosophical paradox at work here.
- 5.29** And at this point, he asks us to reflect as Americans on our attitude toward the Civil War, which is still going to be on everyone's minds and taught to children and so forth. The way he puts it this way, what do we think about the Civil War? "Ask all our millions, north and south, whether they would vote now to have our war for the Union expunged from history." Here we are in 1906, 40 years after the war has ended. Would you like to have the Civil War not to have happened? So that we could, in fact, rewrite history and actually rewrite past reality, such that the war never happened. Would you be willing to do so?
- 5.30** And the answer for most Americans would say, no, no. Actually, the war has an honorable place in our history. It's an important part of who we are. Yes, hundreds of thousands of people died, widespread destruction and so forth, but nonetheless, it was for a noble cause. We are proud of the fact that we fought this war, that we preserved the Union, we eliminated slavery. It is a part of our American identity, and don't erase it from history.

- 5.31 But if you were to ask those same Americans, "Would you like to have another civil war? Should we do that again?", basically all of them would say, "No, no way. Forget it. No, that is too horrible, no more war." In one respect, we are fine with war and we take pride in the wars that we have conducted. At the other extreme, this is the paradox, we're horrified by war and we don't want war anymore. And both of those coexist in our psyche.
- 5.32 And he then goes on to say that this is interesting because, in the modern world, we have changed our moral psychology with respect to war. In olden times, being a man meant being a warrior, and you would celebrate opportunities and look for opportunities to go to war, to prove your manliness, to conquest, take people's stuff, take their women and so forth, and go to your territory, your glory. That's what it meant to be a man.
- 5.33 But what has happened over the course of centuries in the modern world, particularly with respect to the Enlightenment, the rights of man and women and freedom and peace is that we now think that war is not to be celebrated unless we absolutely have to go to war. "Only when forced upon one is a war now thought permissible." This is a liberal attitude that we saw in John Stuart Mill. We should let people do whatever they want, and we're going to do whatever we want. The only time I can use force against any of you or you can use force against me is if it's for self-protection, to protect yourself against harm.
- 5.34 And so that's what he said; only if we are attacked first or if it's the only way to defend ourselves against some sort of aggression, that's the only time war is morally acceptable. This is the new modern thinking. And he points out, "It was not thus in ancient times." Men were men, and to be a man meant you were a great hunter and you were a great warrior, and you celebrated it and you cultivated in yourself the warrior mentality and the mighty hunter mentality.
- 5.35 That's what it meant to be a man, for your own self-image, for the respect of the other men in your tribe, and certainly to attract women. Because women want the man who's going to be the mightiest hunter and the mightiest warrior. He is the most powerful, the most manly of all men. Those cultures are organized in terms of their moral scale of values to prioritize a certain type of psychology.
- 5.36 "It was not thus in ancient times. The more martial tribes selected, and in chiefs and peoples a pure pugnacity and love of glory came to mingle with the more fundamental appetite for plunder." So if we then start to think, evolutionarily, why did some men succeed in their tribes? Why did some tribes succeed and not other tribes? The argument is, it's always the most martial, the most warlike. The strongest, most aggressive, most assertive, and successful at doing so, that succeeds, that gets the most stuff, gets the most women, gets the most territory.

- 5.37 And those tribes that say, "Oh, no, we don't want to go to war, we want to be peaceful. We're not going to cultivate our martial capacities," those are the ones that are just going to get wiped out. And the man, individually, who says, "I don't want to be a warlike tough guy who can go out and plunder and then take," well, he's not going to be as interesting to women. And so his line is also going to die out.
- 5.38 Now we have a biological point here. We, nonetheless, have inherited the biological line. All of the men and women in the tribes that were successful over the course of long periods of evolution were the ones that were most successful at war. They stayed in existence and they grew. And they then reproduced themselves, and partly as a result of their biological transmission of their nature, and partly as a result of the cultural transmission, we have inherited that in the modern world.
- 5.39 We are talking about tens of thousands of years of evolution. The modern world is only a century or two. We're not going to overturn all of that cultural psychology and biology in just a few generations. But at the same time, we have changed. We now think trade is a better avenue than plunder. So yes, we are liberalized. Yes, we are much more pacific. We shouldn't go to war. We should respect other nations and their way of doing things and trade with them and try to go for international peace. We believe all of us as moderns, and particularly as modern Americans.
- 5.40 But at the same time, we are a product of biological evolution and aggression and conquest, and being able to assert yourself over the other is also a part of our nature. So we are in a paradoxical situation. So how are we going to then, if we are pacific and we want pacifism, to make further progress? Because we can't just change our biology, so to speak, overnight. Now, as support, he notices history. History, as he puts it here, is a bath of blood. If you read most history textbooks, who are we celebrating? Well, we're celebrating Alexander the Great, Julius Caesar, Napoleon, and so forth. It's all of their great conquests.
- 5.41 Sometimes it's in a sanitized form, but in that sanitized form, you read the numbers and it says, 125,000 people perished in this battle. That's 125,000 people. It's just a statistic. But that's just one battle in just one war in history. It was war after war after war. And so not only do we inherit all of that biologically, when we become historically informed, we absorb that as what it is to be a human being, including the ethos that goes along with it.
- 5.42 So we have Alexander, we have Rome conquering Greece. "We inherit the warlike type." It's an inheritance, a biological type, and also culturally reinforced significantly. Emphasizing that even more, "our ancestors have bred pugnacity into our bone and marrow, and thousands of years won't breed it out of us." If you think, for example, of human beings as an animal species, well, we know there are lots of other animal species, and some of them are more predatory, like wolves and lions and hyenas and eagles and piranhas and so forth. They are the product of millennia of evolution that has trained them.

- 5.43 If we were to say, well, let's biologically try to take these wolves and train them not to be so wolf-like, to be nice and peaceful, well, how many centuries of evolution and breeding would that take? A huge amount. And the same thing is a fact with respect to us. Now, if we then scale out more internationally, and as Americans, we need to start thinking more internationally as the 1900s come along, "Our civilized opinion is a curious mental mixture." So among the civilized nations of the world, and here, James mentions England, Germany, and Japan.
- 5.44 So we have North America with the Americans, the British representing much of Western Europe, Germany representing Central Europe, and Japan representing here Asia. And these are all by anyone's standard civilized nations. But what are their moral and political attitudes with respect to war? James points out, we Americans are by and large against war. We would rather trade than go to war. The English are still largely liberal, John Stuart Mill. We want to have more commercial trading, and so forth, to be essentially pacific.
- 5.45 But that's not the way it is in Germany, and it is not the way it is in Japan. What we find in Germany is perhaps the opposite, the idea that being a warrior is the essence of what it is to be a human being. Life is conflict, and it's also international conflict. Japan has a long civilization, and at the top of that civilization is samurai culture. The samurai, from the moment of his or her birth, trains for war, duty, obedience, willingness to sacrifice for the fatherland.
- 5.46 It is through one's duty and obedience to one's lord, and by extension, one's nation, that one achieves the meaningful life, and even more importantly, a meaningful death. Not to live and be happy, but to do your duty and die well. That's a very different ethos. Germany, shorthand here, is now going to be three generations after Hegel's influence. Germany is rising, and many of its historians, philosophers, political thinkers, lawyers, even poets, are celebrating Germany as the nation of God and the special nation in which discipline and duty and service to the nation.
- 5.47 And this nation is in conflict with all other nations. And nations either live or die as a result of those conflicts. But it is time for Germany to assert itself and to see dominance and take the world further forward. And it necessarily has to be by means of war. We have a biological problem. We can't change our biological nature. And we have an international civilizations problem, different nations committed to very different moral and political evaluations with respect to war.
- 5.48 How are we going to make pacifism succeed not only in America, but more broadly in the Western world and in the international sphere? It is now a global problem. What James wants to argue, as he says here, "I am a pacifist." I'm not going to just do the traditional pacifist thing of saying, "War is really ugly, war is really nasty," and then show you pictures of young men with their eyes shot out and their legs cut off and bleeding and horrible things and then piles of corpses and so forth.

- 5.49 That my then rhetorical strategy here is to show you just how horrible war is, so you'll have this strong emotional reaction of horror and disgust, and then become committed to not being a war-like person as well. And this is, of course, what pacifists have continually done. I'm also not going to just take the typical role of saying, oh, you people who think that war is life, you're just war-mongers. You're just horrible people. You're terrible monsters. Why can't you be a nice, civilized, decent person? I'm not going to do all of that shaming.
- 5.50 I don't think that is going to work either. We've been trying to do that for a long time. It's not going to be successful. What we need to do is fight a philosophical battle. And the philosophical battle is because the people who are still in favor of war believe themselves to be on the right side of history. They believe they have the right philosophy of life. Just as we believe being more pacific is the right philosophy of life.
- 5.51 So we will say, if we are pacifists, war is horrible, and therefore being a civilized person means recoiling from war and not being interested in it. But if we talk to the leading representatives of the Japanese military or the German military, and we go to them and we point out, "Oh, war is so horrible," they will say, "Yes, it is." And that's why you need to toughen yourself up and be the kind of man who can look horror in the face and still do your duty, and be willing to die and suffer horrible things.
- 5.52 Because that's what it is to be a good person, to be a moral person, to be a manly man. That's a philosophical gulf that needs to be overridden. And they, from their perspective, will say, "We are the ones who are upholding humanity at its highest." Life is conflict. You talk to a lion, if you could talk to a lion, and you want to say, "Why, you lions, why do you have to be so mean to the zebras? And why are you in conflict with the hyenas? Why don't you try to be nicer?" No self-respecting lion is going to listen to you.
- 5.53 "You want to turn me into an antelope? You want to turn me into a cow? No, I'm going to be a lion and act as a lion. It disgusts me, the idea of thinking that I could become a wildebeest or a sheep or some other being. That's not what I want to do." The same thing holds when we start talking to people who are advocates of the military ethos. If you say to them, "Why don't you be more like us Americans? We're more pacific. Or why don't you be more like us British? We're more pacific." And they say, "That's disgusting, that kind of lifestyle."
- 5.54 Because what are Americans? Well, the American dream is to have your own plot of land and become a farmer, grow your own crops and have a few animals. You're a nice guy, you're self-sufficient. But who wants to be a farmer? From the military-minded perspective, that's a boring life. I want a life of excitement and adventure. Or we say, save up your money and have your own business idea and start your own shop. What does that mean? Well, that means you're going to be dealing with cardboard boxes and inventory and standing behind a counter all day, trying to be nice to customers so that they will give you some money.

- 5.55 A nation of farmers, a nation of shopkeepers, guys working in a factory. What kind of life is that? Is that a manly life? No, the best life is not that. We don't want to turn us into a nation of sheep. Then you go home at the end of the day and you eat a little too much and you drink a little too much and you get fat and soft. That's not life. You are fit, you are tough, you are manly, you're ready to go to war. That is life at its highest.
- 5.56 What William James is saying is that we pacifists are missing out on this. We have to engage with the military ethic and the military politics at its own level and come up with something better than that. He gives the point here, he says, somewhat presciently, look at Japan. Japan is getting tough and they're looking at us as soft. Look at Germany. They're getting tough and they're looking at Western Europe, a nation of shopkeepers. They're looking across at America as getting soft. So we are setting ourselves up for being defeated.
- 5.57 Now, here's an example of a German political philosopher applying to issues of war, the philosophy of war, Steinmetz. And we'll see echoes of Hegel in this work here that James is citing. War, according to Steinmetz, is an ordeal instituted by God. It's not only that we have biological predation on our side, war is divinely ordained by God to sort out which nations are superior and which nations are inferior and which ones should be the leaders. We have religion on our side.
- 5.58 Do we have a good argument against that? We nice American liberals, we nice British liberals and so forth. "War is when God holds his assizes and hurls the peoples upon one another. One cannot meet them effectively by mere counter-insistency on war's expensiveness and horror." The Germans are ready to go to war, the Japanese are ready to go to war. And what are we Americans doing? "Oh, it's going to be so expensive. We're going to have to cut back on our luxuries and so on."
- 5.59 "So long as anti-militarists propose no substitute for war's disciplinary function, no moral equivalent of war, we are going to fail in the pacifistic argument." So it's not only perhaps that war is divinely ordained, as some cultures believe, not only that it's necessarily politically necessary in the conflict among nations, that your nation be ready for war and ready to be dominant, there is also this moral ideal.
- 5.60 To be a real man, you have to be a warrior type. Discipline, obedience, duty, sacrifice, a willingness to die for something beyond yourself. That's a moral ideal that informs important political cultures now. That's what we need to go up against. That's why we can't simply say, "We have this different moral ideal, and we think your moral ideal is too aggressive." What is our moral answer, our moral equivalent, to that ideal?
- 5.61 Now, here, James brings in a philosophical point. Of course, America has a reputation for being a very individualistic nation. One of the things that is characteristic of pragmatism and progressivism, these big "isms" that are now being introduced in the American consciousness, is that they are much less individualistic than you would expect American-based philosophies to be.

- 5.62 And what James is going to argue is that what we have to do is accept that morality is a matter not of individual freedom and pursuit of happiness, but rather it is a matter of discipline and duty and sacrifice and service to the collective, just as the warlike types. But what we need to do is find a different vehicle institutionally in which to celebrate those ideals and to channel that human energy.
- 5.63 So, "all the qualities of man acquire dignity when he knows that the service of the collectivity that owns him needs him." And James then is going to agree with that as a moral principle. You are not an individual; you are a member of a collective. You become a dignified individual to the extent that you are willing to say, "The collective owns me." My question is, "What does the collective need me to do?" But we're going to take that ethos and channel it in a non-warlike direction.
- 5.64 I have to just point out this one phrase from General Lea, "human blubber." If you think of a whale, whales are largely constituted of blubber, that constitution of their flesh under the skin. The point here is, from the military perspective, Americans are becoming blubber, soft in their morals, soft in their mentality, soft in their bodies, soft in their institutions, and we can't agree with that. "I will now confess my own utopia," I, William James. "I devoutly believe in the reign of peace," so I'm a pacifist, but unexpectedly for an American, I believe also "in the gradual advent of some sort of socialistic equilibrium."
- 5.65 I'm not going to be a liberal. I'm not going to be an individualist. I'm not going to be, as we will see, a free market capitalist. James has also adopted some socialistic ideals, as well as the notion that, morally, one should see oneself as part of a collective and that one's obligation to serve it is. Here's James' proposal for the solution to the problem of war, all of that being said. What if we did the following?
- 5.66 "If now, and this is my idea, there were, instead of military conscription," that is to say, as many nations are organized, all young people, traditionally men, now increasingly women, but all of them are, in effect, owned by their nations, and they owe an obligation of military service, so they are conscripted or drafted into the army for a certain period of time, and at any moment, they can be reclassified into the army. You are, in that sense, owned by the nation and the military whenever the nation needs its military functions done.
- 5.67 What if we took all of that and changed it to, "instead of military conscription, a conscription of the whole youthful population to form for a certain number of years a part of an army enlisted against nature." Instead of taking young people and having taught them that their obligation is to serve the nation, to do their duty for the good of the collective, and that we're going to do so by herding them into the military, we will assign young people to tasks for a certain number of years.
- 5.68 You will go and work on the farms, you will go and work in the mines, you will go and work here, you will go and work there. "To coal and iron mines, to freight trains, to

fishing fleets in December, to dishwashing, to clothes-washing, window-washing, road building," etc. If we do this, then we are engaging in moral training of individuals, that they are part of the collective and they are doing their service to the nation. This is no longer individual pursuit of happiness and freedom to choose your own lifestyle. We're not at all liberal here.

5.69 But at the same time, we are capturing something important in the military ethic, all of that energy about duty and sacrifice and service that the military emphasizes so strongly. People will say, "I want to do something for my country. I want to sacrifice and serve my country." If the military is the only vehicle they have for doing so, James is now saying, we can take all of that energy and all of that moral idealism and put it to good economic work, building the roads, managing the farms, and so forth.

5.70 It will be national service, national conscription, a draft, but a civilian draft of the young people for a certain amount of time. And this explains then the title. This is a moral equivalent of war. It's the same morality, sacrifice, service, discipline, owned by your society, but it's not directed to war, it's directed to something else. It's a substitute. And James thinks then if we go down this direction, we can solve the problem of war.

5.71 Now, one more passage from James that I want to emphasize here, just in terms of how radical these ideas, particularly as they are being introduced and advocated in this first generation of pragmatic and progressive political philosophy in the United States. The United States, traditionally, has been the nation that says, we are a nation of individuals, and that every nation, individual rather, has the right to his or her own life, on liberty, pursuit of happiness. That's our moral ideal. You are not owned by the government. Rather, the government is the servant of the individuals in the protection of their individual rights.

5.72 We're finding in William James, an American, a reversal of that moral philosophy. This is part and parcel of the progressivist new political philosophy. But this is also the nation that went through the Civil War that he mentioned at the beginning of the essay. The Civil War was largely over the issue of slavery, and slavery being a moral abomination, the idea that some human beings can own other human beings, and how repugnant that is to anyone with Enlightenment, liberal, individualistic ideals.

5.73 One would expect that American intellectuals are, when the issue of slavery and human beings owning each other comes up, reacting extraordinarily negatively. But not in the case of William James. We have a very provocative passage here. "We should all feel some degree of its imperative, if we were conscious of our work as an obligatory, rather, service to the state." Why do I work? Is it because I want to live a good life, provide for my family, have some luxuries, choose my own course in life? Very individualistic.

5.74 And James is saying no. Your work is obligatory service to the state. And then the stronger formulation. "We should be owned, as soldiers are by the army, and our pride

would rise accordingly." Ownership of human beings is to be celebrated morally. The state owns you, and you will acquire your dignity to the extent that you accept that the state owns you and that you are performing your duty with respect to the state.

- 5.75** Then, of course, James' hope is that this will bring about a kind of socialism. There certainly is a fit with socialism there, but it also will solve, more importantly, the problem of war by taking its moral high ground and diverting all of that energy to other purposes. Now, James is writing this at the turn of the 20th century, and I now want to make a transition to two other important progressivist and pragmatic thinkers, John Dewey, whom we mentioned earlier, born in 1859. Jane Addams, born in 1860.
- 5.76** In part, I'd like to mention Jane Addams as she was a graduate from the university, which, rather I have been teaching for many years, Rockford University. It was then Rockford College. But to give us a sense of the flavor of progressivism's moral principles that are going to then be translated into a political practice, this concept of service, obligation, are you an individual? Are you a member of a collective? And what we mean by democracy in the American context, all of these concepts are worked and made explicit in a somewhat different direction from what one might expect.
- 5.77** Here's Jane Addams in a work called *Democracy and Social Ethics*. We've got the word democracy highlighted for special emphasis here. What is it to be a moral person? We're in America where we think everybody is individualistic and my individual rights to this, that, and the other thing. But Addams is arguing, "In this effort toward a higher morality in our social relations," not to be individualistic, "we must demand that the individual shall be willing to lose the sense of personal achievement."
- 5.78** The idea that your life is yours to make and what you accomplish in your life should be your goal and something you take pride in, you have to be able to lose that sense. That's not what being moral is about. "And shall be content to realize his activity only in connection with the activity of the many." So the idea, again, that individualistic idea, I have my life to live, you have your life to live, you have your dreams and goals, I have my dreams and goals, everyone has their own, and we're all going on our own deeply personal journeys.
- 5.79** Of course, if we find there's overlap between what you want to do and what I want to do, we'll form friendships and business partners and all kinds of associations, as long as it's for the good of each of us as we're going on our individual journeys. Addams is signaling that traditional American ethic is not what we are about at all. What you do should be activity only in connection with everybody else. It's a much more collectivized understanding of what it is to be a human being living a meaningful life.
- 5.80** All of this has to do with how we should understand the word democracy, which is certainly important in American political vocabulary. But again, it is reconceptualized here. Instead of the idea of democracy being, we live in a society where every individual is sovereign, everyone has their own right to life, their own liberty, their own

conception of what their happiness is going to be, and they're pursuing their life projects each in their own way.

- 5.81** Of course, we are social beings, so we need to get together and decide policies for our various social institutions, churches and businesses and sports teams and political associations and so on. What we're going to do is get together as individuals and talk about what we need and want and what our goals are and look for the overlap. Then we're going to vote as individuals on what those policies are going to be. If the vote goes against you, you're, of course, free to leave that association and go back your own way, that very individualistic understanding of democracy.
- 5.82** I as an individual vote and so forth. What we have is in contrast to that. "As the acceptance of democracy brings a certain life-giving power, so it has its own sanctions and comforts. Perhaps the most obvious one is the curious sense which comes to us from time to time that we belong to the whole, that a certain basic well-being can never be taken away from us, whatever the turn of fortune."
- 5.83** And I have highlighted here this phrase, "We belong to the whole." And the contrast is to say, you do not belong to yourself. You are not primarily an individual. You belong to a collective, to the whole. It is the whole "demos" that has power. It's the power of the collective. And what we're trying to do is instill a collective consciousness and a collective set of values in society. And that's what we mean by democracy.
- 5.84** Now, I turn to John Dewey, who is perhaps the most famous of all of the pragmatic philosophers. I want to highlight here two books that he wrote, one called *Democracy and Education*, published in 1916. It's published in 1916 when World War I has broken out in Europe. But the Americans are staying out of the war, as of 1916. But he is taking up this issue of, if we are interested in being democratic, and democratic now in this Jane Addams sense of democratic, that we are a whole, we are a collective, and we are turning to the issue of taking young people and educating them to see themselves as belonging to the whole as part of the collective, what will our educational practices as parents and as teachers be?
- 5.85** And it will not be the practice of teaching people to be individual, liberal free agents in any significant sense. I've got that paired with a book Dewey published in 1920 called *Reconstruction in Philosophy*. And the date here is significant in part because America did enter the war in 1917. The war had begun in 1914. Germans attacked the French, quickly overwhelmed them. Germans allied with another empire, the Ottoman Empire. The French and the British largely allied with each other. A terrible, terrible war.
- 5.86** The United States stays out of the war. It says, "Look, you Europeans, you've always been fighting wars over the course of the centuries. We're not interested in this particular war. It doesn't affect us. We're going to adopt neutrality until 1917." And then with the American assistance and, of course, all of the other Allies, finally, the Germans and the Austro-Hungarians and the Turkish are defeated.

- 5.87** But as the result of 1918, when we start to assess what has occurred in Europe, allegedly the most civilized place in the world over the course of four years, four and a half years or so, millions and millions of people just horribly, horribly slaughtered. Most of them, of course, young men, but lots of other people. And that's not to count the number of people who are maimed and disfigured and psychologically devastated as a result of the war, plus all of the property damage and cultural damage and so forth.
- 5.88** And there's a big question then on everyone's mind. How did this happen and how did it happen in a place that is supposed to be civilized and advanced and progressive, as Europe has apparently been in the modern, enlightened world. Does philosophy have something to do with it? Should we blame Hegel? Should we blame various other political philosophers who have flamed certain ideas? Should we juxtapose those to certain other ideals as better? Is there a lesson that we can learn from the war?
- 5.89** The war also was largely shocking to the world, particularly European consciousness. Somewhat of an overstatement here, but if you think about the century from 1815, when Napoleon was defeated finally for the second time, consigned to the end of the stage, to 1914. That is 99 years, let's call it one century of European history. And there was not much by way of war in that century.
- 5.90** There was a Franco-Prussian, Prussian-Austrian conflict, 1860s, 1870s or so. If you count Europe going over to the Far East, there was the Crimean war over in Russia, Ukraine area. There's lots of other small-scale conflicts and battles in which hundreds or some thousands of people die. A contrast, that century in European history with all the previous centuries of European history, where there was just war, war, war, war, war. Thousands, tens of thousands, hundred of thousands, millions of people were being killed.
- 5.91** We've had a relatively peaceful century until 1914, and suddenly, bam, everything just goes to hell in the worst possible way, and the Europeans are right back at it, now armed with modern technologies, which enable them to kill people more easily and in larger numbers. What is the lesson of history here? And do we need to reeducate the next generation? And do we need to reconstruct philosophy in the light of the lessons we can learn from this war? This is Dewey's project.
- 5.92** I'm going to turn again to the text. I have some minutes remaining here. I'm going to take these two texts in reverse order. The first, after World War I has ended, what needs to be reconstructed? Because for some reason, we have civilizations, and civilizations are products of their best ideas and the intellectuals and the philosophers who come up with those ideas. Somehow, France and England evolved to be allies with each other and have a certain way of life that put them in mortal combat with the Germans and the Austro-Hungarian Empire and the Ottoman Turks.
- 5.93** Is there then some blame to be assigned to the philosophers for developing ideas that can put into collision with each other? The one being perhaps more individualistic, one

more collectivistic, whether that is a possibility. Dewey starts this chapter by asking that very question, "How can philosophic change seriously affect social philosophy? As far as fundamentals are concerned, every view and combination appears to have been formulated already."

- 5.94** If we look at the history of philosophers trying to sort out what social relations should be, we have three possibilities, it seems. "Society is composed of individuals. This obvious and basic fact, no philosophy, whatever its pretensions to novelty, can question or alter. Hence, these three alternatives. Society must exist for the sake of individuals." So that's option one. We take individuals seriously. They are sovereign, they have their rights, and societies that we form, all various sorts of them, exist for the realization of the purposes of the individuals that comprise, rather, those societies. That's one.
- 5.95** "Or individuals must have their ends and ways of living set for them by society." We say society is the thing. Society is an entity, an organism, the reality or the institutional being that really exists. It has its own goals, its own ends, and it uses individuals to achieve its social, small s, socialist ends. "Or else society and individuals are correlative, organic to one another, society requiring the service and subordination of individuals, at the same time existing to serve them."
- 5.96** This is going to be close to the position that Dewey adopts, this third position. We don't want to be too individualistic. We don't want to be too socialistic/collectivistic. Instead, we want to see them as codependent, codeveloping, coexisting in some middle ground kind of way. You'll notice in the middle of that formulation, the concept of organic. Again, biological metaphors coming to the fore in the generations after Darwin.
- 5.97** The organic conception, of course, is not new. There are lots of organic conceptions of society all the way through. "The organic conception seems to meet all the objections to the extreme individualistic and extreme socialistic theories, avoiding the errors alike of Plato and Bentham." So he's emphasizing Plato as a traditional organic theory, Bentham as a more individualistic theory. But if all of these alternatives have already been worked out and we've had societies built up on various forms of them, and nonetheless, we still end up in the Great War, what we now call World War I, maybe something new needs to be developed here.
- 5.98** "All these various theories suffer from a common defect." So what has been the problem in political philosophy up to this point? And the problem is a deep philosophical one. "They are all committed to the logic of general notions under which specific situations are to be brought." Now, what does that mean? What that means is, philosophers and political philosophers have said, up to this point, we can develop general universal principles in the abstract, and then apply those to all of the circumstances that arise, individual circumstances that arise, top-down or big-picture theory applied to reality.

- 5.99** We have also, in the course of centuries and millennia of philosophical and political thinking, thought of these things as unchanging and eternal, as absolute. Partly, this is our religious heritage where we think of God as the absolute, as perfection, as unchanging. And so therefore, God's laws for the world are also going to be absolute, unchanging, and perfect. So top-down principles that are supposed to be unchanging and absolute.
- 5.100** That has governed the individualistic theories. It has governed also the more collectivistic theories. That's the problem that Dewey thinks needs to be solved. We debate, and we notice how he emphasizes here, we debate in terms of the state, the individual, the nature of institutions in society in general, assuming in some sense these are static, determined entities or beings or whatever it is that we are talking, that already have a more or less stable nature and a fixed identity that we just need to massage and manage in various sorts of ways.
- 5.101** But what he is going to argue, he being John Dewey, rather, now absorbing evolutionary philosophy, what if we think of reality as evolving and changing, not simply at the biological level, but also at the cultural level? Rather than thinking, the way you're thinking of species, and this is a big thing for people to wrap their minds around at the end of the 19th century, instead of thinking of species as created by God, and each species has a nature that is fixed—a dog is a dog, a bird is a bird, a fish is a fish, and there's some absolute essence that's built into all of these things that makes them what they are, and that therefore they're going to interact the way that they are.
- 5.102** Rather, to see fish as evolving, dogs as evolving. All animals, including human beings, as evolving. And what was good for a particular species, if we cast it very broadly, a million years ago, is not necessarily going to be what's good for it now. Its nature has changed. The environment has changed. Everything has changed. Therefore, the principles that we're going to extract for what it is to be good at one particular time for one particular species are themselves changing.
- 5.103** The same thing holds true at cultural level. Cultures are not static. They don't have firm, unbending principles. Cultures are constantly in a process of change. Therefore, the individuals who are born into a culture are going to be constituted and reconstituted differently by the culture as the culture itself changes. And of course, there are mutations and there are individual variations that come along, and those individuals that are the variants are also going to exert influences on the society more broadly and change the society.
- 5.104** So we have to start thinking more organically in this very modern sense. Change, not static. Flexibility, not permanence. Evolution, not fixed eternal principles. "The logic of rigid universals" is the philosophical phrase. In some sense, there are universal principles, they are rigid, and there's just a logic that follows from those. Instead, what we have to do is recognize that we are all starting off with potential, and that potential

needs to develop, and how it is developed depends on the circumstances we find ourselves.

- 5.105** So against the individualists, for example, "The real difficulty is that the individual is regarded as something given, something already there." So the individualist here will say, well, I am born, I am an individual. I have my nature, I have my identity, I have my rights, and my rights are fixed and unalienable and absolute. Rather than seeing the individual as a kind of potentiality, that when he or she is born, is born into these social circumstances, but could have been born into those social circumstances.
- 5.106** That individual then becomes something, partly as a result of its natural biological development, but largely also because of its cultural emplacement. What you will end up with then is an individual that develops in this way to have certain ideas and values, in contrast to an individual who could have developed in a very different way, in a different kind of social institution.
- 5.107** There is no such thing at the beginning as an individual, that is an entity with a fixed identity that we can start talking about what's good for it, what its rights are, what its values are, what its political status is. Instead, what we have to do, and this is Dewey's way of formulating this, "Social arrangements, laws and institutions are made for man, rather than that man is made for them, that they are means and agencies of human welfare and progress. But they are not means for obtaining something for individuals, not even happiness. They are means of creating individuals."
- 5.108** So the individual is something that is created by society. It's not the case that there are individuals that we put in society, and society is for the sake of protecting the individual's core identity and so forth. Taking the evolutionary theory seriously and applying it to politics. "When selfhood is perceived to be an active process, it is also seen that social modifications are the only means of the creation of changed personalities. Institutions are viewed in their educative effect, with reference to the types of individuals they foster."
- 5.109** All right, jumping ahead. "Society is the process of associating in such ways that experiences, ideas, emotions, values are transmitted and made common. Personality must be educated." We are social products, we are socially constituted, we are socially created. But when we become the individuals that we are, we in turn, because of our individuality, shape society and take society in various directions as well. It is not static either. "This fact fixes the significance of democracy." Democracy being the core political concept here. This is what progressives rather mean by the concept of democracy.
- 5.110** I want to take one more point, a minute to talk about education in particular. Dewey is also a famous philosopher in education. If we're going to reconstruct philosophy, reconstruct society in this pragmatic and progressive vision, we also need to recast the schools so that we are creating citizens of the right sort. This is Dewey's understanding

of what education is going to be. It's not to help the individual realize his or her self potential.

5.111 "Education, in its broadest sense, is the means of a social continuity of life. Every one of the constituent elements of a social group in a modern city as an established tribe is born immature, helpless, without language, beliefs, ideas, or social standards." Pausing there, all of those are constructed into the individual. "Each individual, each unit who is the carrier of the life experience of his group in time passes away, yet the life of the group goes on." And that is the progressive standard. It is the life of the group that is the important thing.

5.112 The group formulates its education institutes, takes the unformed individuals, and molds them and shapes them to have its way of thinking, its way of valuing, so that it can carry on the life of the group as it should be. The argument here is that this is going to get us past war. It's going to get us past conflict. It's going to embody the progressive moral ideal as we reshape in America, hopefully leading the rest of the world toward a progressive democratic future.

Lecture 6: Fascism and Force

At a glance — Fascism and force, beginning with 1914 and the Great War.

- 6.1 Let's begin in 1914, significant year in world history. It's the year the Great War begins. We now call it World War I. Of course, at the time, it was not known that there would also be another world war in the next generation. So when the cataclysm began and the European nations and others were in the midst of it, it was just suddenly the Great War.
- 6.2 But also in 1914, there is turmoil inside the Italian socialist party, and it's to Italy, primarily, that our attention will turn for this lecture, and a focus on the development of fascism as a political philosophy and its fraught relationships with socialism. Now, so far in this series of lectures, we've been looking at a number of "isms", starting with conservatism in a modernized form. Nationalism, communism, liberalism, progressivism, pragmatism, and now, socialism and fascism.
- 6.3 Turmoil had been carried over for a couple of years, reaching a peak in 1914, but starting in 1912, because it was then that Benito Mussolini became the editor-in-chief of *Avanti*, which was the main publication of the Italian socialist party. It was now long-lived newspaper that had been founded almost 20 years earlier as the official voice of the Italian socialist party. And always in the course of the history of Italian socialism, it's written by factions and subversions and debates over what the soul of socialism is and should be, particularly in the Italian socialist party case.
- 6.4 Now, one indication of the deep divides in the socialist party was somewhat perplexing, too, many of the socialists that they saw themselves, all of them, as having the same general political vision. They were opposed to liberalism, they were opposed to capitalism. But what is it to be a socialist in the pure sense? And one side of the faction emphasized that socialism can and should be tied to religion, particularly the Christian religion, and then even more particularly to the Catholic Christian religion as a result of its long history.
- 6.5 And the very first issue of *Avanti* was published in 1896, but consciously on December 25th, which is traditionally the date of the birth of Jesus. And what the Italian socialists wanted to emphasize is that we, socialists, are and should be seen as good Christians, and even more particularly in the context of Italy, as good, good, good Catholics. So the holy birth of Jesus and the holy birth of the Italian socialist party's newspaper are together. And this is part of a tradition that sees socialism as a political extension of Christian moral teaching.
- 6.6 Here the idea being, in many cases, Jesus has preached against the rich and is in favor of the poor and the downtrodden, that he has urged his followers to give up all of their worldly possessions, to sell them off and give their wealth to the poor, a kind of

redistribution effort. And the socialists had argued, we are taking that ethic and simply applying it to the political sphere.

- 6.7** But Mussolini, who became editor of *Avanti* in 1912, was, this is the other side of the controversy, a Marxist. He thought of himself as a true believing follower of Karl Marx and his communist version of socialism. And of course, Marxism philosophically is atheist. It disbelieves in all gods, all spirits, all religions, including Christianity and all of the variations of Christianity, which it sees simply as props for existing kinds of social system. So within this broad commitment to some sort of socialism, we have deep divides. And Benito Mussolini's appointment to the editorship points out this in Italy.
- 6.8** Now, he was a brilliant speaker, a brilliant writer. Under his editorship, *Avanti's* circulation increased multiple times, and what was a relatively small circulation newspaper became a huge circulation newspaper. Mussolini also had been a bit of a rabble-rouser when he was younger, got into trouble with various Italian authorities, left, went to Switzerland, got into trouble with the Swiss authorities. But one interesting historical coincidence is that while Mussolini was still a Marxist, a true believer in the views of Karl Marx, he had come to the attention of Marxists around the world in the international context.
- 6.9** And coincidentally, Vladimir Lenin, who was in Switzerland at the same time, Lenin is going to become the leader of the Bolsheviks, the Marxist Party that takes over Russia and turns it into the Soviet Union after 1917, but they are meeting and talking and getting to know each other. And Lenin has great praise for this promising young Italian socialist as he sees him.
- 6.10** But inside the Italian socialist party, there are nonetheless this commitment to socialism, but deep divides about the underlying morality and philosophy. Should we see socialism as a materialist doctrine, that we are about the natural world, about material forces? The economy is fundamental, as the Marxist side wants to argue, and some of the close travelers to the Marxist versions want to argue. Or is socialism a moral vision, a spiritual quest, trying to unify people in not simply material form, but into something more collective in a spiritual sense? So that metaphysical divide is important.
- 6.11** Should socialism be international, as the Marxists argue? That is to say, it is economic classes that are important, not your religion, not your nationality, not your ethnicity, not your gender. The important thing about your identity is whether you are a worker working with your hands, doing physical labor, or if you are a capitalist parasitically exploiting the workers and making your living that way.
- 6.12** And to the extent that you are a worker, workers have the same interests and the same material circumstances the world over. So it should be, as Marx and Engels had written, "Workers of the world, unite." See yourself as a common class, ignore national differences, ethnic differences, and so forth. But other socialists had wanted to argue

that, no, socialism needs to be reflective of actual political reality. The world is divided into nations. In many cases, nations have a more ethnic national identity, a shared common culture. And what we should be doing is pitching socialism at the national level, another important divide.

- 6.13** And then by the time we get to World War I, absolutely, the war is a huge internal to the Italian socialist party debate. Should we keep Italy out of the war? That is to say, adopt a policy of neutrality. And many of the socialists had wanted to argue, well, the war, World War I, it's a clash of economic interests. It's just the capitalists in this country versus the capitalists in that country, fighting for wealth and spoils and territories and so forth. We socialists should stay out of what is essentially a capitalistic war, whereas others inside the Italian socialist party had argued that Italy should join the war, although it was not always clear what side of the war Italy should join in on.
- 6.14** Mussolini, as now editor and a very prominent voice inside the Italian socialist party, jumps in on this debate, and he jumps in on the side of saying that Italy should not remain neutral. Italy should join the war, and in part because of the influence of Mussolini inside the Italian socialist party, and partly because of more broad sentiment among the Italian people as well, Mussolini decides that it's time for him to leave the official socialist party. He separates from them and starts his own brand newspaper and a new party that he's going to say is a variation on socialism, but he's going to give it a new name, and he's going to argue for a kind of socialism for Italians, and Italians need to enter the war.
- 6.15** A year later, Italy does enter the war. It enters the war on the side of the Allies and against the Axis powers. So it declares war on the Austro-Hungarian Empire, declares war on the Germans and so forth. The war carries on. By the time we get to 1918, the war is over and Italy is on the side of the victors. But the internal debates within the socialist party continue. There's now formal splits, Mussolini from the other Italian socialists, and then, inside the Italian socialist party that had remained, further splits that are going on.
- 6.16** But we start now to see this new name emerging, right? Fascism, a new kind of "ism". Mussolini starts to call his variation of political philosophy not quite Marxist, not quite socialist in the traditional, we're just extending Christian moral philosophy to the political realm version, but rather a distinct version that needs a new name, a new party, and a new activism. And the activism is important here because it's not simply going to be intellectual activism in the form of newspapers and speeches and rallies.
- 6.17** It starts to get more muscular, and we start to see paramilitary organizations under Mussolini wearing a trademark black shirt. They call it their action squads, and they came to be known as the blackshirts, and they would disrupt the meetings of other political parties when they were having them trash their newspapers in various ways, try to intimidate their political enemies as well.

- 6.18** We have here an image that starts to become a little more prominent. One of the things that is interesting about the image is that it has the star at the top of it. The red star, of course, is what is adopted by the Russian Marxists who have come to power in what is now the Soviet Union. But that same star symbolism is adopted by Mussolini, only the color now is black. And we have in the middle of that a fasces doctrine. We'll come back to that in just a moment.
- 6.19** Time marches on. Mussolini's influence grows, the party grows, the paramilitary action grows. Italy seems riven by various kinds of political conflicts and not able to get its act together. Mussolini embarks on a famous march on Rome, the center of political power in Italy, and a year later, he comes to power. And so he is now the first person in Italy's political structure. His party, now called the Fascist, is the reigning political party in Italy.
- 6.20** Now, the symbol here again, the star has been dropped in later versions, and what we have is the core fasces, as he's called, the fasces symbol. It's adopted from ancient Rome. Part of what the Fascists were interested in was reinvigorating the spirit of Rome, back when before it was Italy, but Italy was great. In the spirit of Rome, we want to revive it in modern times. Roman Empire was great in the ancient world. Can we do the same thing in the modern world, with some imperial ambitions here?
- 6.21** But also this, aside from the warlike part where you have an ax, which is clearly going to be used for damaging things and people, if necessary in a militaristic fashion, the symbol of the individual rods bound together. And the idea here is that individuals, if you take any individual rod, whatever it's made of, it can be bent and manipulated in various ways. But even if you take some very pliable and flexible individual rods, you put them together and you bind them with a simple cord, they become inflexible and unbendable.
- 6.22** And the symbolism here is that Italy is not going to be a nation of individuals who are doing their own thing with their lives, pursuing their goals and happinesses and so on, but rather to be an Italian, and particularly to be an Italian fascist, means you come to be joined with all other Italians and bound together in order to achieve certain purposes. And one of those purposes is going to be represented by the ax.
- 6.23** Now, more philosophically, while Mussolini was a very well-read man, he read everything he could get his hands on. He could quote Marx back and forth, as well as other important political philosophers in history. And he knew his general history and political history as well. He was not primarily an intellectual, but he did in his movement have very strong support from intellectuals, prominent intellectuals, in the scene in Italy at this time.
- 6.24** One of the prominent ones is Alfredo Rocco, who is a professor of law and economics, very well regarded in his field. For much of his career, he was a Marxist, straight-up, true-believing, doctrinaire Marxist. But as with Mussolini, as the century turns, as we

get closer to the Great War, he shifts from doctrinaire Marxism and that version of socialism to what is this new fascism. And then when Mussolini came to power, it was Alfredo Rocco who became the Minister of Justice in the new regime.

- 6.25** A similar story can be said about other intellectuals, but here are a few indicative quotations from Rocco about what fascism means. And this is from a piece that he published in 1925, just two years after Mussolini has come to power, and in a mass-distributed publication written by a leading intellectual, Minister of Justice, what does fascism mean? And the contrast is to liberalism. Liberalism is the most opposite political doctrine to fascism from Rocco's perspective.
- 6.26** "For liberalism, the individual is the end, and society the means." Individuals have their own ends, their goals. The individual is the unit of value and reality, and we form social units in order to help individuals achieve their various ends. "For fascism, society is the end, individuals the means." And its whole life consists in using individuals as instruments for its social ends. You are an instrument as an individual. You are a tool in the service of, to be used by society for its purposes, fascism directly contrasted to liberalism.
- 6.27** Well, what does this usage consist in? "For fascism, society has historical and immanent ends of preservation, expansion, improvement, quite distinct from those of the individuals which at a given moment compose it." So somewhat organic conception of society here. It has its history, it has its goals. It wants, says that organisms do to expand, to grow bigger, to exert its power as much as possible. And those are not necessarily the goals of the individuals.
- 6.28** "Hence the necessity, for which the older doctrines make little allowance of sacrifice, even up to the total immolation of individuals, in behalf of society; hence the true explanation of war." You are to be used, you are a tool, you are an instrument, you are to be sacrificed, if necessary, even totally destroyed, if that advances the purposes of the society of which you are a part. And that includes a fascist embrace of war as a necessary part of one's political expansion.
- 6.29** "It is high time, instead, says Fascism, that the individual be brought back to the vision of his true place in the universe. It is high time that he learns how to curb and master his self. It is high time that his freedom be taken away from him if he is to realize the greatest aim of life, the furtherance of the Spirit." And we'll notice here that the spirit is capitalized, and what that typically indicates rhetorically is not your individual spirit that you are maximizing and making more. There is a big, capital S spirit that is captured in the destiny of the nation. The nation is the embodiment of the spirit. You exist to serve that. You have no freedoms apart from the service to your nation's spirit.
- 6.30** Now in this, we can and should be able to read an Italian adoption of the doctrines of Georg Hegel. If we've read Hegel's Philosophy of Right, as we have to some extent in

this course, you will recognize Hegel's influence is now transplanted not only from Germany, but also to Italy and becomes formerly a part of the Italian fascist program.

- 6.31** Now, another important intellectual to mention here is Gentile, Giovanni, who was another big-name intellectual, very well regarded in intellectual circles, professor of philosophy at the University of Rome. For his entire career, philosophically, he was a Hegelian, deeply Hegelian, writing learned articles and books on Hegelian philosophy and adapting it to the Italian scene. Then in terms of his politics, he sees a natural continuity between the underlying Hegelian philosophy, the Philosophy of Right and so forth, with fascist political philosophy.
- 6.32** And under Mussolini, when Mussolini came to power, Gentile becomes the Minister of Education, charged with shaping the minds of the Italian youth in the new fascist direction. The two of them worked closely together and even published together. Mussolini described Gentile as the philosopher of fascism. He is the one. Read Gentile if you want to understand what fascism is all about. Of course, Gentile is totally on board with this.
- 6.33** They jointly published in 1932, now that the fascists have been in power for almost a decade, a work that they'd been working on together for a while. But it came out, where we have the official political philosophy of fascism. It's not only the politics and the legal structure and the educational material, but also the underlying philosophy that gives rise to this. It was just called *The Doctrine of Fascism*, 1932. What I would like to do as usual is go to the text. We'll look at some of the important passages here to discern what fascism is, according to its founders.
- 6.34** Here is *The Doctrine of Fascism*, co-written by Mussolini and Gentile. It's not clear whether Gentile was the primary author, but because of his stature, Mussolini put his name first. This was a work that was composed in the middle part of the 1920s, tinkered with and published in its final form in 1932. All right, so what is fascism?
- 6.35** Well, "Like all sound political conceptions, fascism is action, and it is thought; action in which doctrine is immanent." Now, the language here is going to be Hegelian. "Doctrine arising from a given system of historical forces in which it is inserted and working on them from within. It has, therefore, a form correlated to contingencies of space and time, but it also has an ideal content which makes it an expression of truth in the higher region of the history of thought."
- 6.36** That's Hegel, as translated by Mussolini and Gentile. Important point, emphasize that this is a philosophy of life that the fascists are by. We're not simply technical politics guys worried about changing policies in this particular direction and so on. We see politics as the extension of a philosophy which involves an entire meaning of life and that the purpose of the state is to realize that philosophical conception of the meaning of life in reality.

- 6.37 "There can be no conception of the state which is not fundamentally a conception of life, philosophy or intuition. System of ideas evolving within the framework of logic or concentrated in a vision or a faith, but always, at least potentially, an organic conception of the world." We don't just want power because we happen to like power. We have a philosophy, we have a meaning of life. We want to make that real. Well, what is this philosophy of life?
- 6.38 "It is a spiritual attitude." The contrast here is, it's not primarily materialistic. "Fascism sees in the world not only these superficial material aspects in which man appears as an individual standing by himself, self-centered, subject to natural law, which instinctively urges him toward a life of selfish momentary pleasure." Pausing there, we might look at individuals and say, well, it seems like there are all of these distinct individuals with their own ideas and aims, embedded in the natural world, and they have bodies and they're subject to gravity. That is a superficial way of looking at individuals.
- 6.39 "It sees not only the individual, but the nation and the country, individuals and generations bound together by a moral law. With common traditions and a mission which, suppressing the instinct for life, closed in a brief circle of pleasure, builds up a higher life, founded on duty, a life free from the limitations of time and space, in which the individual, by self-sacrifice, the renunciation of self-interest, by death itself can achieve that purely spiritual existence in which his value as a man consists."
- 6.40 You are bound to a society, a collective that has a life of its own, and your moral significance is to the extent that you see yourself and act as bound up with the life of your nation, and you are willing to sacrifice not only your materiality, your possessions, your physicality, your body, in order to achieve your spiritual destiny in the spiritual life of your nation.
- 6.41 "This conception is therefore a spiritual one, arising from the general reaction of the century against the materialistic positivism of the 19th century." So in the modern world, of course, we are seeing the rise of physicalisms, materialisms, a scientific, non-religious, non-spiritual understanding of the world. The argument here is that that metaphysics, which had dominated in the development of modern civilization, is faulty. We need to recapture a more spiritual understanding.
- 6.42 "This positive conception of life is obviously an ethical one." We're interested in ethics, and it's going to be an ethics of selflessness, sacrifice, a willingness to die for the sake of one's nation. "Therefore, life as conceived of by the fascist is serious." It's not about fun, it's not about pleasure, pursuit of happiness. "It's serious, austere," not about getting stuff and enjoying stuff and becoming rich and religious, not secular, not atheistic, not materialistic in that way.
- 6.43 "All its manifestations are poised in a world sustained by moral forces and subject to spiritual responsibility. The fascist disdains an easy life. The fascist conception of life is a

religious one, in which man is viewed in his immanent relation to a higher law, endowed with an objective will transcending the individual and raising him to conscious membership of a spiritual society."

- 6.44** Now, Hegelian language, but also language meant to capture the centuries of religious spiritual language, higher law, sacrifice for that which is beyond you, de-emphasizing the physical and the individual in your pursuit of happiness. Be austere, the way a person who is serious in his or her religion devotes himself to others, to higher others, and is willing to sacrifice much individuality to become an obedient servant of higher moral values.
- 6.45** We're trying to capture all of that, which, of course, is a strong tradition in Italy, and marry it to a more modernized Hegelian philosophy in general. "In the fascist conception of history, man is a man only by virtue of the spiritual process to which he contributes as a member of the family, the social group, the nation. Fascism is therefore opposed to all individualistic abstractions." All individualism, we are opposed to that. "Based on 18th-century materialism, and it is opposed to all Jacobinistic utopias and innovations."
- 6.46** Now, here we have a reference to the Jacobins in the third phase of the French Revolution who instituted the Rule of Terror. They were quasi-religious in various ways. They were followers, though, of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and this is an indication that we are opposed to that particular modernistic direction as well. "It does not believe in the possibility of 'happiness' on earth." And notice the word happiness is put in quotation marks, which is always a way of some distance from it or some skepticism about it or some ironic perspective on the word.
- 6.47** Life is not about happiness, the pursuit of happiness on Earth, as conceived by the economic literature of the 18th century. So the idea that we are here to enjoy ourselves, to pursue happiness, to become rich and so forth on Earth, none of that in fascism. "Anti-individualistic, the Fascist conception of life stresses the importance of the state and accepts the individual only insofar as his interests coincide with those of the state, which stands for the conscience and the universal will of man as a historic entity. It is opposed to classical liberalism."
- 6.48** So all of the individualism, morally speaking, all of the liberalism, socially and politically speaking, we are rejecting all of that as well. The individual only has value and meaning to the extent that he or she is serving the state. It is the state that is the true reality. It's the one that has the moral conscience. It's the one that has the will. It is the historic entity.
- 6.49** A famous phrase from Gentile and Mussolini, "Liberalism denied the state in the name of the individual. Fascism reasserts the right of the state as expressing the real essence of the individual. The fascist conception of the state is all-embracing. Outside of it, no human or spiritual values can exist, much less have value. Thus, understood, Fascism is

totalitarian." And this is the original meaning of totalitarian. There is no limit to what the state can and should do with respect to individuals in its country. It is concerned with the totality, with all aspects of life.

- 6.50** And it's not the case that individuals have their own private zones of freedom and uniqueness and value purpose. You have no such things outside of the state. Religion is a state matter. The economy is a state matter. Family structure is a state matter. Your sporting memberships and what you do on your leisure time is a state matter. Everything is for the state. It is total.
- 6.51** "The Fascist state interprets, develops, and potentates the whole life of a people." No individuals or groups outside the state. There are no purely private individuals or private associations or private institutions. Nothing outside the state. Now, Fascism and its relationship to socialism. There are any number of varieties of socialism, and Mussolini is well versed in all of this literature, but he is here going to say, "We are distinct enough to deserve a new label." It's not just going to be socialism with some adjective in front of it. Instead, it is going to be Fascism as our new label.
- 6.52** "Fascism is therefore opposed to socialism, to which unity within the state is unknown and which sees in history nothing but the class struggle." Here, the exemplar of socialism is the Marxist version of socialism, and he is distancing fascism from that version of socialism. The argument there is that the Marxists are very reductionistic. Everything is reduced to material forces, and then even more narrowly, everything is reduced to economic forces. We try to interpret everything about human beings, their religious views, their political structure, their family life, in terms of these underlying economic forces, and then more particularly, their class memberships. So highly reductionistic in that particular way.
- 6.53** And what the fascist now is going to argue is that that is an impoverished understanding of what it is to be a human being. Yes, the economic matters, and the state is going to control the economy as part of its totalitarian agenda. But also, family life and religious life and what people do in their leisure time and all of the other zones of life, those also are a part of the state's concern, but they're not explainable solely in terms of what's going on economically.
- 6.54** In many cases, these are semi-distinct, perhaps overlapping zones of life, and some of them might require different policies in place rather than trying simply to reduce everything to a set of economic policies and have everything follow from that. So Fascism then differentiated from Marx's reductionistic version of socialism.
- 6.55** "Fascism is likewise opposed to trade unionism as a class weapon." So we're not going to try any sort of evolutionary approach to socialism. So the idea here of trade unionism was to say, all right, so we have a large number, say, of workers who are competing for various kinds of jobs, and capitalists are hiring these workers, and they do enter into negotiations. But by and large, the capitalists are richer, and so they have

more economic power. Typically, the workers are poorer. They're more likely to be economically desperate.

6.56 They just want a job, and there's a whole lot more of them. I know if I turn the job down, there's 100 other guys who will take that job. So I'm not going to bargain too hard in order just to get this job. I will just accept whatever terms the capitalist gives me. I'm going to be relatively impotent and impoverished inside the capitalist system as a worker. So maybe what I should do, though, is seek a certain amount of power in numbers. I'm going to join with all of the other workers who are doing the same work that I am doing, and we will unify, we will form a union.

6.57 Rather than trying to bargain with the capitalist one-on-one, which doesn't work out to my benefit very well, we will say, here we are. We're the 500 workers at your factory. We're going to bargain with you as a collective or as a unity. Now we have a whole lot more bargaining power because what we can then do, say, is, well, look, we've got skills, we know the business and so forth. If you don't agree to our terms, you don't give us a raise or whatever it is that we want, then maybe we will all quit.

6.58 The capitalist is going to say, "Oh, my goodness, 500 people quitting on me all at once? That's going to be a nightmare. I'm going to lose productivity. I'm going to have to hire a whole bunch of new people. That's going to take time and expense. Then I have to train all of them and so forth. I am then, as a result, willing to give them a raise or some other condition that they want." So the idea here is that we're still going to be doing freedom of association. We're still working in the capitalist system, and we're going to evolve by negotiation to improve the condition of the workers over time.

6.59 The fascists are saying, no, none of that. That then is to say, workers have their own interests apart from the state. Rather, the workers are part of the state, just as the people who are managing the big businesses are also part of the state. Everything is going to be part of the state, not trade unions with their own set of special interests.

6.60 "But when brought within the orbit of the state, Fascism recognizes the real needs which give rise to socialism and trade unionism." We understand where the trade unionists are coming from, but we are going to reconceptualize how to get what they want, "which give rise to socialism and trade unionism, giving them due weight in the guild or corporative system in which divergent interests are coordinated and harmonized in the unity of the state."

6.61 What is also interesting in this passage here is the introduction of the word guild or corporate system. And corporatism is sometimes another name given for the economic part of the fascist program. And it goes back to the idea of a corpus or a body, that in some sense we should see the economy as an entire body, or the entire state, the entire Italian people, as one body, and all of the different organs within the body have a function serving the overall corpus or the overall body. So a corporatist understanding of society is sometimes the label that is used here.

- 6.62 Now, within that, though, we will then say, well, the different organs have different functions, and so we might need to have different policies and different regulations for each of those different organs to make sure that they're doing their job within the context of the overall corpus. And so the other word that gets introduced here is the word guild, which, of course, takes us back to feudal times, when there was the medieval concept, this is medieval political theory, the idea of society as a whole. And we have all of these different classes in society. But each of those classes has certain functions that serves the overall society as a whole.
- 6.63 So obviously the peasants, their job is to grow the food and make the stuff that the rest of society needs. The job of the clergy is to pray for society as a whole and tend to everyone's spiritual needs. The job of the aristocrats is to train for war, train in the martial skills in order to be able to expand the territory for the glory of our society or to protect us against various other invasions. And of course, there's the king who is to be a wise and moral being, who does the serious thinking and establishing the policies for a whole.
- 6.64 So there's all of these functions that have to be performed in society, and we coordinate all of those into the overall corporate. Each particular function in there can be described as a guild, particularly that language came to be used when talking about the skilled craftsmen and craftspeople in the feudal structure. Each different guild which was performing, we're dealing with the wood, we're dealing with the iron, and we are the blacksmiths. Each of those forms its own guild and has certain privileges granted to it by the overall state so that it can perform its job well. So Mussolini is willing to reincorporate some of this slightly medieval-sounding guild language.
- 6.65 Another opposition. "Fascism is therefore opposed to that form of democracy which equates a nation to the majority, lowering it to the level of the largest number." So what again does democracy mean? And now we have a third conception so far in this series of lectures. One is to say, democracy means a series of individuals who have their own rights and their own pursuits in life, but on matters when they are forming social units, they need to come together, discuss what they want from it. If there are competing policies, we will vote as individuals in this. The majority will get their way for a foreseeable period of time.
- 6.66 We've seen the more pragmatic and progressive understanding of democracy, where we are a whole series of individuals who are part of a nation, but we're trying to find our collective purpose, and educate and reeducate ourselves, so we pursue those collective purposes as well. We're not certainly as fascists going to adopt the first one. That's too individualistic, that's too liberalistic, it's too majoritarian. We might believe that, if we look at the Italian people or any people where we're trying to institute fascism, that the majority of people as individuals don't really know what's best for the society as a whole. So whatever democracy means, it can't mean that.

- 6.67 "But it is the purest form of democracy if the nation is considered, as it should be, from the point of view of quality rather than [quantity]. The people who are the most ethical, the most coherent, the truest, etc., the people are expressing themselves as the conscience and the will of the few, if not indeed of the one."
- 6.68 So what Mussolini is saying here is, it is going to be the best, the few, the most moral, who really are dedicated to the ethical whole, to the life of the nation, and who understand from that big-picture perspective what is needed by the nation, what the destiny of the nation is going to be. And in any fascist political regime at a given time, that might be just a few people. And it might even be just one person who then embodies the Italian state as a whole.
- 6.69 Another distinction introduced here, fascism is not racist; it rather is ethnically focused. Race, as the discussion has gone on, has come in the 1800s and on into the 1900s to mean a biological division between peoples, that people are biologically, we're all humans in general, but that there are different biological substrains of human beings, and that each biology has its own slight differences, even though all are on the same human template.
- 6.70 Fascism is not a materialist doctrine, so it does not see people fundamentally in terms of biological categories, and so race is not an issue for them. Any person of any race can be part of the Italian people, and there's been a lot of mingling in the modern world. People, anybody who is ethnically Italian, part of the Italian people, it is a cultural and spiritual doctrine. Same customs, same habits, same mode of speaking, same general religion and so forth. All of these things that are not biologically driven, that is what we are focusing on.
- 6.71 So it's "not a race nor a geographically defined region, but a people, historically perpetuating itself, a multitude unified by an idea imbued with the will to live, the will to power, self-consciousness, personality." A little side note, the "will to power" phrase is a reference to Friedrich Nietzsche, a German philosopher who had died in 1900. Worth checking out, but to this side here.
- 6.72 Reiterating the theme of the totality. "Therefore, the state is not only Authority," authority with a capital A, "which governs and confers legal form and spiritual value on individual wills, but it is also power, which makes its will felt and respected beyond its own frontiers." All authority and all power in the state. "Fascism, in short, is not only a law-giver and a founder of institutions, but an educator and a promoter of spiritual life." So it will be state-controlled and state-regulated education institutions, all of them state-controlled and state-managed religious institutions, all of them, as we manage all aspects of life.
- 6.73 And therefore, the Lictor's rods, we were discussing earlier, the individual rods, bound together with the ax, that is our symbol. Unity, our authority, and our power in the symbol. A few more. This language that Mussolini and Gentile have, where we have the

guild language, "corporazione", forgive my Italian, the corporatism. "It may be objected that this program implies a return to the guilds." So is it the case that Fascism really is just going back in history, we want to go back to the medieval era, we want to go back to feudalism?

- 6.74** Mussolini is going to say, I'm fine with the language. I'm fine with some of those traditions, but you have to understand those in modern form. It's going to be a totalitarian, anti-individualistic state in the modern world. We're not just going to go back to feudal, agrarian, militaristic fashions. But in terms of foreign policy, we have to be clear. We have said a people is an organism of a sort that has a life, and organisms grow or they die. We can and should expect that, while perhaps now Italy is bounded geographically by certain features, it is not necessarily limited to those geographical boundaries. It can expand as organisms do and as spiritual growth requires in many cases.
- 6.75** So against the increasing emphasis by western liberals, western individualists, western advocates of the capitalist peace thesis, that what we want to do is put war behind us, let people do their own individual thing, be very tolerant, let's just trade with each other and grow rich in our own ways, Fascism is going to reject all of that as well. "Fascism does not, generally speaking, believe in the possibility or utility of perpetual peace." It's not possible and it's not useful. "It therefore discards pacifism as a cloak for cowardly, supine renunciation in contra-distinction to self-sacrifice."
- 6.76** So, shaming language. If you don't want to go to war, especially if you're a man, what does that say about you? You're not a real man. You are a coward. And what is the language that cowards use? They say, "Well, we should be peaceful. War is nasty, war is ugly. Let's all get along with each other and try to be friends." That's not what's really going on. It's a mask for an underlying lack of manliness. So war is part of the human condition and an extension of state policy as it furthers the expansion of the state life.
- 6.77** "It therefore discards pacifism as a cloak for that. War alone keys up all human energies to their maximum tension." We want to be fully alive, fully self-realized. Everything on the line. The claim here is that war is that which does that the best and the most. When you are in war, you are at your human best. "It sets the seal of nobility on those peoples have the courage to face it." Embrace war or die; become a warrior or be labeled a coward.
- 6.78** "After socialism," so we're rejecting certainly Marxist version of socialism, "Fascism trains its gun on the whole block of democratic ideologies." We're not a democracy. "Rejects both their premises and their practical applications." All right. Why are we anti-democratic in that western liberal sense? Here he quotes Renan, another proto-Fascist intellectual.
- 6.79** "Reason and science are the products of mankind, but it is chimerical to seek reason directly for the people and through the people." The people are not capable of reason.

They're not capable of science, and so certainly it should not be their reasoning and their understanding of the true nature of the scientific university that should inform policy.

- 6.80** "The maxim that society exists for the well-being and freedom of the individuals composing it does not seem to be in conformity with nature's plans, which care only for the species and seem ready to sacrifice the individual." An analogy from nature. We are adopting that in our organism life. You exist to serve the state. Along the way, you will be sacrificed. But what is important is that the state carries on, the nation carries on, just as, in this analogy, the biology works at the level of the species, the individuals come in low, it's the life of the species' continuation that is mattering.
- 6.81** War. How are we to understand World War I, that we are still, in the 1920s and the 1930s, reacting to? The war is the fault of liberalism from this perspective. The liberal century, classical liberalism, had its greatness, the latter part of the Enlightenment, carrying on into the 1800s. But nonetheless, "after piling up innumerable Gordian knots, tried to cut them with the sword of the world war. Never has any religion claimed so cruel a sacrifice." So the liberal ideology is being blamed. The only solution is going to be to abandon liberalism.
- 6.82** Again, we can reflect on the French Revolution, as informed political philosophers do in the modern world. "The Fascist negation of socialism, democracy, liberalism, should not, however, be interpreted as implying a desire to drive the world backwards to a position occupied prior to 1789." Now that data is firmly in our memory. That's when the French Revolution began. We're not going back to the old regime, the Ancien Régime.
- 6.83** But nonetheless, all of the modern doctrines of liberalism and democracy and socialism and so forth, that are post-French Revolution, we are rejecting all of those as well. We are going to be totalitarian, etc. We are also going to be somewhat evolutionary. Here there is a pragmatic theme that we can find in the Doctrine of Fascism as well. I'll read the passage here first and then we'll say what it is.
- 6.84** "That is to say, it," it being fascism, "rejects the idea of a doctrine suited to all times and to all people." So whatever we take fascist political philosophy to be, this rough-and-ready set of principles that we have articulated—it's not this, it's not this, it's not that, it's this various other thing—we have to understand, again, that we are not in the pre-modern world of believing in fixed essences, timeless truths, an eternal plan that is set more or less in stone.
- 6.85** The world is evolving. Different circumstances are going to call for different kinds of policies, and we are going to have to be flexible. Maybe it will seem like what we are doing this year contradicts what we did last year. But we aren't concerned primarily with uniform policy and consistency in the application of policy because we are in this new evolving, more pragmatic world as well. "Hence, the pragmatic strain in fascism."

And so, Gentile and Mussolini use exactly the right word here, incorporating some pragmatism, "the pragmatic strain in fascism, its will to power, its will to live, its attitude toward violence, and its value."

- 6.86** All right. One final shot. "If liberalism spells individualism, Fascism spells government." We're anti-individualist, anti-liberal. We are all about the government as conceived here. OK. All right, those are the essential themes, somewhat repetitive but necessary for emphasis in the various variations of the Doctrine of Fascism, its core themes, as well as how it distinguishes itself from all of the other competitor political philosophies of the time.
- 6.87** Another quotation from a different publication came out also in 1932, though, here, again, emphasizing the theme of war. By the time we get to the early 1930s, and now we're going to start looking a little bit to the north, the world is changing. The Depression has occurred, and many are interpreting the Great Depression as the death of capitalism in the West, that we need to have a more organized, top-down society, but also to the north, up in Germany, major political events are occurring, and it's quite clear that the German neighbors to the north are not looking back on World War I, or the Great War, as the be-all-and-end-all, and that we're hoping to put war behind us, that the Germans are looking forward to and ahead and planning for war. Italy needs to poise itself for that as well.
- 6.88** As we have seen before, this important passage, "War alone brings up to its highest tension all human energy, and puts the stamp of nobility upon the peoples who have the courage to meet it." That is taken from the Doctrine of Fascism and republished in this piece as well, a more popular encyclopedia piece that was widely distributed. We need to prepare for war. War brings out the best in you. It brings out the nobility in you. Train yourself and your children for what is to come.
- 6.89** And certainly the mutual awareness of what is going on in fascist Italy. And by the time we get to 1934, what is happening in national socialist Germany. The similarities of many of the doctrines there is on everyone's mind. In 1934, there is a formal meeting between the two heads of state, Adolf Hitler and Benito Mussolini, to share ideas, to share plans, which will include sharing resources for the coming conflicts against the anti-Nazi and anti-Fascist other parts of the world.
- 6.90** Home
- 6.91** Quad
- 6.92** Progress
- 6.93** Messages
- 6.94** Curriculum
- 6.95** More

- 6.96 Search
- 6.97 10
- 6.98 Seek backward
- 6.99 Pause
- 6.100 10
- 6.101 Seek forward
- 6.102 Pause
- 6.103 0:10 / 59:01
- 6.104 Mute
- 6.105 Quality
- 6.106 Playback rate
- 6.107 Captions
- 6.108 Enter fullscreen mode

Lecture 7: A Darker Turn

At a glance — A darker turn — 1933 and the rise of Hitler.

- 7.1 1933, a momentous year in European and, indeed, world history. That's the year that Adolf Hitler and the National Socialists take power in Germany. If we go inside the German context in the 1920s and 1930s, one of the big questions, perhaps the biggest question on the minds of most Germans was, why did Germany lose the Great War?
- 7.2 It was shocking because the expectation was that Germany was a rising industrial nation, a rising scientific nation. It had the best philosophers, perhaps the best musicians and poets, the strongest, most civilized culture. And according to the teachings of many of the intellectuals influenced by Hegel and others, Germany had a destiny, a mission to take the world forward to the next place.
- 7.3 And World War I was seen as a battle of civilizations, a battle of cultures, and the expectations that Germany would and should prevail and take the world where the world needed to win. But Germany lost. This was a devastating physical and psychological blow. How do we explain this?
- 7.4 There are lots of explanations are kicked around. Technology is one; who had better technology, who had better military strategy? All of those things, of course, matter. But there also was a strong sense of betrayal, that Germany should not have lost this war. The only reason why we lost was that the people who were allegedly in charge or who were pulling the levers behind the scenes had betrayed the destiny of Germany. This is one of the themes that the political parties, including the young National Socialist Party in the 1920s, was able to play upon.
- 7.5 What do we do as Germans? Now, one very influential answer was that of Oswald Spengler, who published, right at the end of World War I, a book that was a bombshell book in Germany, quickly translated into multiple languages and became an international sensation, called *The Decline of the West*. And Spengler had an organic understanding of societies and cultures, that societies are organisms, and like all organisms in the rest of nature, they're in conflict with each other.
- 7.6 Some are more predatory, and they fight it out amongst each other, and then they divide up the more prey-like nations among themselves and use them to increase their own life vitality. But like all organisms, there's a life cycle that includes death, and every culture has a natural cycle of youth, ascendancy, power, maturity, and then eventually it slips into decline.
- 7.7 So Spengler's view was that Germany had had its moment, and the losing of the war was a signal that Germany was entering into its decline phase. If we're going to ask what we should do, well, we can't really do very much about this. There's laws of

nature, laws of biology, laws of cultural development. What we should do is, of course, be devastated by the loss, but nonetheless accept it and try to move forward.

7.8 "Every creation is foredoomed to decay," Spengler wrote. "Every thought, every discovery, every deed to oblivion." Now, in part, Spengler is interested in consoling the Germans about their loss and giving an explanation for it, but also philosophically he is opposed to any progressivism that we hear from Western Europe, from the British, from the Americans, that in some sense, progress is possible, that we can make the world increasingly a better and better place. There's a signal here of a kind of pessimism that must be built into any cultural analysis.

7.9 Now, other German thinkers, deep German thinkers, were not so pessimistic. Another famous one who rose to the fore shortly after World War I was Arthur Moeller van den Bruck. He wrote a book with the title that should stand out in our attention, *The Third Reich*. Germany had an ancient Reich, and then the Second Reich that came into existence at the end of the 19th century. After the war, a Weimar Republic that Germany was struggling with in the 1920s. But it's time to reinstitute the Reich, a third Reich. We are now looking forward to what this is going to involve.

7.10 And this is exciting for many Germans. We don't think republicanism, democracy, the Western way of doing things is appropriate. We need to find a way to revitalize Germany, to get it back to the glory days of the Reich. Now, what is the answer, though, to the question about World War I and why we lost it? Partly, it was a technology issue, partly it's a military strategy, but it's a broader philosophical battle that Moeller van den Bruck and Spengler and the others see Germany as engaged in. It is a cultural battle, and most deeply, a philosophical battle.

7.11 That in the West, in Britain, France to a certain extent, and certainly over in America, the liberal ideals have come to ascendancy and are dominant. They are democratic, they are republican, they are free market capitalists, they are full of themselves, and they want to make the world entirely liberal in their image.

7.12 But that is not what Germany stands for. The main lines of tradition coming out of Germany do not prioritize the individual or freedom. They prioritize the collective and one's duty and obligation to the collective, to the social. It is socialism. And what Germany needs to do, in creating the new Reich, the third Reich, hopefully, is realize that the socialists have lost the war against the liberals, but find a way to make socialism strong again.

7.13 But it's also more complicated than that because socialism comes in many varieties, and this version of socialism is going to be clear that it is not a Marxist version of socialism. We're not talking about communism. That's the wrong kind of socialism. What we want is a socialism that is a German-based socialism. We see this in both the Third Reich, where Moeller van den Bruck calls for German socialism.

- 7.14** It is socialism pitched at the national level. The German people are a nation. They are a collective. They are a community with their own organic destiny. That is what we are striving for, to revitalize that with a broadly socialistic political economy. Interestingly, also, after *The Decline of the West*, Oswald Spengler came out with another book called *Prussianism and Socialism*, in 1920. Again, a big bestseller in Germany, where he's arguing less pessimistically that, yes, Germany needs socialism. But what kind of socialism?
- 7.15** And again, he argues against the Marxist version of socialism and said what we need is a Prussian kind of socialism. Prior to the unification of Germany into a nation in the 1800s, Germany had been a bunch of different states and so forth. They were all unified. Prussia in the north and the east part of Germany was the dominant, most powerful part of Germany, and many of its leaders and much of its political power came from Prussia. The Prussian model of doing things is seen as the heart and soul of the Germanic way of doing things.
- 7.16** In effect, what we have then is a kind of German socialism, but it's going to be a national German socialism, and that's what we are striving for. The point is that this is being worked out philosophically right after World War I by leading intellectuals in Germany, long before Hitler and the others come to power a decade later.
- 7.17** Now, in one sense, this is a difficult thing for us to wrap our minds around because, with our after-the-fact knowledge about how horrible World War II was with the Holocaust coming out of it and the millions of people dead and so forth, and the images we see of Hitler and Goebbels and various other leaders, in some sense, they seem a little bit crazy. And what they're so willing to do with the mass killings of so many people is hard for anybody to take seriously. They must be crazy. They must be irrational.
- 7.18** And that is in part what I want to caution against in this lecture by pointing out that when we talk about revolutions, ones that go very well or ones that go very badly, in the modern world, every major revolution has a strong network of intellectuals and philosophers behind it who have laid the groundwork for it in the preceding generations. And the political manifestations are just that. They are a manifestation of deeply held philosophies of life that are then applied to culture, applied to politics.
- 7.19** We're familiar, when we do our history and we're trying to explain the American Revolution, to go back to John Locke and other intellectuals a century before. When we study the French Revolution, as we have seen, we say it went terribly bad when the Jacobins came to power. Then we go back and we realize that all of the Jacobins were true believers in and strong disciples of the philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau. When we study the communist revolutions in Russia, later in China and so forth, we realize that they are basing themselves explicitly on the works of a philosopher, Karl Marx, PhD in philosophy.

- 7.20** Later, in the next series of this course, we will be looking at the Islamic Revolution in Iran and what activities in the Middle East. We'll see an Egyptian philosopher, Sayyid Qutb, as laying the groundwork for that particular ideology as it plays out. In this case, let's turn more explicitly to the intellectuals who, before Hitler and the National Socialists came to power, were strong supporters of Nazism, and they supported it because they thought it was a philosophy of life that was true, that was noble, that was beautiful. And they then used their formidable intellectual powers to support it, thereby creating a culture for widespread acceptance of the doctrine.
- 7.21** So in the 1920s, even, we find there are, outside of the humanities, for example, two Nobel Prize winners in physics, giant brains who are strong supporters of the National Socialist program, Lenard and Stark. Another Nobel Prize winner, Gerhart Hauptmann, in literature, and a poet, very strong supporter of Hitler and the National Socialists to the point where he was like a fan boy the one time he actually met Hitler and was so excited that he got to shake the great man's hand. And he said, "That was the greatest moment of my life." And these are intellectuals of the stature of Nobel Prize-winning, world-recognized intellectuals.
- 7.22** When we go more specifically into philosophy, philosophy of law, philosophy of history, epistemological philosophy, and so forth, many of the leading philosophers of the generation leading up to Hitler and the National Socialists, here's a long list of them. Again, deeply read individuals, professors at prestigious universities, PhDs in their respective disciplines, writing books that are read and quoted and discussed by other leading intellectuals in journals, all of them supporting the National Socialist ideology.
- 7.23** In my estimation, the most important philosopher to discuss is Dr. Martin Heidegger. Already by the time we get into the 1920s, Heidegger is recognized in German intellectual circles, and specifically German philosophical circles, as the leading philosopher of his generation. And somewhat anachronistically, now we can say we are a century later, but when philosophers of our time look back on the 20th century and say, "Who are the most important philosophers of the last century?", everybody, whether they agree with him or not, hate him or not, will say, Heidegger has to be in your top five or your top three. And of course, there are a number of Heideggerian scholars who will say, Heidegger is number one.
- 7.24** A brilliant man, original in his philosophical thinking, and from our perspective and relevant to this course here, a strong supporter of National Socialism and Hitler in particular. I want to focus on Heidegger for some time now and see how the leading intellectual of Germany in the 1920s is processing the loss in the Great War, where Germany stands in the 1920s, what it should be doing in the 1930s, and from the intellectual side, how all of this feeds into, on the practical side, what Hitler and the National Socialists, when they come to power, are doing.
- 7.25** So if we ask the question, why did Germany lose the Great War? And again, we can go through betrayal and technology and strategy and various other things like that,

Heidegger says the answer is philosophy. World War I, as he comes to call it, the First World War, strikingly, was a clash of philosophies. The philosophies that have been developed in Germany, specifically, Hegelianism and the nationalism, various kinds of socialism, most explicitly in the case of Marxism. That strong sense of belonging to the collective that is an organic unity, that has a mission and that one's job is to subordinate oneself to that collective and serve it and be even willing to sacrifice for that higher collective.

- 7.26** All of that that had been worked out over the course of the 1800s on into the early 1900s, primarily by German philosophers, was in collision, certainly philosophically, with the kinds of philosophies that had been worked out first and foremost in Britain, and then transplanted to America, transplanted to some extent to France. And those philosophies are essentially individualistic, your life, your liberty, your pursuit of happiness. They are freedom-oriented, freedom of your conscience, freedom to date whom you want, form your own family, go into business as you like, pursue various scientific pursuits and so forth.
- 7.27** So that then is to say that they are liberal in a broad sense. And of course, there's lots of subversions of liberalism that are being debated by the Western thinkers, and some of those liberals are influential on a minority of German thinkers. There is a lot of crossover, of course. But in broad strokes, we have an individualistic, liberal, progressive Enlightenment approach to philosophy, and we have a collectivistic, duty-oriented, more authoritarian approach to philosophy, all worked out.
- 7.28** They create different cultures with different understandings of what the meaning of life is. When those philosophies and those cultures are so different from each other, they start to collide, certainly in a globalizing society, such as we have in the 1800s and early 1900s. And all of those conflicts become unmanageable until it all breaks out in war. This is Heidegger's explanation. It's a long-form argument explanation.
- 7.29** Now, a little bit about Martin Heidegger himself. Born in toward the end of the 1800s, born into a very conservative family politically. This is conservative in the German 1800s concept, and also strongly religious Catholic family, to the point which, as a young man, when he finished high school and was going on, he had decided he wanted to become a priest, and so enrolled in a seminary for further study. While there, he's reading deeply in history of religion, philosophy of religion.
- 7.30** At the same time, he's interested in more secular philosophies, and he experiences a crisis of faith, and he realizes that he cannot become a priest anymore, and so he switches out of seminary into studying theology, not necessarily as a true believer, and then becomes much more philosophical. World War I strikes when he is a young man shortly after having graduated from high school and from university. World War I passes. He becomes a young professor for several years. He's working on his great masterpiece, not publishing a great deal.

- 7.31** But in 1927, he publishes a book called *Being and Time*, *Sein und Zeit*. It is almost instantly recognized by his peers in the philosophy profession as a masterpiece. And great deal of discussion about this work. And Heidegger then is becoming invited to give talks at important conferences and being considered for more prestigious philosophy chairs in Germany.
- 7.32** A slight side note for this lecture, something worth pursuing outside, though, is that Hannah Arendt, one of the great political philosophers of the 20th century, was for some years a student of Martin Heidegger, and off again and on again, a lover of Martin Heidegger. So they had a fraught relationship in the 1920s, one that became even more fraught in part because she was Jewish and part and parcel of the National Socialist program is a deep loathing of Jewish people, but nonetheless, they had a relationship that was in part philosophical, in part mentorship, in part romantic and erotic. And it continued across several decades, even though they were in different parts of the world at that time. But a very fascinating substory to be explored outside of this course.
- 7.33** By the time, though, we get to 1933, Martin Heidegger is the leading philosopher in Germany, and Germany is the leading philosophical nation in the world, such that graduate students from all over the world, America, Britain, Australia, who want to get first-rate philosophical education, they are seeking out where in their judgment one goes to get the best philosophical education, and significant numbers of them are going to Germany to study at German universities before returning to their home countries.
- 7.34** 1933, though, Heidegger is not merely a philosopher, Hitler and the Nazis have come to political power. Martin Heidegger joins the Nazi Party. He becomes the rector, which is to say the headman at his university, and starts attending conferences that are partly educational, partly political. Heidegger seated among a large number of other intellectuals and activists and members of the military and the government about what we are going to do with respect to education and higher education now that we, National Socialists, have come to power.
- 7.35** Now, what I want to do next, though, is, having surveyed this early part, is to go into the text and see what Heidegger is writing because he is a writer. That's what professors do. He's writing texts that are carefully crafted and giving speeches that are carefully directed rhetorically toward people. We now have the very abstract philosopher, having written about metaphysics and epistemology and the ultimate meaning of life, stepping forth more explicitly onto the public stage to bring the high theory, the philosophy, into practice and to exert some cultural influence, especially on education.
- 7.36** Let's plunge in and be Heideggerian philosophers for some time. It's from a book Heidegger wrote called *Introduction to Metaphysics*. After he had written *Being and Time*, which is a huge, deep, dense book, he's following up some years later with a more introductory explanation of the themes that are explored in that work. What is the fundamental question of metaphysics? When we do metaphysics, we are studying

nature, we are studying the world; that's from the ancient Greek word "physis", from which we get physics, which is the study of the natural world.

7.37 But we try to step back and have a perspective on the whole, everything. That's called taking the meta-move. We're not doing any particular branch of physics or application of it, but the whole thing. What can we say metaphysically about all of reality? Is there a God or not? Is the world eternal? Is it not? Is it strictly causal or are there randomness events that occur as well? All of these are questions about reality as a whole. So what is the most fundamental question?

7.38 And Heidegger puts it this way. "Why are there beings at all, instead of nothing?" We might say there are all of these things that exist and we're going to study them and try to figure out what they are. We say these are physical processes and biological process and maybe cultural processes and so on. There's this being and this being and this being. We have all of these investigations, and some of them are sciences about all of them. But then we step back and we say, are there things that are true about all beings? That's a metaphysical question.

7.39 But behind that, why is there any being at all? Why instead isn't there just nothing? And Heidegger almost argues, this is the most fundamental question to ask, because you have to know why things exist before you can explain why they exist in the particular way that they do and the particular processes that are going on. But he also says this is a deeply perplexing question. Because any way we try to answer this question seems to lead us directly into paradoxes.

7.40 So if I say, well, there's no reason why beings exist. And it's like we're just giving up right from the beginning. If things just exist and there's no reason for them, well, aren't philosophers supposed to be reasoning about everything? It's like saying we're going to start by giving up. On the other hand, if we say, no, there is a reason why everything exists, then we say, first there was, and I'm not going to say anything, and then being came into existence. But if being is everything that exists, where did it come from? When did it come from?

7.41 If we say, well, if being is everything that exists, the opposite of that is non-being, the absence of being, or nothing. Then it sounds like, rationally, we'd be trying to say, first there was nothing, and then out of that, nothing came into existence, being. But then does that even make sense? To say that if you got a whole bunch of nothing, then you can make something out of it or something is going to come? No, if you've got nothing, nothing is going to come from it.

7.42 So Heidegger explores this question with lots of variations and tries playing around with the meanings of words. What if we interpret it this way and interpret it that way? And comes to the conclusion that this is a deeply perplexing question. But at the same time, we as human beings can't escape the grip of this question to the extent that we are thoughtful beings.

- 7.43 Because we think about our own being. I am a human being, and I'm trying to live my life as a human being, and I need to figure out what that means. But then to the extent that I start thinking about my human being, I start to realize the various limitations. Maybe, since I was fortunate to be born in the late 20th century, I'm going to live 80 or 90 years, or maybe even 100 years if I get really lucky. But to the extent that I've scaled out and I'm thinking metaphysically about all of reality, I start to realize that one century, supposing I get that long, how much time is that? It's insignificant, in the grand sweep of things.
- 7.44 "And what is a human lifespan amid millions of years? Barely a move of the second hand, a breath. With beings as a whole, there is no justification to be found in emphasizing precisely this being that is called the human being and among which we ourselves happen to belong." So if I am attracted to philosophy because I want to figure out, say, what the meaning of life is, I want to figure out what the meaning of my life is.
- 7.45 But what is the meaning of my life as an individual among millions and billions of other individuals, including trillions of other organisms on one particular planet that we know is part of a huge galaxy that's just one of however many hundreds of billions or trillions of other galaxies, and that I'm going to exist for this amount of time, and the whole of being is going to exist, perhaps eternally, perhaps we don't know? It seems to make my existence as an individual insignificant and meaningless. So how am I going to find some meaning?
- 7.46 The answer is going to be that it can't be in the terms of an individual life. You need to see yourself as part of something larger, something more permanent than just your 100-year lifespan. "In asking the question, we stand within a tradition." And so I need to embed my thinking, my values, my being, in the tradition that I happen to find myself a part of. It, if anything, is going to have an answer to the question of meaning.
- 7.47 Now, he explores this at great length, and we want to get to the political manifestations. One of the things he is saying about why philosophy matters to explaining things like the Great war is that Germany alone seems to be a philosophical nation. Its philosophers, its thinkers alone, are asking these kinds of questions and willing to take their thinking and their cultural development in the direction their thinking takes.
- 7.48 If we look from the German perspective at the rest of the world, philosophically, Heidegger is going to argue that the rest of the world is unphilosophical. Either out of cowardice, they have decided they're not going to follow this road of questioning, or they have let themselves be distracted by the minutiae of day-to-day life, the here and now, and they are focused on piling up goodies and thinking day-to-day, moment to moment, and not at all thinking about the big picture.
- 7.49 "This Europe," outside of Germany, "in its unholy blindness, always on the point of cutting its own throat, lies today in the great pincers between Russia on the one side

and America on the other." So we might say, just taking a geopolitical stance now, or a geo-cultural stance now, we are Germany-centered here. We go to the east, and it happens to be that one of the great nations of the time is Russia, now the Soviet Union. And then we go to the west, the great nation now is America. And so we are between these two systems.

- 7.50** But from our perspective, what is Russia? Well, it is Marxist. It is atheistic. It has eschewed any sense of spirituality or religious meaning or ultimate destiny in its life. It is about technology. It is about materialism. It is about the here and now and trying to transform the world in a frenzied fashion to try to catch up with the West.
- 7.51** If we go to the West, America, again, from this German perspective, what is the West all about? It's about money. It's about capitalism. It's about going to work and working hard and having lots of drinks on the weekend and partying and a good sex life. It's very materialistic and very hedonistic. And nothing particularly spiritual, mystical, or religious about it as well. So they are kinds of philosophies, we might say, but not very significant philosophies. Germany alone seems to be the place where serious philosophy is being done.
- 7.52** "Russia and America, seen metaphysically, are both the same." Or they might say, oh, no, we are liberals and they are communists, and we don't like each other. We're the opposite. But Heidegger said no, they're the same. "The same hopeless frenzy of unchanged technology and of the rootless organization of the average man. Both of them, in the farthest corner of the globe, are trying to conquer it technologically and try to exploit it economically. The spiritual decline of the Earth has progressed so far that peoples are in danger of losing their last spiritual strength, the strength that makes it possible even to see the decline and to appraise it as such."
- 7.53** So we need to find a way to, as Germans, grasp that spiritual essence, the potential spiritual significance, for me as an individual that is rooted in the tradition of the German nation and revive it. "We lie in the pincers. Our people, standing in the center," we are now the center of the world, not just physically, but metaphysically, "suffers the most intense pressure from both sides. Our people, the people richest in neighbors, and hence the most endangered people, and for all that, the metaphysical people." We are the metaphysical people with that ultimate destiny.
- 7.54** "All this implies that this people, as a historic people, must transpose itself, and with it, the history of the West." The entire history of the West, now rests on our shoulders as Germans. In America, then once again, in Russia, it's all intensified back and forth. It's an onslaught. They're fighting each other, and we are in the middle. I just want to highlight one more concept here. It is a "demonic" battle that we are in the midst of.
- 7.55** Now, Heidegger is not an especially religious man, at least not in any traditional sense at this point, but nonetheless, he is using this religiously charged language to say that we are in a spiritual battle between two essentially hedonistic, materialistic doctrines

on one side of the other of us. And in effect, they have sold out to the bad demons, spiritually. And we are a representative of anything that is possible and/or hopeful. This is the fate of Europe, and with it, the rest of the world.

7.56 I want to quickly now to move to an even more applied doctrine. This Introduction to Metaphysics book was still written for intellectuals, and it was meant to be an introduction to his broader philosophical frame. But the year before he published that book, he had attended his 25th-year reunion of his high school at Konstanz. And it's interesting because most of his fellow graduates had seen experience in the Great War. Indeed, they had graduated from high school shortly before World War I broke out. So it was the significant and, in some cases, decisive event of their lives.

7.57 And now, 25 years later, we are men in our middle years and we have survived and we have become where we are going to be, for the most part, professionally, in our lives. Some of us have gone into education, some into law, some into various other professions and business and walks of life and so forth. But we have come together at this high school reunion, and Heidegger, because of his stature, is invited to give, so to speak, a keynote speech at this meeting of his graduates. I want to highlight some of the important themes that he sends here.

7.58 "Dear classmates, our reunion after 25 years and more and so forth, what do we need to do first? Our first communal action must yet remain the thought of our fallen comrades." This is a decent thing to do. All of our classmates who are now dead as a result of the war, let's give a moment of thought to them. But it's a moment that's going to turn into a long speech in Heidegger's estimation. "How should we think and feel about our fallen comrades?" These other young men whom we knew and played sports with and engaged in pranks and studied with and probably chased girls and so forth? They died and we lived.

7.59 Survivor guilt is a real phenomenon. And one of the themes Heidegger explores here is, should we feel guilty that we survived and they did not? They died for their country. Is there anything better or nobler, according to our moral traditions, than dying for your country? They did it. And we got lucky. Maybe we were a little bit cowardly in hiding and not seeking the opportunities. Should we feel guilty?

7.60 But also we have to think about death. They are dead. What does it mean to be dead? Is it just a nothingness? Does it have greater significance? "Each human being dies his own death." But your death is not merely an individual act, he goes on to argue. "The representation of death and the relationship to it is, for the individual human being, for groups of human beings, and even for an entire nation, always the measure of its currently dominant conception of life."

7.61 How do we think about death? What kind of death do we want to have? What kind of death does our nation need from us? "Our comrades died an early death, but this early death was the most beautiful and greatest death—the greatest death because it could

become the highest sacrifice for the destiny of the nation; the most beautiful death because they died this death not in the ebb," that is to say, not when they were old, and most of their life is gone, but rather when they were young, "was a lavish self-expenditure out of the still undiminished fullness of youth's life force."

- 7.62 They made it a sacrifice, and they made the greatest sacrifice that is possible. Our moral tradition says sacrifice is a great moral achievement. Now, in part, we are then celebrating the death of these young men, but we are looking to the future as well. If we are going to revive Germany and take it in the right direction, what are we going to be asking now? Not of ourselves, because we are now middle-aged guys and perhaps a little bit older, but of our sons and the rest of the German nation, if we are going to realize our historical destiny?
- 7.63 "For the Great War comes over us now for the first time, our awakening to the two million dead in all those endless graves—which the borders of the Reich and German Austria wear like some mysterious crown—only now begins. The Great War becomes today for us Germans, and for us first and foremost of all peoples"—we are now first and foremost of all peoples; Germans are special—"the historical actuality of our existence for the first time." Now we have enough distance on the Great War to see its true historical, cultural, and philosophical significance. We have the right perspective, and of course, I, as the philosopher, am telling you what this is.
- 7.64 Here's a very striking passage in this reunion speech. "But the actuality of this gigantic event that we call the First World War." What is significant now about calling the Great War not the Great War, but calling it the First World War, is to put it in a sequence. This is 1935. There has not yet been a Second World War or the Second World War. But what Heidegger is signaling is, there will be. That was the first one. We lost the battle. But the bigger war, the philosophical war, is not yet over.
- 7.65 We need to see the significance of this first war in the context of lessons we need to learn so that we are ready for the next, the second, which now in hindsight, we know is not to begin for another series of years. "The War," the capitalized war, this is the Great War, "in its immediate conclusion, has indeed still not produced any decision," it's not over, "neither for the winners nor for the defeated. The mere result of the war is certainly not the decision. Yet, this yet stands ahead of us. It is a spiritual matter that concerns the entire Earth."
- 7.66 "The question to be decided is, which nation possesses the inner strength to grow towards the great test that now for the first time has emerged and become manifest? It is the question to the nations about the originality of their national arrangements." And the originality of your national arrangements, that's your philosophy. That's your conception of the meaning of life. What is everything that we do, our cultural framework, our legal framework, set up to encourage and discourage individuals to do? That's your original.

- 7.67 "About the rank and legitimacy of their political will to lead, about the cohesion of their spiritual world, about the health of their national force, about their strength to withstand this historical disaster." Yes, the Great War was a historical disaster for us. Can we pass that test, rise up from the ashes, so to speak, rekindle our inner spirit, and fight again?
- 7.68 Now, National Socialism. This is a year after Hitler and the National Socialists have come to power. "When we try to understand the meaning of the new German reality," that is to say, the new political regime, "then we must say, the new movement, which now courses through this nation, is the deepest and widest concern of our nation's freedom." And there's a big political concept, freedom. What do we mean, though, by freedom in this philosophical context?
- 7.69 "For us, freedom does not mean the unchecked license of actions and conduct." That's the Western liberal individualistic understanding of freedom. You can do whatever you want with your life. No. "Rather, adhesion to the innermost law and the institutions of our essence." Our nation has an essence, and its essence is its core beliefs and its commitment to those beliefs that have been worked out by the deepest thinkers and the deepest activists in our tradition.
- 7.70 To be a free German means you are adhering to that, committed to that. You make your free—I'm just doing a gesture here— commitment, engagement, with that tradition. That's what true freedom means. "Freedom means the gathering of each power that confirms the nation in its historical and spiritual position. Freedom means the awakening and commitment of the will of the nation to its own innermost mission," the mission of the German nation.
- 7.71 And then, labeling, "That is the authentic sense of German socialism." We are advocating German socialism, or National Socialism, and our nation happens to be the German nation. So it is a socialism in the sense that we are part of a culture, part of a society, part of a collective that has its own being, its own values, its own mission, its own destiny. It adheres and hangs together in terms of its Germanness, our distinct ethnicity, with all of its philosophy and ideas and religion and language and culture and the rest.
- 7.72 "German Socialism is the battle over the measure and laws of our nation's essence-oriented institution. German Socialism wants an order of merit based on inner confirmation and achievement. It wants the inviolability of service and the absolute honor of all labor." You are a servant of the nation. You work for the good of the nation; and to the extent that you have any merit at all, your merit will be measured in terms of how much you serve, how much you work, not for yourself, but for the good of the nation.
- 7.73 This requires a lot of work. Now, we middle-aged men at the height of our professions, the head of various families, "The liberation that leads to this freedom demands a

complete reconstitution of the entire structure of the nation, its groups, occupations, classes, and every individual." In effect, we are internal revolutionaries. We are going to transform everything in the light of German socialism, National Socialism, with, of course, the Führer as our leader.

7.74 This requires quite a few things, of course. "The first is the overcoming of the whole bourgeois essence." I want to pause here with respect to the language. Bourgeois is most familiar to us coming out of the Marxist philosophical tradition. Marx had divided all of humanity into two great classes, the classes that own property and thereby control the economy and all of society, and those who do not own property. The names that Marx gave to those two groups were the bourgeoisie and the proletariat.

7.75 So what in part we are doing, and this is part of the socialist inheritance, is saying, the kind of mentality and lifestyle that the bourgeoisie represent—we own property, we have some investments, I am the manager or I'm the entrepreneur or I am the executive officer of some organization—all that way of thinking needs to be exploded and reconstituted. You do not think as a German socialist that way. That is a Western liberal capitalist way of thinking about the world. And you enjoy your material comforts and your nice home and vacations to the beach and so forth. That is not the right kind of lifestyle. The whole bourgeois essence needs to be exploded and reconstituted.

7.76 "The second precondition for the future reeducation of the nation is," and the concept of education, the universities need to be remade. Now, it doesn't say it here, but this does mean, for example, getting rid of all of the Jews, and Heidegger did his part to get rid of all of the Jewish professors that he could, not allowing Jewish students entry. But then also various professors who believe the wrong sorts of things. They're too liberal in their thinking or they're too communist in their thinking. We need to have professors who are on board with the correct program.

7.77 This is also going to extend to lower education right from the very beginning, the kindergartens, primary school, all the way up through high school. It will be a total reeducation. "But it will be a destruction of that strange unreal world of illusion in which we moved about before the war and which flared up again, once again, rather, after the War and degenerated into lawlessness, that characteristic mishmash of phony humanism," to the extent that we were humanistic, that we believed that human beings, each individual has worth, intrinsic worth, of himself and so should be free and self-governing. We're setting up social institutions to allow humans individually to reach their potential.

7.78 That entire philosophy, also Enlightenment liberalism in its various manifestations, also needs to be gotten rid of. That's a phony humanism. Your real humanity is not that kind of individual. Your real humanity is part of the nation which has its own destiny. "We stand before the gigantic assignment." So I'm giving you a task. This is your assignment now, people, "to apply the transformative power of the Great War." Don't give up. Don't leave it behind. Don't enter into defeatism.

- 7.79 Don't say, "I got through. Now I'm middle-aged. I've got a pretty nice family and pretty nice job. I can relax and coast through my life." You have work to do. We have work to do on behalf of the nation. "Our generation is the passage and the bridge. The Great War must now be spiritually won by us." And the spiritual victory is first going to be when you have been knocked down and defeated and you are feeling depressed, to marshal your inner spiritual forces, to get up again, and to prepare to fight again.
- 7.80 And he then, in closing, quotes the great pre-Socratic philosopher, as I say, a philosopher before Socrates, Heraclitus, "Battle is the father of all things," and sometimes that is translated as war is the father of all things. It's by embracing war and seeing all of reality as a great conflict of war, being willing to recognize that as a reality, not to shrink from it, and to embrace and do your part in that.
- 7.81 "Battle is the producer of all things, but of all things, also the ruler. Indeed, it makes some manifest as gods." Do you want to be a god? "The others as men, some it gives forth as slaves, the other as masters." This is our call. This is our destiny. All right, this is a striking speech. Mid-1930s, a year after Hitler and the National Socialists have come to power, when the greatest philosopher in Germany stands forth and issues this speech, of course, at his reunion, but it is meant to be published for wider distribution.
- 7.82 This, of course, is part of the lectures that he is giving and encouraging other professors to sign on. He's laying out the manifesto for the near German future. In conclusion on this, this is Heidegger's reunion speech of 1934. Here's an image of the cover when it was published, soon after having been done so. This is, of course, in one sense, prescient from his inside perspective, Heidegger, as a member of the National Socialist party, conferring with all of the other intellectuals and some of the political leadership itself. He knows what Germany's longer term plans are.
- 7.83 And as we now know from human history, by the time things came to 1939, five years later, World War II breaks out. There have been any number of skirmishes as Hitler and the Germans were trying to test their muscle, so to speak, on the international stage. Can we grab this little chunk of land? Will the western liberals object? No. Then we'll grab this other little chunk of land. September 1st, 1939, though, they invade Poland, and there's a series of treaties in place, but also the western liberals have had enough with respect to the provocations, and they declare war formally against Germany, and World War II is underway.
- 7.84 It's a passage I quoted some lectures ago, and I want to return to it now that we are into World War II. One of the great battles of World War II happened in Russia, which was then the Soviet Union, at a place called Stalingrad. In one sense, this was a great shock, that this front of the war had occurred because, as of 1939, Nazi Germany and communist Russia had an agreement, an alliance, a non-aggression pact.
- 7.85 Hitler and the Germans knew what they wanted to do in Europe. Stalin is running the Soviet Union. He knows what he wants to accomplish from further east, with respect to

the Eastern European nations and looking even further east to China and Japan. They recognize that they both hate the western liberals, and nonetheless, they don't want to be fighting against each other. So they sign what is called a non-aggression pact. They sign it secretly.

- 7.86** And part of the non-aggression pact is that they agree that when Germany decides to invade Poland, its nearest neighbor to the east, the Russians will join in and they will also attack Poland from the east, the Germans from the west, and they will more or less divide Poland between the two of them. September 1st, 1939, the Germans do invade Poland. Still, the Soviet Union is engaged in some actions in the Far East; they're wrapping up a smaller war with the Japanese, and there's some tensions with respect to the Chinese.
- 7.87** That gets wrapped up, and then they're able to deploy and redeploy their troops to the other side of the huge country. And they, a couple of weeks later, also attack Poland and end up dividing the country between the two of them. But then shortly thereafter, Hitler and the Germans have been very successful at coming to control most of Western Europe, all the way up to Norway, all the way down to France. And they have a formal alliance with Mussolini and the Italians.
- 7.88** Europe seems to be then, with the exception of Britain, the English Channel still is a formidable obstacle. But Germany is confident and Hitler breaks the non-aggression agreement, reorients significant number of his troops eastward, and attacks Russia. And now Russia and Germany are fighting each other. But this is now a battle between two ideologies, because we know the National Socialists are explicitly philosophical and ideological in their orientation, as we've heard in Heidegger and all the traditions that he is absorbing.
- 7.89** And we know that the Soviet Union is explicitly ideological and philosophical, trying to take the doctrines of Karl Marx and remake the Soviet Union on the basis of them. When these two great armies meet and they come into collision and the Russians decide to make a stand at Stalingrad, it is, of course, a significant point in terms of military strategy, but both sides also see it as a philosophical moment. It is our German National Socialist way of life in collision with our Russian Soviet Marxist way of life. And neither one of us wants to give.
- 7.90** The 20th-century philosopher Richard Rorty did put it this way. "It was the Right Hegelians against the Left Hegelians." That is to say, the Hegelians who were taking Hegel most seriously on the one side, and then the Hegelians who had recast Hegel in a Marxist direction on the other side. Philosophy in collision in war.
- 7.91** Heidegger, after the war, lost his professor position. He was not prosecuted very seriously, but he was mostly shunted off to the side. He never once, for the whole rest of his life—died in 1976, it's more than 30 years after the war—said he was sorry about

what the Germans had done, anything about the Holocaust, changed his positions. He remained mostly silent on all of those issues.

7.92 He did give one interview shortly before his death with a famous German magazine. The thing that comes most strongly through is just a sense of regret that we had had our chance, we Germans, we, the most philosophical nation, and we failed again. There is no hope. And the phrase he uses, "Only a god can save us."